Green Is The New Red

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Explicit

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Graphic Depictions Of Violence, Major Character Death, Rape/Non-Con

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by B_Dazzled

Summary

Entrapta finds herself on Primes ship at the end of season 4. The Emperor quickly takes a liking to her.

Is this a nice fic where nice things happen after season 4?

Nooo..... sorry.

Will it have a happy ending?

Yes. Sort of.

Notes

Oops. All angst.

See the end of the work for more notes

Violet

She loved him.

Prime could see it in her eyes, in her tears. She loved a defect, an imperfection. The crystal she held in her hand could slot into the chest piece of his clone like a missing puzzle piece. His missing piece. The beating heart of their relationship.

LUVD.

From his throne, he smiled politely down at the pigtailed princess, chin resting comfortably against his knuckles.

"So *you* are Princess Entrapta."

He noticed the ends of her twin hair tails twitch at the gentle boom of his voice. Fear. Good. It was as important to him as adoration. Perhaps more so. Fear worked faster.

But love lasted longer.

One of his eyes studied her body, the curves of her form. Soft, supple. Absolutely delicious. Her thick stomach and heavy chest were so unlike majority of the wives in his harem. She dressed like a commoner though and her appearance was unrefined.

Still, with a little bit of care she could be... *perfect*.

"I'm here for my Lab Partner." He voice was flat, but dangerous. Prime felt a stirring in his body. Excitement.

"Lab partner?" He asked coyly, "I'm afraid I don't know where you might find one."

"Hordak," she snarled, "His name is *Hordak*!"

An eye swept over her impossibly long tendrils of prehensile hair, studying its movement, the way it swayed and bounced and twitched, fluffing up when she yelled. His smile widened to a playful grin.

"Hordak?" He glanced to the blank faced clone next to his throne. "Do you know a Hordak?"

The clone turned his bright green eyes to his genetic template, then shook his pale head.

"What about you, little brother?"

He watched the Princess follow the gaze of all four eyes to the the back of the throne room. Her own eyes went wide. There he stood now, the abomination, made perfect again. Or at least close enough. There were still small imperfections, little reminders of his former life before his reconditioning. Hints if blue in his hair, fading rapidly to white.

It didn't matter. The clone looked back at him with his green eyes, so full of trust, so full of love, adoration, loyalty. All for him. He didn't even once glance at the Princess as he shook his head.

"Hordak!" She called for him, running from the bottom of the throne to her lover, "Hordak! It's me! It's Entrapta! Your lab partner!"

The clone finally moved his unblinking gaze to the tiny Princess desperately clinging to him. His vision swept over her, taking in her tears.

"Who is Hordak?" The voice from the clone was soft, far away sounding, so... peaceful. It was *wrong*.

"Hordak-?"

Prime couldn't help but laugh. He had been trying so hard not to, but her desperate plea was too much. The Princess whirled

around to glare at him. The effect was... charming. She was so small, yet so feisty.

"Apologies, Princess," he playfully said, but then his voice very quickly took on a more serious and sinister tone, "Do not weep. Come away from that clone. The one who called himself Hordak is *gone*. He has been reset back to full functionality. Just as he was always intended to be."

The Princess still hung off the clone, sobbing. She had heard every word, but made no sound of acknowledgement. Her hand raised, the violet crystal shining in the white light of the throne room.

Prime met the eye of his clone and in an instant, the one once known as Hordak had her wrist in his grip, crystal only millimeters away from his chest.

"What's this?" Prime stood from his throne, walking graceful as a dancer down the dias. His voice, light, airy, full of calm amusement bounced around the chamber. "My, my. Isn't that pretty."

He plucked it from her fingers as she struggled, her hair gently pulling at the clones powerful grip. Prime hardly had a moment to look at the gem up close when a strand of hair snatched it back away. To anyone else, that would have been an offense punishable by loss of limb. But Prime found himself amused by this Etherian Princess. He truly couldn't say why.

Perhaps it was simply having seen his little brothers thoughts, felt his love for her. Perhaps a bit of that still lingered. A risk one took when connecting to their drones like this.

"Mmm, Princess. You are bold. Very well. Put it back. Let us see if love can restore the *dead*."

At the word 'dead', she let out another sob. The Emperor felt his smile vanish. Why did her weeping bother him so? Pathetic. He

watched as, with a trembling tendril of hair, she reinserted the crystal.

For a moment, the clones eyes flashed a deep violet, not long, only an instant. Yet it was still not the reaction Prime had expected. His face remained neutral. If this went embarrassingly for him, he could simply wipe the memory of everyone in this room, then kill Entrapta.

He noted a pained expression of his clones face when he looked at the Princess, a single tear running down his cheek. He opened his mouth to speak-

The center of his chest sparked as Primes programming fought the crystal. The clone hissed in pain, struggling. Prime felt another smile find his lips as he watched.

Entrapta was holding him again, gloved hands trying to keep the sparkling crystal connected for as long as possible. But it was all in vain. With one last spark, a hiss of pain from the girl and a smoking hole in her glove, the crystal popped out again, rejected. Prime watched the woman examine her hand, then look desperately at the crystal, the clone, then back at the crystal as she moved to pick it up once more.

It was Prime himself that crossed to her and gently pulled her hand back, examining her wound. This caught Entrapta off guard and, if he was being truthful, *himself* as well. His smile was constant as with his other hand he plucked the crystal away, hiding it in the folds of his light robes. The Princess seemed beyond protests now and she allowed him to do as he wished with resigned acceptance.

Good.

All four eyes focused on the the teary face of the Princess, he raised her gloved hand to his teeth and carefully took the tip of her index finger between his fangs. Her glove slid off with ease, leaving her naked, scorched flesh open for him to examine.

"A shame," he let the glove fall from his lips onto the floor at his feet, "this will leave a scar, Princess."

The tiny palm under his hands fascinated him. The rough, calloused surface, the olive undertones, the new scar, the word LUVD now so permanently branded into her flesh...

He lifted her palm to his lips and kissed it.

"I think I will keep you."

What just happened?

Entrapta paced the quarters she had been "assigned", arms crossed, brain working at half speed. Everything was spinning, gravity had failed her, she was heavy and weightless, floating, suffocating, falling.

Or at least she wished she was. She would give anything to be out there now, feeling nothing and everything. She pressed her hand to the window, gazing out at a sea if stars, feeling the cold under her mostly healed burn.

He had ordered the wound treated, pretending to be concerned for her well being. Or *was* he actually concerned? Entrapta truly had no sense for this sort of thing. She could read first ones writing, but when it came to reading faces, spoken words, emotions, she was hopeless.

The only one she ever seemed to understand was...

"Hordak..."

She looked down at her palm, nearly healed, yet still so clear.

Her words. Her secret message to him.
He was loved. And now he was gone.

The realization hit her like a supernova. It shook her to her core, every atom in her body coming undone, scattering to the rest of the Galaxy. She would die from this grief. How could she not?

Before she knew it, she was on the floor, curled in her hair like a nest. Her body shook, her mind went blank.

She gave up.

For hours she lay like that, despondent, grief stricken, mourning. In despair, she considered the best way to die. Weighing the pros and cons scientifically, helped her regain a small sense of self. She decided hanging might not be terrible, but jumping to her death seemed quicker. More... dramatic. Hordak had been all about drama.

As she began to count on her fingers, working out the perfect formula for a guaranteed quick and painless end, the door whooshed open. The clink of heavy boots did not pull her away from her new project until she finally glanced up at a clone standing over her. Not Hordak. Not his shell anyway. This was another drone.

"Emperor Prime asks you to join him for dinner."

"Prime can eat *this*!" She made a rude gesture with her hair before curling up once more.

She physically felt the clone stiffen a few feet away, robotic almost. The air in the room seemed to change, darken.

Entrapta sat up, eyes narrowed, ready to yell until she saw the clone bow as someone entered the room. At once, the tension dissipated.

"Entrapta?"

The Princess sat up again, blinking at the Queen of Brightmoon. There was a moment of relief, only an instant. Then the dam broke.
The two women knelt together in the middle of the room, arms laced around the other, holding each other close. They wept, a hundred apologies choked out between sobs, a rush of regret, hurt, forgiveness. Because this was all they had now.

After several long moments, Glimmer pulled away, wiping her eyes.

"Catras here too."

Entrapta wanted to be angry. She wanted to rage, blame her, throw it all at her feet. She wanted to kick and scream and... and she couldn't. She was too tired now.

"She working with *him*?" It was all she could ask.

Glimmer hesitated before nodding.

"Not because she wants to. There isn't much choice here."

Entrapta snorted at that, not with amusement. Nothing about this was amusing. She felt just like she had on Beast Island. Empty. Hopeless. Ready to die.

"Entrapta... what happened? How did you get up here?"

"I... don't remember," she answered honestly, "me and Bow watched you all vanish. Then I... I woke up in the ventilation system. I must have been beamed up too, and the crystal was..."

She looked down at her palm, studying the burn. She'd woken up with it in her hand. How? There were several explanations. Perhaps she grabbed it before she was beamed up with the rest of them, then managed to smuggle herself into the vents before blacking out, remaining undetected by Prime? Or someone placed her there? Gave her the crystal? But who? Why? It all made such little sense and thinking about it hurt...

"It's okay," Glimmer soothed, placing a hand on her shaking shoulder as she clutched her skull, "if you don't remember, it's okay! Don't hurt yourself."

"Why can't I...?"

"Shh... Entrapta, please, relax."

But she couldn't. She shook, breathing hard, hair fizzing and twitching as she clutched her head with both hands. She'd been sad before. Often. But this was a level of despair she'd never imagined. This was endless, cold, lifeless, loveless.

"I couldn't find him in time!" She sobbed, "I was too late. Hordak is... Hordak is..."

Glimmer, for all her hate towards the Horde, for all the endless rage she felt towards Hordak her entire life, managed to dredge up an ounce of pity for him. Because her friend, *yes, they were still friends*, was mourning. Because she had seen something good in him. Because she had loved him. Because she had lost him.

And now she was hurting.

"I know," she whispered, "I know. He..."

"He's dead. Prime said he's dead. Gone. Gone. *Gone*..." she sobbed into Glimmers shoulder, "And I'll never get to... I'll never tell him-"

"I do *so* dislike tardiness."

The two women froze. The voice of the Emperor broke them from their embrace, and shocked the pigtailed Princess enough to stop her endless weeping. Her large wet eyes blinked up at the beautiful form of Horde Prime himself, smiling his soft smile from the door way.

It was... hard. He positively dripped with an elegance, a perfection that seemed impossible. In her wildest fantasies, she would never have envisioned him, and yet, now he stood before her, tall and almost angelic. Stunning. Beautiful.

And she was in so much pain, looking at him, so bright, so terribly enchanting... she knew he was responsible for her pain, but it was so difficult not to feel some measure of forgiveness.

She was beginning to understand Hordak now, his desire to return. The Emperor had a gravity to him. It drew people in. Entrapta glanced at Glimmer, the shine in her eyes, the fear, the love, the hate, the disgust, the fascination, the complete... adoration.

"Off the floor," he commanded, a hint of amusement, almost laughter in his sweet voice, "you are Royalty, remember?"

The two women did as commanded, messy, tear stained faces presented for him to examine. His perfect smile fell as two of his four eyes fell on Entrapta. A shiver ran up her spine.

She hated him. So much. And yet... she reached up to wipe her eyes on the back of her hand.

"Get dressed," he commanded, voice suddenly cold, "I will be lenient this time, but in the future I expect punctuality, even from my... *guests*."

He turned to leave, but not before offering a slight incline to the women, a hint of a bow, respectful. Once he was gone, the door slid shut behind him, leaving two clones waiting just inside guarding the door.

"We have to get you dressed," Glimmer whispered urgently, reaching to pull her to the wardrobe.

"But I... I *am* dressed?"

Entrapta was confused, so confused. None of today made sense. None of it felt real. Hordak was gone. Her Lab Partner was gone. Forever. And she never got to say what she wanted to say. And now she was supposed to have dinner with his Big Brother, the one who erased him, killed him.

"He means dressed. Like a... Princess. We need to clean you up."

Entrapta looked down at herself, clothing torn, filthy from a month on Beast Island, hair dirty. An angry part of her wanted to refuse, to march down there as she was, offend him with her unrefined appearance. But the look in Glimmers eyes warned her and for once, Entrapta caught the meaning at once.

Rebelling now would be a mistake.

"...Okay."

For thirty minutes, the Emperor of everything waited. This was a courtesy he offered so few. He *never* waited. It was a proof that there was something special about his new guests.

When the door finally slid open to the large, clean white dining hall, The Emperor rose with a smile. The Queen looked much as expected, clean, regal. But the Princess, the one his clone had fallen for...

He found one of his eyes lingering just a little longer on her. Clean, well dressed and properly made up, she could have been a completely different person.

His smile turned into a grin.
He was pleased.

"Queen Glimmer, Princess Entrapta," he said Entrapta's name with a flourish, all four eyes flashing to look at her directly as he bowed, "thank you for joining me."

Entrapta felt... foolish. She felt naked without her gloves, her mask, her coveralls. How would she work like this? The dress was so uncomfortable. She couldn't move in it. Too tight in some places, too loose and flowy in others. And the fabric was too delicate. She would rip it in a moment.

A clone pulled a chair out for Glimmer. But for Entrapta, Prime himself helped her to be seated, offering a hand, kissing her palm, just as before. He seemed to almost... purr when her calloused fingers brushed his cheek. It made Entrapta deeply uncomfortable. Her stomach flipped, she felt she would be sick any moment. On instinct, she pulled her hand away, shivering.

It was the wrong move, she knew it was. But when she dared to look up at the Emperor, he still wore that smile. That was almost worse. As if he were somehow pleased by her discomfort.

He took his place once again at the head of the table, holding an empty glass out to be filled. A clone stepped forward to do so and Entrapta recognized the clone at once as her Hordak. No. Not anymore. This was just his... shell.

She looked down, tears threatening to overflow again. The Emperor purred, reaching up to run a gentle claw across the clones cheek.

"Princess? Would you care for a... taste?"

Entrapta looked up again, eyes frantically moving from the clone to the glass. Prime had traced the metal claw across his clones sharp jawline, pulling his chin close, lips inches from his. Two eyes focused on the blushing Princess, a brilliant green grin flashing.

Not-Hordak looked... desperate. Fearful? Loving. Adoring. *Needy*.

When the Emperor finally pulled his hand away, Entrapta could have sworn she heard a whimper, but Horde prime either had not noticed or did not care.

"The *wine*, my dear," The Emperor elaborated, "would you like a taste of the *wine*?"

Entrapta shook her head, looking down. As food was brought out, the familiar hands of Not-Hordak placed a serving in front of her. Some sort of soup in a large bowl.

She frowned.

Glimmer silently raised her spoon to her lips, glancing to Entrapta as she did. Not that Entrapta suspected poison. If he wanted her dead, he could have had her dead already. And the food appeared to be... eatable by Etherian standards. Truthfully, it smelled delicious and a faint rumble in her stomach told her she should eat, but...

"It's too big."

Every set of eyes in the room snapped to her at that moment. With all four eyes of the Emperor staring her down, she trembled, hands fiddling with a tendril of hair at her shoulders.

"Too... big?" Horde Prime questioned, "please elaborate."

"She only eats tiny things," The voice of Catra explained, stepping out from a small nook at the edge of the room, "a dozen small bowls of soup should do it. tiny servings, food cut into shapes, miniature versions of larger foods. Bite sized. Things like that."

One of Primes eyes flashed to Catra, face betraying only a hint of annoyance. The rest of his eyes remained firmly on Entrapta.

"I see."

He did not smile. It made Entrapta nervous, especially when he snapped his fingers and Not-Hordak stepped forward again. With lightning fast ferocity, his claws gripped the face of the clone, roughly pulling and forcing his face towards Entrapta. She watched with horror as the living doll stared back at her with

lifeless green eyes.
"Our Princess says her soup is too big. Fix it. Now."

He shoved the clone away. Causing him to stumble to his knees. He lowered his head to his master before rising again. Entrapta waited, silent, wide eyes fearful as he reached over her shoulder to remove the soup. For one instant, his chest brushed her back, throwing her down a dark tunnel of nostalgia, memories of gentle touches, accidental brushes as they worked, hands both reaching for the same tool. Then it was gone and so was the soup.

"Catra, assist him."

The feline looked prepared to protest, but said nothing as she followed him out.

"A thousand apologies, Princess. I was not aware of such... needs. Please feel free to make more specific requests in the future. I want nothing more than for you to feel comfortable here."

Something in his tone sounded dangerous under the polite, almost song like sound. Her mind worked to uncover hidden meaning, but it was useless. She glanced at Glimmer who was pointedly looking anywhere else.

She nodded her response, quieter than she had ever been in her life. Prime regarded her carefully, swirling the deep colored liquid in his sparkling glass. He seemed to contemplate saying something, but as he opened his mouth to do so, the clone returned with a tray of a dozen soups in tiny matching white cups, complete with a tiny spoon for each one.

It was... cute.

Her face must have betrayed her delight because the Emperor let out a small breath of laughter as the tray was set before her. It reminded her very quickly where she was again and her joy melted once more to despair.

The clone behind her waited, and she knew it was *him* again. Constantly there, tormenting her. She was reminded immediately of the first time Hordak fainted in front of her. She had made him soup, a dozen in any tiny cup she could find in the mess hall. He had been resistant, but it was so cute-

"Do you need assistance, Princess?"

Primes smooth voice cut through the memory like a razor. She realized too late that she was crying again, staring down at the soup and if it were a gravestone.

"N-no," she wept, reaching a shaking hand for a spoon, only to make a mess all over the table.

A sigh brought a new feeling of inadequacy, disappointment in herself.

"Assist her," he ordered.

Before Entrapta could protest, the clone who had once been Hordak gently pulled her chair out, grabbed a tiny bowl and guided a spoon to her lips. His impassive face, dead green eyes only made the tears fall harder as he spooned bite after bitter bite down her throat. Twice she nearly choked on her own sobs.

Glimmer would not look up, but their host watched the scene with calculating intensity. He looked fascinated.

"Enough." His order was gentle, almost sing-song. The clone set down the fifth tiny bowl, now nearly empty and stepped away with a bow. "Now, Princess. Are you feeling better?"

Tears still trickling down her cheeks, she nodded. Lying was not something she generally did. And it was clear it was a bad idea from the way he frowned.

"No you aren't," his voice went arctic cold, "I advise you be truthful from now on, Princess. It will... make it much easier to live together."

She wept harder, hair fizzing all the way to the base of her pigtails. His words broke her heart in a way that made her feel unfixable. His implication was obvious. She would not be leaving.

"W-what will...?"

Glimmer watched her now, pity in her sparkling eyes. She had the distinct feeling that her fate had been decided before she had been brought before the Emperor. And she had the impression that Glimmer had a hand in it.

"Do not look so sad, Princess," he soothed, setting his glass down, "my future bride should be happy."

Bride. A bride. Her. Wife. Marriage. Him.

Her eyes roved frantically around the room, from him, to Glimmer, from clone, to clone, to clone, to Not-Hordak, to Catra. To the exit. She rose to her feet, shaking.

"*No*."

"No?" The Emperor seemed to raise a brow at this.

"Entrapta, please-" Glimmer hissed, "don't-"

"Did I give the impression I was *asking*?" He rose to his feet as well, cold anger, rage like an ice storm. Directly opposite of Hordak. His rage was always so hot, fiery. She missed the warmth of his rage.

"Why me?" She demanded, glaring at Glimmer. She pointed a finger at the other woman. "Why not *her*?!"

Fire. She needed to find that fire. Melt his ice. Hordak. She needed to hold his warm memory, keep it burning. Use it. The nights would be cold from here on out.

"Leave us."

The order was absolute. Even Glimmer left the room. All clones, Catra, Not-Hordak. Everyone left. They were alone, just the two of them remained now.

The Emperor seemed to calm a little. He closed two of his eyes for a moment, breathing deep. When he opened them again, he was smiling. He stepped around the table, approaching her with hands tucked neatly behind his lower back.

"It's simple, really," he answered with a hint of amusement, "I don't want her. She is close to perfect. You? You are *not*. You are...flawed. So unlike my ideal. You fascinate me."

He looked so... gentle, almost loving. But his words stung. She felt insulted, deeply. All of her insecurities seemed open to him, laid out for him to pick at.

"While I establish myself here, it will be useful to have a sympathetic figure at my side. You. A symbol of what I can accomplish. Making the imperfect, perfect."

He reached out to her with one hand and she winced, certain he would grip her face, throw her as he did with his clone. But he didn't. His hand was soft, gentle as he cupped her face, guiding her.

"Be mine and you will have all you could ever want. I could provide you with a lab, assistants, all the knowledge of my Empire at your disposal. Think of what you could discover. You could unlock the mysteries of the Universe at my side. That is what you always wanted, yes?"

His whispered words seemed to put her under some sort of trance. She found herself honestly considering it. Had this voice come out of Hordaks mouth, she would have said yes in an instant. But he was gone. Wouldn't he want her to do this?

"Refuse and..."
He leaned in, teeth flashing, scraping gently against her throat.

"And you'll kill me," she assumed, "got it."

Good. It was a win-win situation. All she had to do was say no and she could die.

"*Kill* you? Oh no, my dear. Not exactly," he pulled away to focus all four eyes on hers. "But I *will* kill them. Catra, the Queen, even that clone. What did you call him again? Hordak?"

At the sound of his name spoken outloud in this voice, she raised a tendril of hair to slap him. He caught it in one claw, smiling that beautiful terrible smile as he tugged it hard.

"Before I erased him, do you know what I saw?" He leaned in, lips close to her ear. She could almost feel the wicked grin as he whispered a single word.

"*Love*."

It was one word, but it meant everything. For the rest of time, from this moment to her last, that word was an anchor, a light in the dark, the final spark of hope.

He was right. He loved her. She looked down at her palm, to him, to that sickening smile on that mouth. So much like his. A shallow, desperate part of her could see Hordak in him.

Not the same, but...

No. Not the same. But she could pretend. For their sakes, for a little while. Because Hordak had loved her to the very end. Because he wanted her to live.

Her eyes pricked with tears at the sheer effort it took just to keep breathing now.

"If you would love a flawed clone," he purred, tracing her jawline with one hand as he tugged a hand through her hair with the other, "then surely you can learn to love me as well."

He gripped a handful of hair at the base of her scalp, eliciting a cry from her as he forced her head back. At that moment, a flash of violet from somewhere in his robes caught her eye. The crystal. *His* crystal.

She made up her mind. She would survive. Because Hordak loved her. Because he wanted her to live. Because if there was a way to bring back the dead, Entrapta would find it. No matter what she had to do. No matter what it cost her.

"When is the wedding?" Her voice was flat, emotionless, resigned.

A green grin flashed. He had her now.

"As soon as possible. Is that a yes to my little... proposal then, Princess?"

Entrapta met his eyes, all four of them and slowly inclined her head.

"I accept."

Green

Chapter Summary

Physical abuse, emotional abuse, mild sexual assault. Suicidal thoughts as well.

"*I accept*."

Barely had the words escaped her that he forced his lips against hers. Hard. Messy. He kissed her with an urgency he had not known for some time. The other wives in his harem, they were lovely, true, but this was a desire that was so far removed from his usual. A taste of something strange and exotic.

Flawed. So far below him, and yet...

His clone had possessed something Prime didn't. Not *yet*. That clone had her love. Even now, her heart beat for him. *Only* him. Entirely.

How *dare* he? How dare he even think of forming a bond with another? How dare he ever consider loving another more than he? He was his creator, his *God*! He was made in his image and his devotion belonged to him entirely!

She moaned as his tongue forced it's way past her lips. The sound made him absolutely wild. He pushed her against the table, knocking glasses over. Wild, almost feral.

His grip in her hair tightened, his mouth hungrily devoured hers. The taste, the touch. Her weak protests only urged him on, excited him. She moaned again, involuntarily, he knew. She was terrified, pressed her hands against his bare chest, trying in vain to break away.

Good. He liked her fear, the taste of her tears. A strand of hair whipped out to push him away and he tugged her scalp in

warning. The strand fell limp down her back again as the rest of her gave in.

The instant he felt her relax, he pulled away, grinning. One eye took in the state of her as his hand combed through her hair, gently, lovingly. A sharp contrast from only seconds ago. She shook, back still pressed against the table. Her hair was a mess now, pigtails down, limp, lifeless, pooling on the floor like water. The sleeve of her dress had torn as well, hanging off her shoulder. He couldn't quite remember if that was if his doing, or if it had been a result of her struggling. It didn't matter.

He broke away from her completely, pushing his white ropes if hair and wire back into place. Perfect. Always perfection.

Except just a moment ago. When she made him lose control-

Like a flash of lightning, his beautiful claw snatched her chin, forcing her close again. All four brilliant green eyes focused on her face, her bruised and bloodied lower lip. His eyes softened suddenly, unexpectedly, and so did his grip. He sighed, letting go and dipping into a shallow bow for her.

"My deepest apologies. I appear to have forgotten myself for a moment."

And he was being sincere in his apology.

"That was no way to begin our relationship."

His beautiful, gentlemanly smile was captivating. Entrapta found it hard not to forgive him, especially as he pulled out a soft, perfectly white cloth and brought it to her lips. He dabbed at her bloodied lip with a gentleness she had not expected. All the while, he held her eyes in his, appearing almost...

No. He was *not* a kind man. She couldn't allow herself to imagine he was for an instant.

"Ah, our first kiss, my dear one," he seemed to almost tease as he moved on to wiping her tears away, "such a pity it could not have been the romantic moment we both envisioned. Still, plenty of time for romance later."

She wanted to point out that it was his fault. She wanted to shout at him. It had been...

"Was that your *first* kiss?" He questioned, as if sensing her thoughts. "Curious..." he whispered, running a thumb now down her cheek. "Your Hordak never once kissed you?"

That was enough to break her from what ever spell he seemed to have her under.

"Don't. Say. His. Name."
Her voice was little more than a hiss, but there was such venom in it to make even a mighty Emperor take notice. His perfect smile faltered, his hand fell away from her cheek, a flash of anger on his face was the only warning he would give.

"Hordak," he said sternly, "is dead."

Her hair twitched, but before she could attack, he snatched it all up in one hand, holding it above her, harmless, while his other hand reached for one wrist. Strong. Powerful. Beautiful. Terrible.

She struggled. He seemed to only find that charming.

"Hush now, hush," he soothed, pulling her close like a lover. He let go of her wrist, moving his hand instead to her waist, but his other remained firmly on her hair. "Do you promise to behave? I will stop pulling if you do."

To illustrate his point, he gave her hair another fierce tug. She nodded and as he promised, he let go.

"If you try anything again, I will cut it," he warned, "it is in your best interest to be obedient. Life will not be kind to you here if you keep having such a rebellious spirit."

He still held her close, leaning in to brush his lips against her neck as both hands traced up and down her waist and hips. The thin fabric of the dress left so little for him to imagine about her body, yet it took so much of his will power not to lose himself again and tear it off of her. As his hands continued their journey, his lips gently placed tiny airy kisses against her pulse point.

"Princess..." he breathed, tickling her ear, "I've had your first kiss. By the end of the week, I will have the rest of you."

Before she had a chance to question, his lips were once again on hers. This kiss was closer to what she had imagined a first kiss to be. This was gentle, but firm. His lips had a taste that was both familiar and alien. What did they taste like? Sweet, and almost... minty?

He pulled away and she lost his taste. Breathlessly, she clung to him, feeling weak. Desperate, lonely, hurt and angry all at once. He was a constant, would be a constant in her life now. She had to at least pretend, put on a show. Perhaps if she pretended long enough...

Chuckling darkly, he pulled away from her slightly, just enough to tuck a finger under her chin.

"Good girl," he purred, "you learn fast. Remember our first kiss, my Dear One. I do not wish to hurt you, but I will always do what is necessary to maintain order. Do not test me."

With eyes locked, she nodded, understanding. She had to play along. It was the only option available. He pulled her in again, a gentle embrace, a sweet kiss to her forehead. Like this, she could pretend. He and Hordak were... similar. Enough so that if she squinted her eyes...

"There now. Let us go. I will have you taken back to your room. You are a mess, Dear One. We can't have you looking less than..."

"*Perfect*," she murmured as she took his offered arm.

The delight on his face was like a sunny winters day. Cold, but bright all the same. Overwhelming. She felt she might go blind from its brilliance.

"You are clever," he complemented, the first genuine one he had given her. "I have an idea. As an early wedding gift, I shall give you a clone of mine. Someone to serve you, protect you, dress you and undress you, entertain you. A companion. You would like that. Wouldn't you? After all, I have a Universe to run. I can not very well be at your side all the time."

Entrapta knew where this was going before he even led her out of the dining hall. In the other side, Not-Hordak waited, greeting them both with a low bow.

"This one," he decided with a wicked smile. "I'll gift you this one. You are... familiar already with him. He is a little flawed, of course, but if that bothers you I can always throw him away and-"

"Thank you, my... love," she awkwardly replied, testing the word on her tongue. The L word seemed to bring fresh delight to her new Emperor. "he will do."

She locked eyes with Not-Hordak as he bowed to her once again.

"I live to serve you," he said in that same soft, blissful voice.

Perhaps she was simply getting used to being hurt, or perhaps she was simply out of tears, because she did not cry this time. As her future husband stepped away, gracefully bending down to kiss her hand and pass it off to the clone, she allowed it without protest. She was tired, sore, drained.

"Rest well, My Dear One," he purred, "tomorrow I want you to rise early so we may discuss details of the wedding."

Wedding. Her heart sank, but she forced a smile. That seemed to be enough for him. He gave her one last bow which she returned, before walking away, two clones appearing seemingly from nowhere to walk behind him.

Once he was out of sight, Entrapta looked at his... "gift". He stared ahead as if in some trance, still focused on the space Prime had once occupied, as if he lost all purpose once he was out of sight. He was... so empty. Like a doll, she decided. To be posed how ever he wanted him, to be anything he needed, to be used, abused, and tossed aside once he was finished playing.

"Hord- I mean..." she took a deep breath, trying to calm the panic that crept up in her heart, "What are you called?"

The clone turned his head slowly to look her politely in the eye, a tiny porceline smile on his pale doll face.

"My number is 828-1075," he replied gently, citrine eyes unblinking, glossy, "You may call me what you please. I am at your service, my Princess."

She simply nodded in response. 828-1075 was a bit of a mouthful to say, but... she couldn't bring herself to give him a name. She couldn't call him Hordak. She could name her bots, and did. But this felt... less somehow. Her bots had personality, but this... he had nothing. Just a singular need, following his program, one order.

"828," she sighed, "fine."

The clone gently tilted his perfect head at her before guiding her along by the arm. A... companion. That was what he was meant to be to her, according to the Emperor. But she knew that wasn't entirely true. A companion was a friend, and there was nothing friendly about this doll. He looked pleasant to be around, calm, serene, but Entrapta did not buy it for an instant.

This was a spy. No matter what Prime said, he did not truly belong to her at all.

She wracked her brain for anything to fill the silence during the long walk back to the room. A conversation topic. Something.

"So... you will do *anything* I tell you to do?" She ventured.

"I will preform any task assigned by you. Princess, so long as it does not violate my primary purpose."

"...and what is your primary purpose?"

They stood outside her "room" now and the clone immediately unlocked and swiped a claw in front of a panel, opening it for her. That interested her. She would figure it out later. Experiment. Taking things apart always made her feel better.

"I was created to serve our great Emperor," he answered vaguely, bowing as she moved past him to enter the bedroom again.

The room was... large. She hadn't noticed before. Through her tears, the only thing she saw was rage and sorrow. But now, with a clearer head, a goal, she took it all in.

Entrapta was a Princess and as such, she was used to a certain bit of luxury. But this was astounding. It made her bedroom in Dryl look like a primative shack.

Every surface of every wall had an almost diamond shimmer to it, the floor was white too, some brilliant white stone that likely cost a fortune. She wanted to study it, but the large fur rug beside the sleek, elevated white bed caught her attention instead. The bed looked comfortable, but that rug looked... so soft. Without warning, she lay down on it, curled up, staring at the impossibly tall ceiling, the dozen softly glowing lights dripping like rain and the sea of stars beyond.

Stars. It only just hit her that majority of the room, including the ceiling above the bed, was a window. The sudden realization made her feel exposed, vulnerable. Sure, the chances of someone floating outside in space to peep on her were almost nonexistent, but to be so crushingly on display for the entire universe...

"Emperor Prime created this suite for his Empress," 828 chimed in helpfully, like some overly cheerful AI, "the white is meant to remind you of your place at his side and his quest for order. The

windows display for you your shared Empire. If you would turn your attention to-"

"Bath," she snapped, cutting him off mid explanation, "I'm going to have a bath."

The clone seemed to need a moment to process this, but once he did, he bowed and then moved to the other side of the room where the tub was also annoyingly exposed to countless windows. Why was there no privacy in this suite? The only other rooms were one room for a toilet, and another room for clothes. Annoying. But her... Fiance? He said she could request anything she wanted, so... maybe she could get a screen or two for Privacy?

"Wait, I can fill-"

"My purpose is to serve you, Princess," his soothing voice replied immediately as water began to splash and fill the impossibly large tub.

She sat up a moment to watch him, then lay back down to look up at the endless Universe. When she married him, this would be...

Still his, no matter what he said. His talk of 'sharing' anything was all just that. Talk. He was posturing. Using her.

She just had to make this work. Because she had no choice. For Etheria, for her friends, for... Him.

"My Princess," 828 appeared again in her direct view, standing over where she was quietly watching the stars from her place on the floor, "your bath has been prepared."

She sat up again, blinking. After the week she'd had... no. Scratch that. It had only been a little over 42 hours, by her calculations since she'd been rescued from beast island. No wonder she felt so dizzy and tired. She'd hardly slept. And the information overload,

seeing a first ones ship, learning about Etheria, meeting Horde Prime, finding out about Hordak, the engagement, the kiss-

Oh First Ones... the kiss.
As 828 gently guided her to the tub by her elbow, she traced her fingers along her bruised lips. Her mind worked to unravel what had happened. His hands on her, his lips, his teeth, tearing fabric, the taste of mint and blood, his whispered warnings, his promise to... have the rest of her by the end of the week.

Dear one.

828 stopped her beside the tub, hands immediately working to unfasten her ruined garments. By the time she came back to herself enough to realize, he had already pulled one shoulder down.

"Stop! What are you doing?!" She demanded, pulling away, "Dont!"

828 brought his lifeless green eyes to study her before wordlessly moving to tug her garments down once more, robotic, automatic.

"I said *stop*!" She snarled, hair whipping out to shove... Not-Hordak away. "Leave! I don't want you here when I bathe."

"I am ordered by Emperor Prime to watch you at all hours while you are awake."

At the mention of Prime, she blinked, going stiff with fear. He seemed to take that opening to tug her dress the rest of the way down, exposing her to the cold air of her room.

"Don't touch me," she snapped, slapping his hands away when he went to hook a talon around her panties to pull them off, "I will do that myself!"

The doll-like clone paused, then stepped back, appearing to accept this compromise. He still watched her every agonizingly

embarrassing second as she slipped the last bit of modesty away and sunk into the warm scented depths of the tub.

Tomorrow, while they discussed the wedding, she would have a few demands of her own to make, starting with Horda- Clone 828.

Taking a deep breath, she slid under the soothing waters, letting it all wash away. The sting of her lip throbbed with every beat of her heart, reminding her just how easy it would be to simply stay under this water just a little too long. Let her lungs fill with bathwater, slip into beautiful unconsciousness. Let Prime discover her the next day, floating face down at the bottom of this way too large tub. He would have to find a new Etherian bride to use and humiliate. Someone more suited to his image.

She looked up through the swirling surface of the water at two green eyes looking down at her. Him. He was even ruining her suicide fantasies.

She splashed above the surface, gasping for breath. 828 blinked slowly at her and for a single tired instant, she thought he had looked almost worried. Then he smiled his perfect smile and held up a towel.

"You must sleep. I have selected a clean nightgown for-"

She snatched the towel from his claws and quickly covered herself as she stood. Doll or not, he still wore Hordaks face like a mask and she was... embarrassed.

In the back of her mind, the nagging thought followed her all the way to bed.

What if Hordak is still in there somewhere? What if he sees all this? What if he is in there, conscious, unable to do anything? What if he can only watch?

The idea of him alive in there brought her a new level of pain. Especially as the lights dimmed and her new 'companion' settled

into bed next to her. He lay stiff, leaving three feet of space between them, hands folded across his chest like a corpse. But his eyes remained open, staring, examining her every breath and small movement, ready to report to Prime in an instant.

His wide green eyes cast a sickening glow around the room. She realized quickly that he would not close his eyes until he detected that she had entered her sleep cycle. She turned away from him, heart thundering as her imagination ran wild.

What would happen when she fell asleep. Would he sleep as well? She had never seen Hordak asleep. Not really. Sure, he fell unconscious once and she suspected he needed sleep, but when she went to bed at night he was always still awake and when she awoke in the morning, she always had the distinct impression he had been awake for hours.

She was certain they required sleep, otherwise why would he lay down with her? Prime must need sleep as well, right? She hoped he did, otherwise she had no idea how she was going to steal Hordaks crystal back.

Maybe she could just ask him tomorrow about it.

This was the thought that chased her off to sleep.

Gray

Chapter Summary

Non consensual sexual touching, and just general ickiness.
Clone fucking. Incest or masturbation? Both?
Either way, that's what you're in for.

Please be kind to yourself.

"Wake, Princess."

Entraptas eyes snapped open and she sat up. The past 2 days played in her head at top speed. Part of her was in a panic, thinking she was still on Beast Island and the other part was in a panic hearing Hordaks voice again.

She sat there for almost a full thirty seconds, panting as she blinked at her surroundings. At the side of the bed, Hord- no. *828* stood with a pretty porceline smile and a tray of charming pastries. Entrapta reached for one on instinct, but pulled her hand back, feeling nauseous.

"*Are you unwell, Dear One*?"

She jumped, fearful eyes finding her husband-to-be lounging on a long sofa by another window. His brilliant green grin both thrilled her and terrified her. Immediately, she held the fluffy down duvet to her chest, blushing.

"I'm... okay," she answered awkwardly, watching 828 from the corner of her eye. The clone, endlessly smiling, set the tray down on a large glass table before the Emperor, bowed once more and backed out of the room, leaving her entirely alone with him once again.

"I dismissed your companion for the time being," he explained, crossing his legs, making it quite clear he would be remaining for a while.

"I... thought you wanted to discuss wedding plans?" She asked cautiously, too quiet.

"Are we not able to have a discussion here?" He asked playfully, "out of bed now. *Come*."

She found she simply couldn't disobey. His approval was... vital. To make anything work, she had to simply be perfect. His ideal. Somehow.

And, if she was being honest, he felt... *good*. His attention. It was so toxic and so cruel, but in a deep dark part of her heart, she enjoyed it. He was important to the Universe. And he wanted *her*. And even when he hurt her, she still craved it, felt she deserved it.

She pulled the covers off, bare feet meeting the soft fur rug. Two of his eyes were on her. The other two seemed focused on the silvery gray dressing gown laid carefully out over a chair at the bed side. For a moment her eyes snapped from Prime, to the dressing gown, then back to him again. Then she got it. She couldn't quite stop herself from letting out an "oh!" once she got the hint.

Quickly, she threw the dressing gown on over herself and cautiously stepped forward. Her fingers ran through her hair, still dragging heavy along the floor. After yesterdays events... she just couldn't make it do what she wanted.

Her discomfort was clear as day. Her fingers felt cold all the time without her gloves, she had no blast mask to hide beyond, all the clothing here was too restricting. She wanted desperately to explore and discover, but she had a clone 2 feet behind her at all times watching her every movement. It was...

A prison

A beautiful, sparkling, luxurious prison. And her warden was the most perfect creature in the Universe.

"In the future, I expect you to obey my orders faster, Dear One." His words were a confusing mix of annoyed and playful, but the tone was clear as day. She was displeasing him with her hesitation.

Her lip, now swollen and bruised reminded her that he could be both gentle and vicious, kind and cruel. And there rarely seemed space for any gray.

He motioned for her to sit across from him in a high backed white chair and she did without a fuss.

"Let us get down to business, shall we?" He smiled at her and there was a sudden increase in heartrate. Fear. She didn't like the way he was looking at her. Like she was some sort of... meal.

"I have a request!" She squeaked immediately before he could continue.

He seemed taken aback and she noticed that the wires in his hair seemed to almost twitch in her direction when she interrupted. A reaction to Primes sudden anger? As quickly as it came, however, it seemed to drain when he closed his eyes and took a deep breath.

"Interrupting me will be punished in the futu-"

"I just want more privacy!"

Now he looked neither angry or pleased. He simply seemed stunned. For a full ten seconds, his mouth moved but the only thing that came out was a choked gasp of incredulity.

"It's just- I don't like being watched when I'm bathing and seeing to my other biological needs and I can undress myself and he watched me fall asleep and I just want a few moments alone and-
"

"*Enough*!" He snarled, "silence! Stop babbling for a moment!"

His hair tentacles had detached from its resting place and seemed almost... poised for attack? Like agitated snakes.

She looked away, eyes shining with fear. The sight seemed to remind him of his position and he quickly pushed his 'hair' back into place with a gentle sweep of his hands.

"Many apologies," he sighed, stretching across the sofa and leaning his head back. Two eyes studied the endless Universe above while the other two studied her. After a moment to calm himself he explained.
"The duty of a companion is to protect and serve his mistress. How can 828-1075 be expected to protect you if he can not see you at all times?"

"I'm not saying I don't... *need* him. But can't I just have some privacy? He doesnt have to undress me for a bath all the time, does he? And I just... sometimes I want alone time."

Now all four eyes were on her, narrowed, suspicious almost.

"Why would my wife need 'alone time'?"

The razor sharp meaning of his words cut. Wife. Her. She had to remind herself that it was a role she was expected to take up. Perfectly.

"Well... sometimes it helps me think. Or... if I want to..." she played with her fingers, blushing, "experience *solo* sexual pleasure."

The Emperor looked impassive, if a little releived. It was clear this was not a taboo subject for him.

"If you are need of sexual release, you are permitted to approach me for assistance. If I am unavailable, 828-1075 is permitted to orally stimulate you."

His voice was calm, almost clinical. Unbothered. Entrapta blinked, face red. The corners of his mouth curled up at her clear embarrassment.

"You are a virgin," he observed, "I knew you had never been kissed, but then, you don't necessarily need to kiss to experience sexual pleasure with another. Ah. My poor baby brother never got to enjoy you after all."

He watched her for an uncomfortably long time before moving on as if they had simply been discussing dinner plans.

"We will marry on Etheria. Queen Glimmer has been kind enough to offer Brightmoon for the ceremony. You will be happy to see your... friends one more time, I suppose."

She stared down at her hands sadly. Brightmoon. So Glimmer really *had* sold her. What was the treasure her love paid for? Her own life? No. Glimmer was better than that. Likely, she had convinced Prime to spare Etherias people, maintain peace.

Order.

One more time, he said. He would see them one more time. Did this mean what she thought? That she would never be allowed to see them again? Perhaps it meant she'd never see Etheria again.

"The wedding will of course be transmitted to the entire Empire. Trillions will watch the ceremony, so it will have to be perfect. You will be trained extensively on the proper etiquette to follow and exactly what you will be expected to do and say. A script will be provided."

It sounded like a play. Well, in the end, isnt this what it was? He didn't love her. He only wanted her for symbolic purposes. For his ego.

"After the wedding, I will expect a child from you every three years, at least. If you can not conceive naturally, we will use other means. You will stay and live here on my flagship with me for the

foreseeable future. I will visit you in your chambers as often as I please, or I will summon you to mine."

He propped himself up on his elbow, turning towards her, one hand tapping lightly on his thigh, his lips pulled back with another coy smile.

"As I said earlier, you are welcome to seek me out for sexual pleasure, however, if I am with another wife-"

"Another?"

Eyes narrowed at her interruption, but he did not react with anger this time. He simply tilted his head at her thoughtfully.

"I have twelve wives currently," he explained, "but I will have a single Empress."

Twelve. That would make her lucky number thirteen. She took a deep breath, nodding. Of course she did not think for an instant she would be the only one for him.

"And which one is your Empress?" She asked, playing idly with her hair now.

"Did your Companion not explain?" He sounded genuinely surprised, so much so, that she looked up to meet all of his eyes. "This suite was designed for my Empress. If it is where I have chosen to keep you, then...?"

He was trailing off for her to finish. She took a deep breath, nodding.

"I am your Empress?" She ventured, "but... I'm really not a good leader. I can't-"

"What made you think I was asking you to help me lead?" He actually laughed now. "No. Your job is to simply look happy at my side and give me heirs. I am working on my image, you see. I found it is easiest to make my subjects fall in line when they have

a healthy bit of love for me, as well as fear. My people crave a bit of tenderness, and I will give it... with you. The masses adore a good love story, after all."

"I don't understand why you want me..."

The Emperor sighed, sitting up entirely to grab a glass and pour himself some of the water on the table.

"I said it before. You are imperfect. It makes you relatable. If I am capable of loving even you, then surely I am capable of loving the rest of my subjects, you see? But the plan goes further. I will change you with time, showing that with my love, even the imperfect can become-"

"Perfect,"she finished for him, "I see now."

His pretty perfect lips pulled back in a grin and he patted the spot next to him.

"Come, Dear One, sit with me."

She stood up, and wordlessly walked around the low glass table to sit next to him.

"My sweet girl," he purred, laying an arm around her shoulder and offering his glass to her, "it doesn't have to all be an act. You'll find I can be a good mate and a better lover."

She simply nodded, looking uncomfortable with the touch as she drained the glass. In general, she preferred as little contact as possible. Allowing someone to touch her, especially sexually, would be a challenge.

"Things will be better for us both if we can learn to... appreciate each other," his hand over her shoulder began to squeeze her close as he leaned in to place a kiss to her neck. Her eyes closed and she just allowed herself to drift away. He was right. It would be better to just give in. Who knew how long this would be her life?

His other hand fell to her knee and he began to almost impatiently tug the skirt of her nightgown up her legs. Her eyes blinked open again and she began to pull away. Struggling against his tight grip.

"Please, don't-"

"Relax," he purred, pulling the empty glass away and setting to the side, "it will feel good if you allow it."

Allow it. If she allowed it. He made it sound like she had a choice, but she knew she didn't. There was never a choice.

His talons against her throat warned her against a struggle, sharp, painful, deadly. She felt teeth scrape the side of her neck as his hand traveled up her thigh and disappear under the hem of her nightgown.

"Open your legs," he ordered as his hand traced across her mound, fingers curling in the downy hair. He clutched the V of her womanhood, attempting to slip a finger inside, but gave up when she crossed her legs in a panic

He removed his hand with a sigh and pressed a finger to a small panel on a side table.

"828-1075, I require your assistance."

In horror, she turned her head to look at him, but he simply smiled that victorious smile back at her. She had disobeyed, and she was about to see her punishment.

The door whooshed open and Not-Hordak entered with a bow. As the door closed behind, the Emperor gestured with a long silver talon and the Clone stepped forward. Entrapta met his eyes, pleading and for one fleeting moment she thought she could see something in him. Understanding? Horror? Perhaps even pity?

Then it was gone the next instant.

"Hold her legs open," he ordered and the clone knelt in front if her to obey.

"*Please*," she begged in a panic, "please don't! I'll do anything, just don't-"

"Oh, it is too late for bargaining, Dear One," he sighed, nodding for the clone to do as he was instructed. Not-Hordak place both hands to her knees and forced them far apart. Her eyes overflowed then and she let out a sob. This wasn't her Hordak anymore, but she still felt betrayal, even as he turned his head away, doll-like smile faded, nearly gone.

"When I give an order, I expect it obeyed. Without. Question."

His long fingers slid up and down her slit as he spoke. She wept openly, hands balled into fists on her lap. Her short nails dug deep into her palm, shaking. His teeth were so close to her neck, his other claw traced down her throat, shoulder, arm. Hand. He suddenly gripped her wrist as a finger slid inside.

It didn't hurt exactly, but it was far from comfortable. His teeth suddenly sunk lightly into her neck. Now that *did* hurt. Hurt and... something else. Something she wasn't familiar with. She let out a sound that was in between a groan and a gasp.

"Ahh, *there* is is," he teased breathily, slowly pumping one finger in and out of her, "I believe you enjoyed that. You are so wet already."

She shook her head as if to deny it, but what did she really know? Alright, she knew a lot. But that was all theoretical knowledge, the basics. Biological responses to stimuli. Not... this. She had almost no practical knowledge of any of this.

"Oh, do not feel so embarassed, Dear One," he purred, guiding her hand to his lap, "you've had an effect on me as well. See?"

Through her tears, she followed their hands to his erection, stiff and firm through his clothing. Immediately, her tears stilled. She

was curious. The possibility of scientific study was far too much. Before Catra betrayed her, she was working up the courage to ask Hordak is she could study his anatomy. She'd had an entire chart prepared to fill out, experiments to conduct.

If Hordak was a defect, how could she resist studying the original?

"I want to see it," she managed to pant, heat rising in her cheeks as pleasure built in her core, "I... f-for *scientific* purposes."

Against her throat, she felt him grin. Still kneeling between her legs, the clone seemed to almost stiffen, glancing up for only a moment as the Emperor let her hand go. She watched with stilted breath as he pulled aside his tunic and from his trousers revealed the only phallus she had ever seen in person.

It was different than the typical Etherian males that she had seen in textbooks. For one thing it seemed almost... impossibly large, thick at the base, but came to a tapered point at the tip. The color faded from a deep navy blue to a cobalt, darker in some places, almost purple at the tip. The length was...

"I forsee a physical challenge," she winced at just the thought, "from the size and the width, I..."

"You will *adjust*." It sounded less like a promise and more like an order. "Your body is able to pass an infant with a head circumference of 35 centimeters. You may find you even enjoy this."

She glanced down at 828. He had squeezed her thighs a little too hard as he held them open. She didn't understand why until she saw the look on his face. With a start, she realized that she had seen that hunger in his eyes before. At dinner the other night, when Prime had hovered near his mouth. So... lustful.

Her cheeks blazed brighter at the realization, but she had no time to really consider the deep implications. Not now. She would later.

In bed, with her fingers tracing little circles on her clitoris. But now-

"Touch it," he ordered, slipping a second finger inside of her. "I can tell by the way you clenched down on me that you want to. Be my guest, Dear One. Explore. You will come to know me intimately eventually."

He had a point. Lust aside, this was the scientific study of a lifetime! Tears still clinging to her lashes, she bit her lip and carefully traced a single finger along its length. The effect on him seemed immediate. The Emperor growled against her neck and he crooked his fingers inside her.

Several things happened at once. The Princess groaned, loud, arching her back at this new sensation as he touched a nerve she did not even realize she had. Her tiny hand wrapped around his phallus, and at that moment all sense was lost to her. It felt like fireworks, beautiful blossoming sensations in her belly, a fluttering ecstacy.

In the back of her mind, sense was telling her to hate this, that no matter what, it was wrong, that she had not wanted it. And then he rubbed her inner walls again and she was sent to paradise once more. She gently squeezed his hard member, eliciting another growl.

"Careful, Dear one," his low breathy voice warned, "not like that. Stroke. Like- *ah*!"

Entrapta prided herself on being a quick learner. Always able to figure things out. The thrill of discovery was beautiful. As her hand experimentally dragged up and down his shaft, his breathing slowed, he closed two of his eyes, almost as if he were attempting to concentrate on something else. His other two eyes fell between her hand and his clone, still watching with a hungry, adoring expression.

"Dear One, do you want to climax?" He asked with a gentle, yet slightly quivering voice.

He opened his other two eyes and stared directly at her. Something in his gaze made her weak. Nothing about this was right. Her eyes were still wet. She felt violated, humiliated, tormented. This man stole her love, killed him. Then to rub salt in the wound, turned him into... this. And now he...

She looked down at the claws holding her knees apart and realized two things.
First, he had stopped needing to force them open long ago. But more importantly, his hands were shaking. Her eyes found his as he knelt between her legs. He seemed to flicker between being an emotionless doll, and a worshiping slave, but now he looked...

Afraid.

He was afraid, she realized to her own horror. There was a flick in his green eyes, a... glitch? She glanced to Prime, nervous. Had he noticed?

...No. No he hadn't. Right? He didn't seem like he did. Two eyes were closed in, what she assumed, was ecstacy. The other two were hungrily watching her. She moved her hand faster to distract him further.

A breathy, needy growl escaped from the back of his throat as his fingers rubbed her again, again. He seemed to take her eagerness as an answer. Or he simply didn't care if she wanted it or not. Either way, she felt a pressure, a deep sensation, pleasure building. Her eyes screwed shut, and her other hand traveled down between her legs to stroke her swollen, sensitive clitoris. So close.

"Yes. O-oh... yes." she panted breathlessly, despite every instinct telling her not to. It was... all part of the plan, wasn't it?

She felt his smiling lips against her neck, his slick tongue flickered against her pulse in time with her racing heart. His hands worked

her faster and faster, driving her to bliss at a breakneck speed.

"You are... so enthusiastic," he groaned, "don't tire yourself."

He gripped her hand suddenly to stop her wild pumping motions, but before she could question why, he had reached to grip the back of Not-Hordaks head, tangling claws in his silvery-blue hair. The clone released her thighs at last, leaving behind, she noted, faint scratches and light bruises. If he had noticed the damage he was causing her, his pale doll face did not betray it.

Especially now.

All his focus, his devotion, his entire being and sense of self was for his Master. Prime opened one eye to study his clone while the rest of his focus remained on pleasuring his Princess. He graced his servant with the smallest of smiles before guiding his mouth to his still firm and pulsing erection.

Entrapta watched, stunned, horrified.

And if she was being entirely honest, a little aroused by it. *Fascinated*, actually. She couldn't look away. She should be crying, she should be weeping about this horrible situation she found herself in. But as a scientist, the dynamic between these aliens biologically was worth studying. The social behaviors between Prime and his clones, as well as his sexual responses.

If her *own* sexual responses didn't get in the way at least.

It was so hard to focus as his fingers quickly brought her over the edge, clenching his claws hard. Her eyes glazed with a cocktail of lust, need, hate, love. Complex, swirling. Something in his eyes made her want to just give him... *everything*.

As the clone brought his creator to climax, Entrapta was riding the after shocks of her own. Her mind was heavy, foggy, tired. Next to her, The Emperor groaned, arched his back, held the head of his clone to his lap as he rode out what sounded like absolute bliss.

And when it was all over, he nearly collapsed against her, smiling so beautifully as he opened two of his brilliant citrus colored eyes to study her.

And study her he did. Her flushed face, flawed olive skin, the marks he left on her pretty neck. Groaning, he pushed his clone off of him. With an almost comedic pop the Emperors now softening member slipped from 828's thin dark lips.

Entrapta watched the clone as he emotionlessly swallowed and ran a finger along the bottom edge of his lip before rising to his feet to prepare a bath.

"You enjoyed that," the Emperor observed, sliding his fingers out of her and examining them, "you want more. Now that you've had a taste, your body craves it."

"N-no. I didn't want that. I didn't-"

"Mmm..." he opened all four eyes now, smiling serenely, knowingly, "is that so? Perhaps not at first, but at the end? Did you not hear yourself? You were begging for me."

The Emperor glanced behind them at the clone as he poured a sweet smelling oil into the bath.

"Was she not?" He asked the clone, "you heard her too, yes?"

The clone stiffened at being called to and seemed to hesitate before nodding.

"I did hear it," he answered robotically.

"See? And you know he is telling the truth because they are physically incapable of lying."

She tugged her nightgown down over her thighs again, ashamed. She wasn't sure what to believe anymore. It *had* felt really good, after all. Sexual stimulation, particularly with a partner was said to be more enjoyable than solo. It was possible she had simply been

too caught up in the moment to notice. And now that she thought of it, she had never heard Hordak lie, in fact, the very idea of falsifying information had enraged him.

Logically, she knew he *must* be right, and yet her heart refused to admit it.

The Emperor chuckled at her clear embarrassment, running a claw up her back in a way that might have been soothing if she didn't feel so ill.

"You aren't as innocent as I originally assumed," he teased, leaning in to press a light kiss to her forehead, ignoring the discomfort she felt. "I did say I could be a good lover, if you allowed me."

"I *didn't* allow you. Y-you forced me," she whispered shakily, "I didn't ask for any of that. I- he-! You made him hold my legs open..."

The Emperor hummed, leaning in to place a kiss now against her neck. He was still smiling that victorious smile of his.

"Yes. I did," he purred, "and I would do it again. I will do it every time if you resist me. Let it be a lesson, my Dear One. My orders will be followed, one way or another."

A claw went to the hem of her nightgown again and she was terrified he would do it all again. But he simply observed the still bleeding scratches on her thighs with a look of mock pity.

"Imagine how good it might have felt if you just did as I asked the first time?"

Heart beating like a drum, she did her best to steady her breathing. Remain calm. It was hard, impossible. He ran a hand through her hair, tucking it behind an ear.

"Can I have a sample?" She asked suddenly, mind skipping to anything else, *anything* other than the guilt and shame she felt.

"Sample?" He questioned, tilting his head.

"A sperm sample!" She excitedly explained, "I've never had a chance to study H...Hordaks anatomy."
Her voice went weak at His name and she glanced behind her at the clone who was finishing up with the preparations of the bath.
"I, um... I find it fascinating. And... if we're supposed to... procreate, I should find out if we're genetically compatible so we-"

"We *are*," he waved a hand dismissively, "I had my science division look into it already."

"That was fast," she commented, playing with her fingers, "w-well, I just thought..."

"You may have a sample," he relented, but the wicked smile suggested his meaning before he even had to elaborate, "but you will have to get it yourself."

The water stopped running and the Emperor rose to his feet, holding a hand out for her.

"Come. Bathe with me."

Another order. The pain between her legs reminded her to obey. She took his hand, eyes on the floor as she followed, until they walked by 828. He knelt, head lowered, eyes seeming to be intentionally avoiding hers. As she walked by, she could have sworn she saw pink on his cheeks. Was it possible? What could it mean? She wanted to kneel in front of him, touch him, shake him until he yelled at her like Hordak.

The Emperor stopped in front of the bath and held his arms out expectantly. Without a word, the clone stood again and began to pull garments off. Entrapta couldn't help but stare. She wanted to move close, study his body. Every curve of his form, the powerful muscle, beautiful navy hue of his chest, arms, legs, the painted talons on his perfect toes. And they truly *were* perfect. All of him was. Flawless.

She swallowed hard as she watched him step into the deep, warm swirling waters. As he relaxed against the side of the tub, his pale ropes of hair and wire piled itself on top of his head. So much like her own. She wanted to ask about it, but 828 had moved on to undress her now. As his fingers pulled her night clothes off, she murmured an apology. His green eyes snapped up to her and she saw it, *truly* saw it. There was no doubt. A flicker. A glitch.

And then he stepped away, gathering soiled clothing to take them away and bring fresh garments. She stood there for a moment too long, stunned, brain struggling to make sense of what she saw. She couldn't ask. Couldn't even broach the subject. She had no data to work with and everything to lose.

"Dear One..."

She almost jumped, finding the Emperor watching her with all four eyes. His smile had vanished and for a moment, she wondered if she had displeased him somehow. Then he curled his finger, summoning her into the water with him. And she followed like a puppet.

"Beautiful," he breathed, watching her step into the water. Her cheeks burned at the compliment. "Simply breathtaking. Yes. You will be so perfect... once we make a few *adjustements*, of course."

He held a hand out to her and she took it, allowing herself to be pulled against his nude form.

"D-do you want me to...?" she glanced down between them, frightened.

The Emperor laughed at that, placing a gentle hand on her face.

"No, no. Not today. Why? Eager for more, Dear One?" His voice was low, teasing.

And it confused her. He had her bare, open to him. Even now, he was positioning her tiny body like a toy, holding her on his lap, in

the best position to take her. And yet, he was gentle, almost... *cuddling*.

"Relax for a moment with me," he sighed, closing his eyes, "in an hour, we meet with Etherias Queen to finalize our trade."

Entrapta lowered her gaze to her lap, to his large hands slipping across her stomach.

"Trade?" She questioned, automatically, hardly caring anymore for the politics of her situation. Truthfully, Glimmer was the last person she wanted to see.

"Oh yes. If Etheria is to be the new jewel to my Empire, there are a few things that simply must change. All things being considered, your world is getting rather a good deal. I've brought you order and peace. All I ask is a little... cooperation. You *will* cooperate with me, wont you?"

His talons dug slightly into her stomach as he spoke. A warning. In pain, afraid, she simply nodded.

"Good girl." The pressure vanished and he placed a sweet kiss to her cheek. "I think this will be the start of a beautiful relationship."

Magenta

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Entrapta was glad the meeting was mercifully short. It mostly consisted of Horde Prime sitting on his throne, telling Glimmer what she would do for him and her silently accepting it.

Entrapta watched Glimmer nod like a chastised child, but more than once, the other woman gave her tiny apologetic glances. From where Entrapta sat on the Emperors lap, she could not risk trying to say anything or even show that she had noticed.

But *Glimmer* noticed. She had seen it in her eyes, the horror. Entrapta winced as she walked, supported a little too much by her betrothed, the bite on her neck, the bruise on her lip. The implication was clear.

"-Ensure all is made ready by the end of the week. You have five days," Prime sounded bored and waved her off. "That is all. You are dismissed... *Your Majesty*."

Her title sounded almost sarcastic coming from him. Glimmer dipped into a low bow, looking away when Prime began to run his fingers through Entraptas hair as if he were petting a cat. When she straightened up, she met Catras eyes for a moment as the feline stood near the door with her arms crossed. The two nodded and seemed to silently pass message to the other.

Entrapta noticed and for one fearful moment, she thought Prime might notice as well, so she did the only distracting thing she could think of. She grabbed his hand, lacing her fingers through his, pressing it to her face, affectionate, loving, needy. And he seemed to absolutely eat it up. It was something she had noted during her interactions with him. Touch, affection shown of any kind, seemed to absolutely *captivate* him.

Smirking, Prime narrowed all of his eyes and watched 828 as he brought the back of her hand to his lips. The clone, standing off to the side, waiting for his mistress, barely seemed to react, save to a tiny twitch of his fingers.

Catra met her eye while Prime was busy silently gloating. She gestured with a flick of her tail at... something. Entrapta didn't quite get it. She kept flicking from Not-Hordak to Prime, back to her, then over again until Prime turned his full attention back to his betrothed.

"Five days, Dear One," he whispered, close to her ear, although Entrapta had no doubt that in the quiet of the throne room, all present would hear. "Five days. Can you wait? Or shall I visit your bed tonight?"

Entrapta felt her face go bright magenta. Shame, fear and yes, even a little excitement.

"Etherian tradition, uh... s-states that-"

"I know of your ridiculous tradition," he rolled two of his eyes, sighed. "so dull. But what my Emperess wishes, My Empress receives."
His lips pulled back in a wicked green grin.
"Our wedding night will absolutely change your *life*, Dear One."

Something about the way he said that sounded like a threat. Her ravaged womanhood already throbbed painfully from that mornings events. Just recalling any of it sent her spiraling. So instead, she simply hadn't been thinking of it. The instant she was away from him, then she would think about it. Then she would try to process it. For now, it was best to smile, nod and just play pretend.

"I look forward to the experiment- I mean, um, the *experience*."

"Good girl," he purred, placing a quick kiss to the top of her head, "Off you go. I have work to do now."

His claws grasped her hips painfully and he nearly shoved her off of him. Another reminder that she was little more than a play thing to him. She stumbled, but 828 was there at her side at once, arm out to catch her.

"I will visit you in a few hours," the voice of her husband-to-be made her freeze, "*Be ready*."

Entrapta bit her lip, bowed once with 828 at her side and left the Throne room as quickly as she reasonably could. The instant she was out, everything came flooding back like a tide washing in. The morning, his touch, his mouth. His eyes. His eyes were the *worst*. The way he watched her, looking for an excuse to punish her. That's what this was to him, his need for perfection.

He wants a reason to hurt people, she realized suddenly.

Her legs gave out and she sunk to her knees, clutching her stomach. So empty, but the urge to vomit was overwhelming. So many hours of simply smiling and touching. She wanted her gloves. She wanted her mask. She wanted her lab. She wanted her lab partner!

828 knelt in front of her, concern replacing his perfect dolls smile. Lab partner. She looked down at her palm, the word LUVD burned into it. Forever. An imperfection. Why did Prime seem so unbothered by it?

A drop hit the diamond shaped scar, then another. Her shoulders shook.
She couldn't do this. So much pain. He hurt so much. After only 48 hours, she was already addicted to it, felt she deserved every scratch, every bruise. The pain felt... justified.

A hand slid into her open palm. Navy blue, clawed. She almost jerked away, thinking in a panic that the Emperor had pushed his way into her space once more. But... no. This hand was imperfect, flawed. She brought her tear streaked face to the doll, the shell that had once housed her Lab Partner.

He looked surprised by his own actions. His fingers cautiously traced the outline of her scar, brow knitted together. Confused. He looked so very *confused*.

Another flicker in his eyes.

"Hordak...?" She breathed. Cautious. Around them, clones stood at attention guarding the door. But they seemed to have little real thought if their own.

828 blinked, the flickering in his eyes went immediately back to green and the porceline smile returned.

"Princess, we must get you back to your quarters. Much preperation is needed for the Emperors visit!"

He sounded so pleasant, so happy. It still sent shivers down her spine.

"Oh, but..."

He held a hand out to help her back up. In silence, she was once again led back to her pretty pale prison. Locked inside with Him. Her new life now.

The instant the doors were locked, she reached to pull 828 in with her hair, holding him as she wept. She expected him to break too. The way he looked earlier, she'd expected to hold him and somehow break through.

But the experiment seemed to be a failure. He stood rigid, cold. His impassive face didn't even flinch, his smile had not moved.

"Hordak," she wept, "please tell me you're in there. Hordak, Hordak..."

"You have not eaten," he noted, robotically, "it is time for another meal. Would you like something specific?"

"Hordak!" Her fingers dug desperately into his hips and his perfect smile seemed to twitch slightly, "Hordak, stop acting like this! Come back!"

She shook him, violently, desperately. Her eyes were wild, tears flowed freely, leaving dark streaks as the makeup they had put on her smudged. Imperfections clear for the entire universe now.

"Princess, you are upset. I will bring you a calming drin-"

The door opened and both sets of eyes turned to it in fear. That fear did not fade, even as her brain registered that it was not her betrothed in the door way, but instead a female. A beautiful, full figured female. Alien, obviously with skin that reminded Entrapta of the first time she saw the stars. She actually glowed. And as she moved, Entrapta noticed where legs should have been, were tentacles.

Entrapta's hands went limp as she stared and 828 seemed to take that moment to separate himself from her and bow to the woman.

"Your Highness," he greeted, hand over his heart.

The woman blinked her brilliant magenta eyes, then her lips pulled into a radiant grin.

"Darling! You must be Entrapta!"

Entrapta looked at 828 who was still bowing until the female sashayed into the room and touched the back of his neck lightly.

"Up, up, Cutie," she instructed, and 828 did as he was told, straightening up with a perfect smile.

"Uh... should I know you, or...?"

Entrapta was looking to 828 again for assistance. She hadn't met many people here. Mostly she'd spent her time locked in this room or with the Emperor. 828 opened his mouth to make a formal

introduction, but the woman had plucked Entrapta up in her soft arms and held her to her massive overflowing bosom.

Entrapta only struggled for a little while, shifting until she could breathe again. When she was finally released, her dress was crumpled and her hair was frizzy. And she was confused. So very confused.

"I'm Tallulah," she said, "I'm the Emperors sixth wife. But you can think of me like a sister."

Entrapta blinked, once more exchanging a look with 828. He was still smiling, hands folded politely behind his back.

"Uhh... hi. I'm Entrapta. I'm-"

"I know! The entire wives corridor is just buzzing about you! You've got a reputation already!"

The woman bounded across the room, sinking onto a low sofa and motioning for her to follow. Entrapta exchanged a look with 828, eyes pleading, but as usual, he was unhelpful. She sighed and simply did as she was bid. Once she took a seat, Tallulah turned her attention to 828.

"Bring us some drinks, would you dear? And some food. This one looks like she hasn't had a proper meal in days!"

828 bowed to each woman individually before taking his leave. The instant he was out of the room and the door locked behind him, the woman immediately straightened up and turned her full attention to Entrapta.

"Alright. *Spill*."

Entrapta blinked.

"Well? What did he do to you? You lip is a mess, you've been crying your makeup off, you have teeth marks on you neck," she observed, "what did he *do?*"

Entrapta stared for a full thirty seconds, glancing around the room, heart pounding in her throat. It took a moment, but Tallulah got the hint. She laughed.

"Oh don't worry, darling. Your companion isnt here to spy on you anymore and I made mine wait outside. We're alone."

"I know, but..."

"How do you know you can trust me?" She smiled so wide her pretty fuchsia eyes squinted. "You don't. And yet, I'm all you have, sweet little Sister."

Entrapta weighed her options. What could he do if she said anything? Kill her? She already wanted to die. And she wanted to tell someone, she realized. She wanted to spill her heart out. She wanted to let every hurt she had suffered at his hands be known.

And so with a torrent of tears, she did. She confessed as if she were under a truth spell. She described every sordid act, every way he made her feel small and powerless. The way he forced Horda- 828 to help him violate her.

She even confessed to *enjoying* it.
That was the worst part.

By the time every bitter moment had been revealed, Talullah had her arms around her again. She patted her back, gentle, motherly almost. Entrapta... was unfamiliar with this sort of touch. She closed her eyes, breathing shakily, sobbing.

"What has gotten into that man?" Entrapta heard her mumble, "he's forgotten his manners. I should have a talk with him. Remind him how to treat a Lady."

Entrapta squirmed out of her fluffy embrace. Eyes wide with panic.

"You can't! He'll do worse if he knows I'm not happy. I have to keep smiling. I have to-"

"Entrapta, he's trying to break you. He thinks it makes you a better wife. You want to know a secret? He doesn't hold as much power over you as you think he does. Below the surface? He's a hopeless romantic."

"I... don't understand."

"Surely you've *noticed*? Does he call you a sweet nickname? Stroke your hair, hold you against him?" She laughed, "he pretends to be this detached perfect being, so above it all, so above *us* all. But really? He just wants someone to love him. Not as an Emperor. As a man."

Entrapta frowned, but listened. Any data she could collect would be helpful.

"Cuddles," she continued, "he absolutely *lives* to be cuddled. Oh, and if you need him to do something for you, try to sound as horny as possible when you ask. It keeps his attention. If he invites you somewhere with him, meet his eye a lot. Any eye. He just really likes to know you're paying attention to him. Even if he pretends he doesn't care, he *does*. His image is everything. So stoke his ego. It is so fragile."

Entrapta opened her mouth to ask something, but Talullah seemed to read her mind.

"Your wedding night, right?" The beautiful wife of Prime snickered. "Don't be so afraid. It'll likely hurt, I won't lie to you. Even if you weren't a virgin, he is always too rough the first time. Wants to make sure you're really 'broken in'. But don't worry. The next time, he will be gentle. And when you become pregnant, he is the most loving man. When Zallah was pregnant, he absolutely spoiled her rotten with gifts and attention. "

"Zallah?"

"That's wife number 7. She's been a long time favorite and the one we all honestly thought he would make Empress."

Entrapta looked down at her hands, afraid.

"Oh! Don't worry about her! Zallah isn't likely to try to hurt you. She's always been good to the new wives. And she's not the jealous type."

Entrapta let out the breath she was holding.

"It's Aleiz and Ajna you need to look out for. Those two are his newest wives. Twins. And they will sell your secrets to Prime for a pat on the head. Also stay away from wife number 9. Rawnie. Shes convinced that she's the only one that's Empress material because she used to be Queen of some asteroid belt or something. And she will *absolutely* poison you if you give her the chance."

Entrapta felt like she should be writing this down. Her head was spinning. She wished she had her recorder.

"Don't worry. I'll point them out to you at the wedding. Most of the other women are very sweet and helpful. You can trust the older ones. They've seen it all. Most of us didn't choose this, you know."

Entrapta blinked back tears again and had opened her mouth to ask if Talullah had chosen, but it was at that moment that 828 reappeared with a large tray with small sandwiches and... fizzy drinks. When he set the tray down on the low glass table, Entrapta couldn't pull her eyes away from him. She had made her prefrence for tiny foods clear, but the fizzy drinks had not been brought up. How did he know?

Wordlessly, he poured a drink in two glasses and set them in front of the women.

"Thank you dear," Talullah purred, "Entrapta, your Companion is so cute! You should tell him he's cute more."

Entrapta actually blushed and pulled her knees to her chest in the pristine white chair she sat in.

"Did I embarrass you, Dear? I'm sorry. Our companions are meant to be playthings as well as slaves. But as much as they act like mindless drones, they do have hearts. Be kind to them. Trust me."

She winked at Entrapta and drained her glass before rising to her... tentacles.

"I should be going. You have an Emperor to prepare for and *you*-" she sighed and turned her attention back to 828 who was smiling, standing at attention against the wall, "you need to take better care of her. You're supposed to be her friend."

828 bowed as the Emperors wife walked by.

"I will visit again soon, if that's alright, Dear."

Entrapta nodded, but still remained seated with her knees to her chest.

"Excellent! See you soon!"

The instant she was gone, 828 was by her side once again.

"You need to eat," he said once more, "Then we must make preparations for Emperor Prime."

Despite the gnawing, emptiness in her stomach, Entrapta couldn't bring herself to touch anything. Even her fizzy drink remained undisturbed. Stubbornly, she shook her head.

The clone... *frowned*. Why he cared so much was obvious. This was his mistress. Seeing after her needs and wants was his job. It pleased his creator and pleasing Horde Prime was his entire reason for existing.

But it went deeper. It wasn't just seeing her attempt to starve herself that was nagging at him. It was seeing her unhappy at *all*. She was unhappy and it made him... unhappy? Was he *allowed* to

be unhappy? His existence felt so confusing, ever since he had been assigned to her.

"Please eat," he picked up a tiny sandwich and attempted to place it in her hand. She turned her face away and knocked it down with a tendril of hair.

A new feeling was present now. Frustration.

"You *must* eat. If you do not, He will order me to force you."

Her stomach growled loudly and his perfect, porcelain composure was cracking.

"*Entrapta*!"

Her eyes widened, she gasped, looking up. Familiar. The tone, the way he said her name. She brought her sparkling magenta eyes up to meet his with a smile.

And 828 was utterly lost. His cheeks felt hot, his fingers twitched. Why did he suddenly feel the urge to say her name again? He wasn't supposed to use her name. It was improper. Titles only. But it had made her so happy when he used her name. Was his purpose not to make her happy? How ever that may be?

"Entrapta," he said again, gentler this time, "Eat. Please. I do not want to hurt you."
He held another sandwich out for her, looking away. In shame, he realized.
"Not again."

She took the sandwich from his hand, but did not raise it to her lips. Not yet.

"You didn't wanna do that," she ventured quietly, "did you?"

The clone took a deep breath and stood back up.

"What I want is immaterial. I am in service to my Emperor."

"But what he made you do-"

"I... I did not... if I could have found another way, I would have," he eventually settled on, "I hurt you. I am truly sorry for that."

"But what about what *he* did to *you*? What he *made* you do to him?" She asked, "is that... normal?"

The clone went rigid, opened his mouth to speak, but closed it again.

"Please eat," he said again, "I must find you a proper outfit."

He watched her with two sad green eyes until she took a bite, a tiny one. It was enough. He vanished in that locked room that stored clothing and when he was out of sight, she finished an entire sandwich. Not much food considering it was a tiny one, but it was more than she had eaten all day. It was enough to calm her stomach some and when he returned with yet another white gown, she was much better prepared to do what she had to do.

She allowed 828 to lead her to the vanity table and adjust her makeup again, giving her a flawless complexion and even disguising the bruise on her lip some. Once she was presentable, she let 828 strip her and dress her, no longer truly caring if he saw her nude anymore after the events of that morning. When she saw her reflection again she looked... different. Not at all like herself.

828 opened a box and pulled out a heavy silver necklace with a large citron green jewel in the center. He held it up to her neck and clasped it

"A gift from your Emperor," he explained, "the rarest jewel in the Universe. He wants you to wear this to the wedding as well."

Entrapta felt like it would pull her right off of her feet with its weight. It was heavy. She had seen this jewel before. On the Emperors bracers. If a small one was this heavy, she imagined those two were equally so.

"The jewel can be found only on a single planet in one mountain," he continued, "His first wife had been Queen of the planet these jewels came from. When he married her, he took the Jewel as his symbol."

"Oh. Won't she be angry if I wear this?"

"Unlikely," 828 continued, applying a touch more color to her lips, "she died nearly fifty years ago in a rebel attack."

Entrapta nodded slowly, eyes on her reflection.

"There's so much I don't know here," she sighed.

"You will learn," 828 assured her. He lowered the lip color he had been using on her and seemed to be studying her for an uncomfortably long time. Finally he managed to breathe out, "you're beautiful."

Before Entrapta could question or even comment, he was moving again, cleaning up the room, putting things away, removing food trays and resetting the room back to a state of perfect cleanliness.

"It is nearly time. We should have you sit here," he motioned to a high backed white chair beside the bed, but then seemed to reconsider, "or... no. Here."

The clone seemed nervous as he grabbed the chair and repositioned it, setting it down in the middle of the room.

"Yes. Here." He decided, "please sit and wait."

"Why are you staging me for a visit from my husband?"

The clone seemed to take a deep breath, then gave her a pretty, patient smile.
"He likes people to wait for him."

Oh.
That was a vague answer and she found it frustrating. She wanted to know more. She wanted real reason behind the insane rituals she was expected to follow.

"So I... wait? All day? Hoping he'll come visit me?"

The clone looked almost scandalized by that.

"Oh, *no.* Of course not. But it does help to keep up appearances this early in your..." he hesitated, looking away, "relationship."

Before Entrapta could ask another question, the door slid open and 828 positioned himself behind her chair with another plastic smile and a bow.

"My Dear One," Emperor Prime greeted with an emerald smile, "I hope you were not waiting long."

Entrapta opened her mouth to reply that she hadn't, but 828 held a hand out to help her out of her chair, reminding her to do something that did not come naturally.
Strech the truth to the breaking point.

"*Too* long," she replied, forcing herself to smile as she took 828's hand and rose to her feet. A slightly awkward moment passed where Prime scanned her, eyes roving in 3 different directions before all finally settling on her face. He smiled his approval.

"You look nearly radiant, my dear!" He complemented. Or *almost* complemented. It was the 'nearly' part that stuck out to her.

Talullah's advice fresh in her mind, she made her move. Her little feet hurried across the room and she wrapped her arms around his middle, burying her face in his bare chest. Touch. He responded well to touch. That was the theory, anyway. Her working hypothesis. Previous studies and peer research suggested this to be fact.

More research required.

Slowly, strong arms snaked around her and he pulled her close against him. Chuckling.

"My, my," he purred, reaching down to her chin to lift it with one claw, "shall we stay in, then? Or do you want to see the surprise I have for you?"

Surprise. She wasn't certain she liked his surprises. He was impossible to trust. But his tone didn't seem... sinister?
He pulled away from her, smiling in a way that seemed almost genuine.

"What's the surprise?" She asked, blinking up at him.

"Come, Dear One. I think you will like this."

She did. She liked it so much it almost made the past 48 hours worth it. Almost.

"Well?" He chuckled as she stepped into the large, pristine white lab, "is it satisfactory?"

Satisfactory? Entrapta had equipment, space, materials, computers and absolutely every convenience her heart could possibly desire here. If Hordaks Sanctum was a 1, this was an 11.

She *loved* it! And still, she missed Hordaks sanctum. The sanctum was safe, secure. It was freedom and love and personality.

This was just... sterile.

She turned back to The Emperor with a wide excited grin. She was getting better at this, pushing everything down for the sake of survival.

"Is it... is it really *mine*?" She asked softly.

The Emperor nodded.
"828-1075 informed me that you were feeling a bit... bored. I do hope this alleviates some of that."

Entrapta glanced to 828 who met her gaze with a steady, but firm nod. She didn't understand. He... lied to the Emperor? No, not *lied*. Simply withheld information, twisted the facts a little. But it was enough.

Why would he do something like that? Something so dangerous? If Prime found out he would erase him again, or worse. He must have known that. And yet, he still did it. For her.

"Thank you," she said out loud, hoping 828 would understand it was thanks meant for him, "it's so wonderful. I'm really happy."

Primes face did something she had never seen before. His face held an almost boyish shyness, a near magenta blush on sharp cheekbones. He stared at her for a long while with all four eyes, then as if suddenly remembering where he was and who he is, he cleared his throat and crossed the white tile to stand directly in front if her.

"It is as I said. I can give you anything you desire. All you must do is comply."

He reached again to her chin, guiding her face up again. He leaned in, mouth hovering so close to hers.

"What do you need me to do?" She whispered, shivering as his crisp cool breath ghosted over her lips.

"Something only you can, my Dear One," he whispered back, lacing his hands through her hair.

"You mean... the...?"

He pressed a deep kiss to her bruised lips, tongue lashing out to attack her own. Then as quick as it came, he pulled away with a victorious smile.

"Mmm, yes. The Heart of Etheria."

Chapter End Notes

Special shout out to ForestFairyUnicorn for letting me use her OC, Talullah. I hope I did her justice. Shes so fun.

Blue

Chapter Summary

TW- explicit male penetration, clone fucking, dubious consent

"Please be careful. That's very delicate."

Entrapta stood in the middle of her new lab, directing a team of clones. Her fiance had given them to her as "assistants", but if she was being honest, one of Hordak was more than ten of these drones.

She eyed 828, who was carefully soldering something at a workbenches behind her. As he carefully worked, it reminded her so much of Hordak. Days spent together working in silence or in conversation. But no matter what, they were together. That was the important thing. Partners. Equals.

Not... *this*.

"Your Highness," 828 said, setting his tools down and removing the safety equipment she had insisted he wear, "it is time for us to go over your lessons again."

"Again?" She groaned, looking around the lab, "but didn't we just do this?"

"That was *yesterday*, Princess," 828 offered her his arm and she took it automatically, "your wedding is only three days away. There is much to do. We must get you cleaned up as well. In an hour you also have your dress fitting. Then after that, Emperor Prime would like to visit with you. I've already told him you accept-"

"What?!"

828 blinked at her and she couldnt help but notice the blue from his hair, although nearly gone, still clung to the ends. In this pure

white hell, blue was quickly becoming her favorite color.

"You can not refuse a request from your Emperor," he responded flatly, "not without angering him."

Entrapta growled in frustration. Her time in her lab was always too short. But at least she had it. It was something. A little slice of heaven in this hell.

"Why does he even bother asking, if I'm not allowed to refuse him?"

828 did not answer. In the last two days, he had developed, what Entrapta called, *sass*. He always did what he could for her, of course. A perfect servant, keeping her in order. Keeping her clean and organized and keeping her room spotless and ready for an Imperial visit at a moments notice. But he also kept her grounded, focused, with a little but of attitude.

He was the closest thing to a friend she had here. And it still hurt every second she looked at him.

"What is the first thing you do when you enter a room?" 828 quizzed as Entrapta bathed.

"Uh... look for my husband?" She guessed.

"Who is...?" The clone sounded as if he were barely keeping his patience.

"The Emperor?"

"The highest ranking individual in the room," he answered for her with a sigh, "by default, he is going to be at the top of the social hierarchy everywhere you go, and if you enter a room with him, you are automatically at his social rank. Luckily for you, he is also the *only* person who is ranked higher than you so he is the only one you must remember to bow to."

"Uh huh," she yawned, "but what if I'm walking with you? Do I take your social rank, or do you take mine?"

"As a clone, I would ordinarily bow to everyone by default. However, as your companion, I am allowed to adopt *your* social rank when I am with you. Regardless, however, I am meant to be treated as a tool, not a person. So more often than not, I will simply be ignored."

Entrapta frowned. She didn't like this system. She had only been here a few days now, but the urge to break the social hierarchy was absolutely evident.

"When it comes to the wedding feast, when are you allowed to begin eating?" He asked preparing a warm towel for her.

"Uhh... " she rose from the scented water, grabbing the towel with her hair, "I guess when someone tells me to?"

828 winced.

"We have a *lot* of work to do, and only three more days to do it," he seemed annoyed at her as she stepped out of the tub wrapped in a warm towel. "Are you certain you are a princess? Was basic etiquette not taught to you?"

"Rude," she sniffed, long wet hair wringing itself out, "I just had more important things to do!"

"Entrapta, this is not a game," he was using her name again. Dangerous if anybody but her knew. "If the wedding is not perfect, there will be consequences. For both of us. He may hurt you and I will be reconditioned."

Entrapta froze, fear running up her spine. It wasnt the idea of her husband hurting her. That was something she'd just accepted. No. It was the idea of losing *him* again. 828 wasn't quite Hordak, but it seemed like he was getting closer to breaking through by the day. If she could just get her hands on his crystal again-

"S... so, when am I allowed to start eating at the wedding feast?"

The clone looked relieved that she was suddenly taking this seriously.

"As soon as the Emperor takes the first bite. Now, let's practice your vows. Do you remember what we went over this morning?"

"Big smile, straight back. Look at him constantly," she recited, then moved on to her vows, "To you I swear my undying love and loyalty. As my Emperor, I will obey and worship. As my husband, I will adore and cherish. The stars will not shine and the Universe will not spin unless you are beside me. From this moment until my last, I belong to you alone."

Entrapta... hated her vows. The possessiveness of them, the arrogance. To belong to someone. To be property. And to be pleased with that fact? It was awful.

"Very good," he complemented, "but you forgot to put emphasis on Adore and Cherish. Imagine saying this to..."

He trailed off, mind seeming to seize. Glitch. His eyes twitched and then he was back, smiling a porceline smile again. This happened a lot. The second it seemed like he would break through. He went back to being a doll.

"Let me assist with your makeup, Princess. The dressmakers will be in to do adjustments on your wedding garb soon."

Entrapta sighed, defeated as she sat at the vanity. Silently, she let the clone that she had loved with all her heart, do a makeup trial for her wedding. She wanted to laugh at the absurdity, but if she thought too hard, she was sure to cry again.

Two hours later, Entrapta found herself staring at a complete stranger in the mirror. The dressmakers on The Velvet Glove knew their trade, that was without question. But... it just didn't *feel* right.

The low neckline, the skirt that opened to her upper thigh, strange opalescent fabric that glittered like a thousand seashells... none of it was very her at all. And they kept trying to style her hair in uncomfortable ways. In the end, they had settled on a simple twisting braid woven on top of her head.

"You look..." 828 almost said beautiful, but caught himself, the two alien dressmakers eyeing him suspiciously, "*satisfactory*. The Emperor is on his way to give his final notes."

"The Emperor...?" She questioned, "but it's bad luck to see-"

"An Etherian superstition, Princess," the clone gently reminded her, "it means nothing here. The Emperor must personally complete the inspection of a wife before a public appearance. You should expect the same thing before we visit *any* world."

Entrapta hated this. She hated the entire process. She hated standing around like a doll to be dressed up and critiqued and powdered and painted. She hated the ceremony of it. In the Fright Zone there was never any of this. Hordak never cared if people saw her with oil on her face or dust in her hair. He just cared that she worked with him. They'd been such a team...

She sniffled at the memory, catching herself just before her eyes overflowed. She hoped nobody noticed, but 828 did. That made it worse. As if anticipating the flood of emotion, he rushed forward, dabbing her eyes with a clean white cloth.

"Makeup," he mumbled, "it took a long time to get the liner just right."

"S-sorry," she whispered and once more, she swallowed the emotion.

"Overwhelmed with joy *already*, Dear One?"

He was here. If course he was. He couldn't just knock like a normal man, could he? He had to make an entrance.

She turned slightly to smile at him over her shoulder, but he was not smiling back. 828 seemed to notice as well. She saw him stiffen just before dropping to a knee. Entrapta had nearly forgotten to bow as well. *Nearly*.

"This is the dress?" He sounded disappointed, "I suppose for a *Princess* it will do..."

He crossed the room, sweeping by both dress makers and 828, keeping them on their knees as he reached for Entrapta. She winced, afraid of what he might do. Then a soft hand caressed her cheek and she opened her eyes to find him smiling.

"But you will not be a Princess anymore. You will be an *Emperess*."

Two of his eyes snapped to the older of the two dress makers. He snapped and they hurried to his side.

"Make it again. Longer train, I think. And the collar should be wider. I cant have the jewel getting lost in the fabric. It is my symbol, after all."

The alien seemed to let out a breath they were holding, relaxing- too soon. A claw snatched them by the face, pulling them close to a seam on her shoulder.

"And *this*- look at your stitch length. Unacceptable. Sloppy. Do it again. And have it finished by tomorrow."

He let them go and they tumbled to the floor, apologizing and bowing. Horde Prime was not finished yet. He eyed her makeup and hair next.

"Hair- no. It's too heavy on top. Take it down. Half up, half down. Leave it loose. She looks more... innocent."

828 moved to do just that, but Entrapta untangled her hair herself, letting it fall down her back in voluminous lavender waves. The Emperor nodded, approvingly.

"The makeup is acceptable," he decided, "now, get this off of her and get to work."

The two aliens wordlessly began to strip the now trembling Princess. Once the dress was removed, 828 moved in at once to throw a robe over the white slip she wore protecting her from the Emperors leering gaze. A split second too late.

"Leave," he ordered in a soft but commanding tone. 828 bowed and made for the door to follow the dressmakers outside, but the Emperor held a hand up. "*You* stay. Wait for further instructions."

Entrapta met the eyes of the clone for a split second and the look on his face made her blood run cold. He looked sad and apologetic. Like he knew what was coming.

"Dear One," the Emperor placed a hand on her cheek, guiding her face to his. A soft kiss greeted her, minty and cool. And sweet.

She was so confused. Why did 828 look so scared? It was only kissing and if she was being honest, she liked it. Oral touch was plesant, generally.

Yesterday he kissed her like this too, just before it was time to sleep. He had come by for a visit unannounced after she had already changed into her night clothes, but only stayed long enough to place a sweet kiss on her lips. Then he left.

The Emperor pulled away after a moment and ran a hand through her hair, looking at it like it was the first time he had seen it. And that was nice too. She was beginning to think Talullah did speak to him. Maybe this would be alright for her? Maybe she could learn to adjust to this new normal?

Then he clutched her hair and pulled her to bare her neck for him and she realized at once what 828 was afraid of. The clones all seemed to have a connection to him, like bees in a hive and they all seemed to almost instinctively know what their "queen" wanted. Possibly a pheromone reaction? More data was needed.

He pressed his mouth against the warm flesh at her neck, kissing, sucking, licking. It was not unenjoyable. She imagined in a sexual situation. She might even welcome such stimulation. But-

Oh, she realized immediately, *that's that this is. He is trying to initiate sexual intimacy.*

She pulled away quickly, shaking her head.

"My Love, what-?"

"Get on the bed. I will have you. *Now*."

The sound in his voice startled her. So much need, so much want. Every syllable weighed heavy with desire. It almost hurt to hear.

She pulled away, stepped back.

"Please, you promised," she begged, "our wedding night-"

"Oh my Dear One..." he sighed, snatching her wrist in his claw, "I promised that my *Emperess* may have her way. You are not my Emperess yet. Not until we marry."

She looked from his hand on her wrist, to his lustful gaze. He was going to do it. She was so sure. She glanced at 828, eyes pleading, but he was not looking her. He was looking anywhere but her as she was led to the bed.

Heart pounding like a war drum, her mind raced. She supposed it wouldn't exactly matter if they did this now or at the wedding, since the wedding now seemed like an inevitability at this point. Was it better to just get the hard part over so she could focus better on her wedding day? So she won't spend the day afraid?

But then, what about what Talullah said? About him "breaking" her in?

"B-but my ovulation cycle isn't at its peak. Chances of successful fertilization are only 5%."

"I don't *care*," he hissed, mouth close to her neck, "we can do this as often as it takes."

"B-but..."

The Emperor pushed her to sit on the bed.

"Lay back. Spread your leg. That is an order."

There was a dripping danger to his voice that reminded her of that one morning. The bruises on her thighs reminded her that in this case, obedience was the wisest option. She lay back, head on the pillows. She turned her head away as her eyes overflowed again. The instant she felt his cold hands on her thighs, she let them fall open.

Kneeling on the bed between her knees, she heard the rustle of clothing, the jingle of metal.

"Sire!"

Both Entrapta and the half dressed Emperor looked up at the clone. He looked unsure for a moment before he spoke up.

"Etherian law will not recognize your marriage if..."

He trailed off, the glare the Emperor gave him could freeze the sun. The clone knelt, looking at the floor.

"Forgive me. I was out of turn."

The Emperor growled under his breath and placed both hands on her knees. She was so sure he would hurt her now, but instead, he gently drummed his fingers, humming to himself.

"Is this so?" He asked Entrapta gently, tilting his head.

She nodded. It was... in some kingdoms of Etheria. Not Brightmoon. Not Dryl either. Not many places. But there were

small kingdoms that held that tradition. It wasn't a lie... exactly.

The Emperor did not look angry, simply disappointed. He sighed, his hands sliding up her thighs.

"I can not risk my marriage being seen as invalid..." he seemed to be seriously considering a work around as he pressed a soft kiss to her inner thigh. His hair cables came alive, slithering along her bare flesh. Entrapta gasped, involuntarily bucking her hips. He was grinning as he did so again, trailing a finger lower until he could slide his middle finger into her soft wetness. Under him, she groaned, chest heaving. Another kiss was given to her smooth thigh, then another as he slowly pushed the digit in and out, lips working their way slowly to her core.

And Entrapta wanted it. Or at least, a part of her did, so desperately. His face between her thighs made her weak. If she closed her eyes, she could imagine he was Hordak.

She'd fantasized about this, about *him*. She imagined him kissing his way up her thigh while she sat with knees apart on his throne. She'd touched herself at night, playing over the mental imagine of his tongue sliding over her and she lay prone on a work bench.

Entrapta opened her eyes and looked to the side where 828 was watching impassively. She *wanted* him. She realized that with a start. She wanted him panting, deep inside her. She wanted him to groan her name and kiss her neck. She wanted him to do everything her betrothed would do. And more.

He wasn't her Hordak. Not yet. But he was *lightyears* closer than the man currently hovering over her would ever be.

His breath tickled her warm, swollen clitoris and she could feel his tongue extend, pausing a millimeter away. Suddenly he pulled back, slid his finger out and looked down at his blushing bride with a wicked grin.

"I am sorry, my Dear One," he seemed to moan. Panting, heart fluttering like a cage of butterflies, she watched him as he

snapped his finger, inviting 828 to come near the bed. Wordlessly, he held his hand out. The finger that still shone with her essence was extended for him and the clone silently took it into his mouth, lapping the taste of her up as if it were the sweetest thing he had ever experienced.

The Emperor pretended not to even notice and as he pulled his hand back, his clone let out an audible groan, blank green eyes once more heavy with lust.

"I know, I *know*," the Emperor groaned again, climbing up her body to settle himself teasingly between her hips. "You want it. You are *so* ready, aren't you?"

He leaned in to kiss her neck again, hard. Entrapta groaned, but as she had learned, it was best to just allow him to do as he wished.

"You want so badly to fuck someone, don't you? Would you even settle for *him*?"

He reached up suddenly, hands clasped around her throat. Not hard, not enough to steal breath, but the threat was there. He could break her in an instant if he wanted. He forced her face to look at the clone. Their eyes locked and as she opened her mouth to deny it, his movements made her hiss, tears pricking her eyes again.

He was pressing the tip of his erection against her dripping opening, threatening to penetrate. It was taking every ounce of his self control not to just take her then and there. To hell with this hideous little planet. If they gave him trouble, he could wipe them all out in moments.

No. He was an Emperor. He had restraint. His image was... vital. Groaning, he pulled away just a little, sliding his length teasingly up her dripping slit. Oh, she was so wet and open to him already and the way her body quivered under him was so delightfully charming.

"Perhaps we can both still have some fun, my Dear One," he purred.

Two eyes snapped to the clone while the others focused on her, noting with satisfaction at the way her hips rolled against him as he teased her. When he pulled away, he could have SWORN he heard her whine.

"828-1075," he called, breaking away entirely, "your mistress requires your assistance."

In her haze of lust, Entrapta almost didn't hear what her Emperor had said. *Almost*. But when she opened her eyes, it was not Prime that she saw settling between her legs, but the clone. Every inch of her knew this was wrong. He was not her Hordak, no matter how she wanted to pretend. But when she met his eyes, the hungry way he looked at her, the desire, the lust, her guilt drained some. This was alright to want. Because he wanted it too.

Right?

His breath hitched just before he lowered his mouth to her sensitive womanhood. The instant the contact was made, she was shattered. Everything she had ever known was a lie. Her entire universe was laid out before her eyes. A thousand billion stars and none of them were half as brilliant as this feeling.

His tongue flicked against her clitoris and she writhed, fingers lacing in his silvery blue hair. She moaned and gasped and whispered. And she *forgot*. For a few precious moments, she forgot about the most powerful man in the Universe, watching on the other side of the bed with a smirk.

He took in the state of her. Flushed skin, wild hair, fingers lost in the blue of his defective clone. If she loved *that*, she was going to absolutely lose her mind with an Emperor. His fingers wrapped around his member and he carefully dragged his hand along its length in time with her panting.

"Princess, does this feel good?" He purred, using his other hand to caress her cheek. Against his large blue claw, she looked impossibly tiny. He'd never taken the time to notice, never bothered to really consider. It wasn't a negative, in fact, he found her small size to be a bit of an advantage. Next to her he looked like a giant- in every sense of the word.

Eyes screwed shut against the building pleasure, she nodded.

"Excellent," he purred guiding her face, "now it is my turn. Wet it."

She opened her eyes at his instruction, but before she had a moment to work through the fog in her brain, he was guiding his erection to her lips. She wanted to tell him it was too big. She opened her mouth to do so, but as she did, he gave her no choice.

With an almost adorable 'Mmph!' he shoved the tip of his manhood between her lips. For the briefest moment their eyes met, all of them. Then he moved his hand around to the back if her head and gently rocked his hips.

She shut her eyes as tears clung to her lashes and she moaned. Pleasure or pain, he did not care. She served a purpose to him at that moment, nothing more.

Her tongue flicked the tip as he fucked her mouth and for a moment, just an instant, he considered ending it right there. Giving in to pleasure, supplying the requested sample and depositing it down her throat. She licked him again, taking him into her small mouth so that she nearly gagged. She was trying so hard it was almost... endearing.

"Oh... Dear One," he allowed himself to groan, "you are doing so well..."

Around his penis, he felt her smile. He opened his lower eye to peak at her and it nearly sent him reeling.

"Enough," he sighed blissfully, "I want to hear your voice when you climax."

Hand still cradling the back on her head, he reluctantly pulled out. Her lips, now healed from earlier bruising, looked red and wet in a way that made him want to pin her down and fuck her throat to completion. But he was an Emperor, a God among the lesser beings of the Galaxy. He was above such crass behavior.

He touched the end of his manhood slightly, running a finger along the slippery wet saliva she had left behind. Normally when he did this, he preferred a more substantial lubricant. Well... he would make do with what he had.

Wordlessly, he moved behind his clone who was still busily pleasuring the Princess. There was no exchange of words, no announcing his intentions. And the clone seemed to already know what was happening. He raised his hips for his Emperor, moaning excitedly into Entraptas dripping womanhood.

The Emperor penetrated him with a breathy growl of ecstasy. His clones were made to be disposable, used, abused and tossed aside when they were no longer useful. Wives were a little less disposable, of course, so he was gentler with them. It was why, if he wanted purely pleasure, he would seek out a clone instead. And at this moment, pleasure was all he wanted.

Entrapta balled her hand up in a tight fist, pulling 828's pale blue hair. Her body shook with absolute ecstasy. Between her legs, her Companion panted as he once more brought her to another ground shattering orgasm. How many now? 3? She couldnt think straight. She gasped and arched her back, pressing his tongue deep as she rode out the waves of perfect pleasure.

As she cried out in orgasmic delight, Prime felt himself near his end. His hips slammed into his imperfect rebellious clone. Oh yes, it felt so good, this punishment. To violate him, humiliate him in front of the woman he had loved enough to want to leave... ah, the only thing that would make it better would be their wedding

night. He would force him to watch, he'd decided. Memory or not, The Emperor had felt it in his thoughts. This imperfect clone was in there somewhere and still so in love.

How. Dare. He.

Snarling, he pulled out just as he hit his peak of pleasure. His cock pulsed, sending ribbons of his seed shooting through the air to splat across the back of the clone. Prime grinned wickedly, panting as he came down from that glorious high.

"That was satisfactory..." he murmured, collapsing on the bed next to her, tired. All he wanted to do was fall asleep, hold her to his chest, nuzzle her. He opened one eye to find her running her hands through pale blue hair, while his clones head rested on her stomach.

Like a *lover*.

Three more eyes popped open and the Emperor cleared his throat. Not angrily, exactly, but annoyed. *Deeply* annoyed.

"828-1075, you are no longer required at the moment. Clean up and bring us refreshments when you are finished."

828 jerked away from the Princess at once, face a mask of guilt, followed by regret and then, when he finally managed to rise to his feet, pain. Physical pain. His Emperor was not gentle with him.

"And-" 828 froze as he began to flee the room, "I will speak to you *tonight*."

The clone bowed, face perfectly impassive, hidden. He did not look at the Emperor or Entrapta. Shame? Entrapta had the distinct impression shame was a factor. The instant he was out the door, she found herself gathered in her Emperors large strong arms and she was forced to turn all her attention once more to her betrothed.

Awkwardly, she traced her hands up his perfect blue biceps as he held her from behind, nuzzling her shoulder. He purred into her hair like a feline in heat, whispering sleepily in a language she did not understand.

"What?" She asked, momentarily breaking him from his almost drunken worshiping.

"Apologies," he whispered in Etherian common, "I said your hair feels like stardust."

Silence. Confusion. What did that mean? Was it a complement? She would take it that way.

"Uh... thanks?" She ventured and he sleepily nodded against her neck.

"Cover us," he ordered, voice soft and distant, "lay with me for a few hours."

How could she refuse? Physically? He had her practically pinned down and even with her hair there would be no prying him away. Struggling slightly and causing the Emperor to hiss in annoyance, she shifted to pull the covers up over them. As he settled back against her, he sighed in contentment.

"Talullah said you liked to cuddle," she pointed out, shifting to look up at him as he held her to his chest, "she was right."

He opened two eyes to look down at her, frowning.

"I do not 'cuddle'," he mumbled, "I am simply... claiming my territory."

The way he said it reminded her so much of Hordak, including the pink on his high cheekbones and the way he looked away.
'I have never been in a tizzy.'

"...Talullah came to visit you?" He questioned, voice soft and gentle.

"Mmm... she was very nice," Entrapta replied, tracing fingers along his bare arms, "If I'm being honest, I was really lonely. Its nice to have someone just be *nice* to me without asking me for something."

"Have others been unkind to you?" He shifted now, face hovering above hers, "I will see to it. Give me names."

The Princess wanted to throw his name in his face, but she resisted. After everything he put her through, he wanted to pretend to care? Still, she smiled and reached up to touch his cheek with, what she hoped, was an adoring smile.

"Aww, you worried about me?"

Prime grasped her hand in his and brought the scar on her palm to his lips.

"I do not *worry*," he purred, "I am simply looking out for your reputation. And mine. If someone shows disrespect to my bride, they show disrespect to me."

Oh. That was it. Entraptas smile did not fade, but the shine in her eyes dulled.

"Oh. Of course."

She would be lying if she said she wasn't disappointed. She knew better. But a small optimistic speck inside of her had hoped to find the tiniest bit of genuine love in him somewhere. She'd accepted that she would have to marry him, but she thought perhaps they might find a way to love each other. Or at least show a genuine fondness. It would be hard, considering everything, but it was either that or hate every minute of the rest of her life.

"I feel I must remind you, Dear One," he sighed, laying back to once again wrap her in his arms, "that your companion is not meant to be your lover."

That took her by surprise somewhat.

"I never thought he was."

"Good," he whispered close to her ear. His voice sounded like a snake, soft, hissing. "Because, if I catch you holding him like that again, I won't just erase him. I will *kill* him."

"Holding-? Wha-? I was just-"

He squeezed her tight to his chest.

"You belong to me." He ran his hand up her throat, long fingers curling around her windpipe from behind, but not squeezing. "Never let yourself forget that, My Dear One."

He let go of her throat with a sigh and a kiss to the top of her head.

"I'm... yours," she repeated shakily, staring at the scar on her open palm, "I won't forget."

Yellow

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The Emperor sat upon his throne, gazing out at billions of conquered worlds. For hundreds of years, he had done the same thing. Conquest, judgement, maybe take a wife, husband, other, maybe not, move along, rinse, repeat.

What had changed? The answer was clear. And he was kneeling at the base of the dias.

Horde Prime turned at last to face the clone. He had kept him kneeling there for nearly a half hour now while he really considered what he would do. The poor creature. It wasn't his fault, not really. It was the fault of a flaw, a glitch in his systems. That's all it was. A sickness in the body of his perfect Empire.

Well, a literal sickness as well. The Horde *could* cure him, theoretically. Perhaps if he proved to be loyal, despite his precarious position... no. Even then, Horde Prime would be wasting resources curing a clone who could so easily be replaced in a moment. He was just a companion. A pet now. Not a general.

Wordlessly, Prime rose from his throne and stepped down the dias with a grace that had taken hundreds of years to perfect. As his steps approached the clone shivered.

"Little Brother," he purred, looking down on him with the smile of a God about to grant forgiveness. "Rise."

828 looked up and the instant he saw the smile, all of his worries seemed to drain. The poor fool. Emperor prime reached down to his chin guiding him up from his knees.
828 leaned into his touch like a dying man in a desert offered life giving water. Prime touched his cheek, ran a talon over his sharp,

angular cheek bones, flawed flesh. The clone sighed and relinquished what little hold on his own thoughts he had. Like a lamb to the slaughter.

The Emperor placed his other hand on his cheek, all eyes drifting shut as he probed his thoughts. This was always a tricky endeavor. If he wasn't careful, he might let his own personal thoughts slip. It had happened once with another clone. He'd been disposed of very quickly. A shame. He had been a perfect servant too.

The clones emotions flooded into his masters mind, a thousand stray thoughts, harmless on their own. Even a perfect being like the Emperor could not always control his own stray thoughts. How could he expect a puppet to do the same?
But it was when those stray thoughts gathered, formed an idea, that they could be dangerous.

So far, he found nothing that he disagreed with. Good. He would keep an eye on some of his more rebellious thoughts, of course. But over all it-

Oh. Yes. *There* it was.

Hordak. The name was alive and well within him, clinging desperately to one memory.

"Imperfections are-"

The Emperor let go of his face suddenly, eyes narrowed. He wanted her. He wanted her with every breath he took, every beat of his heart. He no longer remembered who she was to him, but the desire was there. The love was there. Steady and unshaken. Like a flower stubbornly blooming between a crack in the pavement, his love grew strong. And he watered it every day.

"Sire, I-"

A swipe of the Emperors shining claws sent him sprawling to the floor.

"You speak when spoken to. And not an instant sooner."

Prime kept his voice calm, carefully measured. One might think he was simply instructing, teaching a child a lesson. In a sick way, he was.

The clone scrambled to his hands and knees at his Emperors feet, head lowered. From his lip, blood dripped slowly onto the perfect mirror-smooth floor.

"Imperfection is...? *What* is imperfection, 828-1075?"

The Emperor began to walk a slow circle around him.

"I-Imperfection is b-... unacceptable," he finished softly, hesitantly.

"Correct. And *who* in this room is imperfect?"

"Me," he answered immediately, "I am."

"Correct again," he purred, tracing his silver talon across his shoulder blades, "you are a defect. Unfit to kneel in my presence. And yet... I have given you purpose, allowed you to live. In my kindness, I have even allowed you to serve my bride as her companion. My Emperess. And how am I repaid?"

He stopped his predatory circling right in front of the poor whimpering clone at his feet.

"Please, Sire. Mercy," he begged, "I won't-"

"Mercy? It is far too late for that," the Emperor sighed, kneeling in front of him. The clone, the poor flawed, hopeless fool, began to weep. And the Emperor truly did pity him. It wasn't his fault. He was simply made... wrong.

As the clone wept, Emperor Prime placed his hands to his face, guiding his head up to kiss his forehead.

"Restrain him," he ordered as he rose to his feet, voice cold as the vacuum of space.

"Wha-?! B-Brother! Please! No!" He begged as two other clones grabbed him from behind, "please! Don't do this! You don't have to do this! I'll obey every whim! I'll do anything you want!"

His words came too late. As he begged, the cables in the Emperors hair unlocked themselves and slithered in all directions, unfurling and hissing like snakes.

"Brother-! Please!"

"A lesson must be learned, my little Failure." Prime reached up to wipe away a tear, "Do not worry. I will not reset you again."

A feeling of intense relief crossed the face of the clone. Prime almost found it charming how he hung on every scrap of mercy.

"But this will still be... unpleasant."

Like striking vipers, the cables sunk into the ports on his sad broken body. The clone howled loud enough that He honestly worried for a moment that his voice would carry to Entraptas chambers. But in moments, the screaming stopped and the clones eyes faded to yellow.

But just because he stopped screaming did not mean the pain had ceased. He was now in a place beyond sound and sight. Within his mind, Prime assaulted him with every doubt, with every insecurity, and yes- *pain*. Pain straight from his brain, sending signals of agony to every nerve ending. His body quivered with it, his eyes went wide and twitched, his fingers clenched.

Prime went through every hurt in his life, every instant he felt shame. Every failure. And he found her there too. His worst memory.

Well, no. Not of *her*, exactly. But it involved her. The moment he thought he'd lost her. When his mind put two and two together,

reaching the seemingly obvious conclusion that she was gone forever.

Clones were not supposed to fear death in any capacity, not for themselves and certainly not for others. But he had. He had feared her death more than anything. And her death was still on his mind when he had been reconditioned.

"*She is alive, you know*," he purred directly into his mind, "*you've seen her, touched her, dressed her, undressed her. You've brought her pleasure and pain. But this is only the start... 'Hordak*'."

The clone was struggling now, squirming against his words. He was in there, deep, but present. And aware.

"*She is not yours. And after I marry her, she never will be. I am going to make her mine in every sense of the word. Body and heart. I will break her and rebuild her to my specifications*."

"*No-*"

"*I will **make** her love me. And you will watch her every day, aching. Her every thought will be for me. Every moment will be lived for me. She will hurt so much that you will wish she was dead*."

"*Please! Don't-*"

Prime cut their link, his hair tendrils retracting and he pushed them back into place with a gentle shake of his head and a sweep of his hands. He stood again as the clone slumped, eyes flashing yellow once more before they closed.

"Take him back to his princess and let him think about what he's done."
His voice maintained a soft and almost sing-song quality as two other clones dragged the twitching Companion back to his charge.

Entrapta paced her room, mumbling out loud a few dozen concerns. Stretched out on a sofa, Talullah waited with her.

"You aren't doing yourself any good by worrying so much, Darling,"she reminded her, fluffing her candy pink hair, "have a seat. Take a drink and relax."

"I can't. It's my fault," Entrapta buzzed, "I shouldn't have- ugh! What was I thinking?"

"Sweetheart, it really isn't as big a deal as you probably think-"

The door opened and Talullah went silent. Two pale, perfect clones dragged 828 behind them. Once properly inside the room, they both dropped 828 between them, bowed to the two women and left without explanation.

Entrapta was at his side in an instant.

"He's still breathing," she noted quickly, "no outward signs of injury- no. Minor injury to the face. No *life threatening* injury."

Entrapta looked up at Talullah who was now staring down at the clone, biting her lip.

"He's been Mind Kissed," she observed with pity, "poor thing."

"Mind Kissed?" Entrapta scooped his frail form up with the help of her hair, "I don't know what that means."

As she took the clone to the bed to rest, Talullah went to his other side to help.

"The Kiss is pure agony to a clone," she explained, pulling the sheets down so Entrapta could lay him down, "He... rips them apart. He goes through everything in their memories and uses it to hurt them. He says it... teaches a lesson."

Entrapta pulled the blankets up to his chin, reminded of the last time she did this. After he fainted in his lab. She recalled the scent

of him as she wrapped him in a blanket. She had placed a little kiss to his forehead like he was some cursed Prince in a fairytale. She thought he smelled nice, like fire and medical grade alcohol. Now he smelled like... nothing.

"Will he...?"

"He'll recover, dearie. Don't cry."

Entrapta reached up to her face, realizing that, yes. She was crying. Again. She'd never cried this much in her entire life. Now it felt like she couldnt stop.

"This was my fault. Why did he punish him and not me?" She demanded, "it's not fair! He should hurt me instead if he's angry! He should-"

Talullah pulled her in close and once again Entrapta had to gasp for breath as her massive bosoms pressed against her face.

"Hush. Don't talk like that. If I hear you talking like that, I will suffocate you in my cleavage."

It seemed like a valid threat. Entrapta pulled away, shaking her fluffy lavender hair back into place.

"*Will* he?" She asked suddenly, turning her attention back to the sleeping clone, "hurt me, I mean."

Talullah was hesitant, careful. She had known her husband a very long time and they had been through so much. In many ways, she knew him deeper than anyone. And even then, she didn't have an answer.

"I... don't know," she answered honestly, "but I think if he was going to, he would have done it by now. He is usually swift in his punishments. He didnt become the Emperor of the Universe by being overly forgiving, Entrapta."

The Princess sniffled as she sunk into a high backed white chair. So she was likely safe... for now.

"I'm alright, Talullah. You can go if you want. I'm going to sleep soon, I think."

The other wife nodded slowly.

"If you're sure...? Do you need me to get my Companion to look after you? Would you like him to grab you some nightclothes?"

Entrapta looked down at herself. She still wore just the silky slip from her dress fitting. For nearly two hours, The Emperor had insisted on holding her, petting her hair, whispering sleepily in a language she did not understand. And she found herself craving it, *him*. The hurt, the way he hurt her was breathtakingly beautiful. And she hated herself for it.

She shook her head as she plucked absently at the thin strip of decorative silver at the hem of her slip. Talullah hesitated, but nodded.

"Alright... but if you need something-"

"I won't," Entrapta cut her off, "but... thanks."

She turned all her attention back to the clone. She didn't hear the other Wife leave, but when Entrapta looked up again, she was gone. She was left once more alone in her glittering white prison and for once, she was glad for it.

Her fingers raked through his hair while his body rested. The blue was fading fast and soon it would be gone, leaving him indistinguishable from the others.
But she would know. She would *always* know. To her, the difference was night and day.

"You're still beautiful," she murmured, "no matter what they do to you, you'll always be beautiful."

For another hour, she sat at his side and carefully cleaned his visible wounds. Small as they were, she took her time, using every excuse to touch him she could take. Every drop of blood at his lip filled her with sad, sick delight. The more he bled, the more she could touch him. It was acceptable to touch him like this. She was simply helping him. She was giving medical attention, nothing more.

And it felt so good. He was warm in a way that Prime simply wasn't. He had held her just hours ago and that warmth lingered. His hands had left deep imprints on her hips, the warmth of his face still left her burning.

"I never got to tell you, Hordak," she whispered, leaning over him, "your crystal. Do you know what it says?"

She hesitated. Was he awake? He'd shifted slightly, but went still again pretty quickly. She decided he must still be asleep. Good. She didn't want to break the spell just yet.

"It was my little secret. But I think I can tell you now." She looked down at her palm, smiling at her scar. Standing up, she placed her palm over his heart as if she could somehow will the words into his soul.
"Loved. That's what I wrote in it. I loved you."

She leaned. Her eyes closed. Their lips met. It was a small touch, barely a whisper of a kiss. But for Entrapta, it was love like a sweeping orchestra.

"*And I always will.*"

She lay down next to him as she had the past few nights. But this time, she was the one awake, listening to his breath, watching his chest rise and fall. She was the one observing him. When it hit the hour for sleep, the lights dimmed automatically.

Suddenly the breathing stilled and a strange new light blinked at the ceiling. Yellow.

"Are you... awake?" Entrapta asked uncertainly, rolling on her side to face him.

Large yellow eyes turned to her and she realized too quickly he seemed frightened. His breathing rate increased, his heart fluttered. He looked around in the darkness, panicked.

And then she took his hand in hers and smiled.

"It's okay," she whispered, "you're safe now. I'll protect you."

The color shifted from golden yellow to apple green and he seemed to sigh in relief.

"Princess. I..."

"Shh, I know," she soothed, squeezing his hand, "are you in pain?"

The clone hesitated, then nodded running a claw under his eye to catch a tear before it even had a chance to roll over his waterline.

"The Kiss is... unpleasant," he admitted quietly, "but I am grateful for his attentions. He has made me better for it."

Entrapta stared in the darkness. The way his eyes seemed far away, unfocused, deeply disturbed her. And worse, the adoration in his voice, as if he truly believed it. As if he thought he *deserved* it.

"My creator is kind," he continued as if reciting a prayer, "he is generous. And he will be a... good... husband for you."

The last part shocked her. He sounded unsure. Like he was struggling just to get the words out. Fighting. She squeezed his hand again.

"Hordak," she tried his name again, quietly, "you're in there. I know you are. I'll find you."

"I am... 828-1075," he whispered automatically, but there was a question hanging at the edge of the number.

"I know you are right now," she replied, "but it's okay. I'll find Hordak again. I'll bring him out."

Silence. The clone blinked in the darkness, but squeezed her hand back in silent acknowledgment. For one minute and thirty eight seconds exactly, nobody said a word and then-

"You marry in two days," he reminded her.

"...Yes, I do."

"Are you happy?"

"No. Are you?"

Another impossibly long stretch of silence. He closed his eyes and for a while, she thought he had gone back to sleep. She tried to roll over but his hand still held hers so tightly. She began to close her eyes as well.

There was the tiniest flicker of red, so fast Entrapta thought she had imagined it. But then a tiny voice in the darkness answered;

"No."

"Hordak?"

He let go of her hand and lay on his back again.

"Sleep, Princess. It is well past your assigned bed time."

"...Goodnight, Hordak."

For a long time, he was silent, staring up at the endless expanse of the Universe above them. Then, when her breathing slowed and he was certain she was asleep, he smiled.

"Goodnight... Entrapta."

Chapter End Notes

Shorter chapter than normal. Sorry, I guess? Next chapter will be a longer one. Wedding, smut and tragedy.

For now, I hope you enjoyed our boy getting tortured.

White

Chapter Summary

> TW: violent rape ahead. If that disturbs you, congrats. You are a normal functioning member of society.
> You've been warned.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The day of the wedding, Entrapta woke much as she had the week prior. For all intents and purposes, it truly was a day like any other. She had a job to do. That was what this was. A duty. She allowed herself to be dressed, prepped and led to the shuttle that would take her home to Etheria.

One last time.

828 was silent, more so than usual. She wanted to talk to him, smile, insist she was alright, ease some of that worry she could see so clearly in his eyes. But she couldn't. Even if they were alone, which they certainly were not, she couldn't lie. The truth was, she was far from alright.

"Ah, Dear One," her husband-to-be greeted her at the ramp, holding out a gentlemanly hand to assist her aboard, "today is your day. Are you the happiest woman in the Universe?"

Lips pulled back into a thin smile, she nodded. It was enough for him. He smiled back, kissed her palm, her wrist, forearm. Then he stopped, leaning close to her ear.

"Tonight, begins a new age of my Empire. Let us give the Universe a good show, shall we?"

She blinked as he pulled away, unsure what he meant exactly. He did not see fit to explain either as he led her to a comfortable set

of seats. She took one, he took the other and...

"*Catra?*" She looked the feline up and down as she took a seat opposite of them. 828 settled next to her, hands resting neatly in his lap, face a porceline mask of indifference.

"Catra here will be serving as your personal attendant today." The Emperor checked his talons, looking bored.

"I don't need her. She's-"

She closed her mouth at once as two of the Emperors brilliant green eyes snapped to her, narrowing.

"I mean... *thank you,* love," she whispered, looking down at her lap. In response, his perfect hand reached over to lace his strong fingers through hers.

"Anything my Emperess desires," he purred, lifting her palm to his lips.

There was such ceremony to exiting the ship. Entrapta had to be inspected to be sure not a hair was out of place, dressed suitably in a coordinating outfit with her Emperor. Catra has assisted her in this, avoiding her eye, but making confusing gestures with her tail.

As 828 adjusted her makeup, she noticed a pretty, young-looking female alien speaking to Prime across the ship. She smiled with sparkling green fangs, twirled a lock of swirling bright white hair, looked him over with brilliant emerald eyes. And Entrapta felt a tiny pang of jealousy. She watched her reach up to adjust a shining green gem at the center of his chest. He smiled down at her, then bent slightly to press a soft kiss to her forehead.

"His *daughter*," Catra explained quickly as if sensing her discomfort, "her name is Beck. She's his personal assistant."

"Ooooh... I thought-"

"Please do not move, Princess," 828 mumbled, carefully sweeping black color through her lashes, "this is difficult."

"Oh. Sorry."

She tried not to stare at the Emperor and his daughter. Tried not to consider that, at the youngest, she was probably her age or older. Tried not to remember that he probably had children twice, three, or even six times her age.

Beck tucked a lock of hair behind a long ear and glanced over her shoulder, giving Entrapta a pleasant smile and a wave. Entrapta smiled and waved back awkwardly. This was the absurdly complex family she was going to legally become a part of in a few short hours.

The other woman, her... step daughter flashed her teeth in a friendly grin, then continued to assist her father in pulling on a high collared Cape, much like what Hordak used to wear. It made him look huge and intimidating as he walked back over to her, offering his arm.

"Well, my Bride, shall we make ourselves known to the Universe?"

She laced her arm through his and pulled on (what she hoped was) a lovesick smile. He glanced her over one last time, then reached across to carefully adjust the green stone she wore. They approached the doors and just before they opened, he swept her up in a grand, passionate kiss.

That would be the first thing the Galaxy would see of her. Hands flat against his chest, chin pointed upwards to accept his kiss, eyes closed. For all watching, she looked a woman in love. He held her close against him, so tall compared to her he had to pull her up off her feet. For all watching, she looked a woman in love. In her heart she felt like a corpse.

And when he pulled away panting, he made a good show of looking shocked and embarrassed at being "caught" in an affectionate moment. Entrapta understood so little about acting that it was fortunate that her shock was genuine.

He laughed and Entrapta did the same, but not before he squeezed her hand just a little too tight in warning. She felt her feet touch the ground as the sheer weight of the eyes upon her hit. Trillions of eyes from every corner of the Universe, watching, judging, picking out her every flaw. But she supposed that was rather the point. She was flawed. And he was *not*.

The eyes that she couldn't see were not half as bad as the eyes that she could see, however. It was as if all of Etheria had turned out to see them land. Horde Prime waved, smiling like a fairytale Prince. Charming. Handsome. Even by Etherian standards, he oozed sex appeal. And Entrapta would be his bride.

She tried to look the part. She tried to look the ecstatic bride about to marry a God. And maybe she fooled some people. On a certain level, it was fun, exciting. There were moments where he was kind, generous, almost *loving*.

And then she saw Hordak behind a set of glassy eyes. He followed close behind with Catra, both of them dressed to fade into the background. Pale. White, blank.

"Your Majesty," the Emperor purred as they approached Queen Glimmer, "from the bottom of our heart, we are truly honored that you have offered your beautiful Kingdom to host our marriage. And we are grateful that Etheria has chosen to join our humble little family."

He bowed and Entrapta did the same. Glimmer was smiling and Entrapta thought she might actually be happy. But when she returned the gesture, her bow was stiff, formal.

"Etheria thanks you, Emperor, for saving us all from Hordak and bringing peace and order to our own little world."

The Emperor let out a hearty laugh and laced an arm across Entraptas waist, holding her close.

"If anyone should be grateful, it is I, Majesty. You introduced me to the love of my life."

"Y-yes," Entrapta added, trying to remember her lines, "I am so happy. Thank you."

Behind her, she heard Catra shift uncomfortably and Glimmer stared past Entrapta with a false smile. She hadn't looked her in the eye once. Ashamed, Entrapta supposed. It was logical. She was, after all, the one that sold her out.

Catra stepped forward as Prime gestured with a silver claw, presenting a white and gold box.

"For you, your Majesty," he purred, "As a show of our eternal gratitude."

Catra approached and opened the lid, showing all the Universe what a gift from an Emperor was. What lay inside was tiny, a ring with what looked almost like a Pearl, if not for the fact that something was glowing and moving within.

"It's... lovely," she replied, sounding uncertain,

Entrapta glanced at Prime who's smirk seemed to take on an almost sinister appearance before shifting to a pleasant, handsome grin.

"What you hold is what one might call the 'soul' of a lost Galaxy. The last traces of a trillion years of life."

Entrapta froze, her fingers clutching tight to his arm. Was he serious? She wanted to get a closer look now. Study it. But she had to remain still, forever smiling. Glimmer looked up, took a deep breath and snapped the lid shut.

"it will be treasured for as long as Etheria stands," she responded stiffly, visibly disturbed, "and for you and your bride, we have a celebration planned larger than any in our humble worlds history."

"We look forward to it, Your Majesty," he chuckled, charismatic and almost boyish, "but for now, we have a marriage to prepare for."

Entrapta swallowed, looking past Glimmer to the sullen faces of her friends. The Princess alliance, broken, defeated. The pity behind their stone smiles hurt more than anger, more than loss, more than death.

She met the eyes of Princess Scorpia whos smile cracked and nearly crumbled until Perfuma grabbed her claw. She would be alright, Entrapta decided. At the very least, her friends were safe.

As her eyes studied her friends, she noted the absence of Adora and she had the sudden realization that no matter what work she did in her lab, the Heart of Etheria was never going to work without Adora and without the sword.

Good. Prime would get angry, take it out on her, but at least Etheria wouldn't be used to hurt people.

Before she could think on it anymore. She was being ushered inside to prepare for the rest of her life.

Entrapta stared silently at her reflection for a long time as several drone-like clones fussed over the tiniest details of her look. At the back of the suite, 828 stood, silent, stone faced, watching, waiting. She wanted to approach him, take his hand, beg him to escape with her. But he wouldn't. Couldnt.

"Wow! You're pretty!"

Entrapta jumped and looked around. The voice was young, feminine. Not a clone. Who else was in here?

Her eyes focused on a wide, sharp grin, long furry brown ears, large yellow eyes full of excitement. Cute. Entrapta smiled, ignoring the muttered protests of her clone attendants as she turned fully to face the girl.

"Thank you. I'm Entrapta. What's your name?"

The young alien girls eyes seemed to flash with excitement and she bounced up and down on her furry little feet.

"I'm Terr! You must be Fathers new Wife!"

"Fath-? Oh! You're one of his children!" Entrapta waved, grinning. She hadn't officially met any of his children. Part of her assumed he sent them away so they would not bother him. This was a surprise. To have such a young one at a royal wedding.
"It's nice to meet you, Terr. Do you live on The Velvet Glove too?"

A clone mumbled about wasting time, but Entrapta ignored him. This was far more interesting than being fussed over for a wedding she did not want to have.

"Yeah! I live in the Childrens Corridor with the other young ones. You're going to have babies too, so you'll see it!"

Entrapta felt her face heat up at that reminder. Her 'purpose'.

"Y-yeah... so there are other children? I haven't seen any. Are they all here?"

"Most of them," little Terr answered, touching the skirt of Entraptas gown carefully, "wow this is pretty. The ones that weren't doing essential work came. So all of the young ones and some of the older kids."

A clone began to fuss over her hair and Entrapta narrowed her eyes, playfully swatting his hand with a lock of lavender. Terr

watched, wide eyed.

"You have magic hair?" She gasped, "you're so lucky!"

Entrapta giggled, patting the small alien childs head with another tendril of hair.

"Hey, Terr? Can I ask you a favor?"

The child looked up with a wide grin, still playing with the hem of her dress. She seemed to think about it for a moment before giving a sharp nod.

"I don't have many friends outside of Etheria. Do you think you could be my friend?"

The child opened her mouth to answer, but a voice from the other end of the room cut her off.

"Terr, are you bothering your Emperess?"

Entrapta jumped and so did the girl, jerking a hand away from the pearly white fabric.

"Sorry Da- I mean, Father," she dipped into a bow with the rest of the clones as well as Entrapta.

"She isn't bothering me, Love. She's been a great help," Entrapta added quickly, jumping to her defense. Would Prime harm a child? She had no way of knowing. The Emperor stared, face unreadable from his Bride to his daughter.

"Very well," he sighed, but then his face split with a smile and he held his arms open.

At once, the small girl ran to him, throwing her arms around his shoulders and nuzzling his chest.

"You're being nice to Entrapta, aren't you?" Entrapta heard him whisper to the child, "helping her feel welcome?"

The child nodded and murmured something that made the Emperor chuckle.

"That's alright, Starlight. I would like it very much if you were her friend."

The girl glanced at Entrapta from where she was now curled up in her Fathers strong arms and flashed her a grin as if to say 'he said it was okay!'

Prime murmured something and set the girl down, hand on her cheek.

"Run along, Starlight," he placed a soft kiss on her forehead "I am counting on you to make sure your younger brothers and sisters are ready."

The little girl gave a playful salute and with a small wave and a flick of her tail, she scurried away. Entrapta waved back as she left, smiling, but confused.

"So I see you've begun to make friends with your stepchildren," Prime mused, looking her up and down, "a good start. They will be helpful to you."

Entrapta looked up, finding all four eyes focused entirely on her face.

"Terr is... a nice girl," Entrapta offered, "are they all-?"

"That friendly?" Her Emperor guessed with a chuckle. "They are trained to be future leaders, Dear One. Charisma is essential for that. But Terr is special. You will continue to show her kindness, understood?"

He didn't sound angry, simply... concerned? As if this were a conversation he had needed to have with many people.

"Of course. We're friends now," Entrapta replied simply.

"Good," he nodded, "I raised her myself. She is especially precious to me."

"By yourself?" Entrapta asked, watching her husband-to-be as he walked in a slow circle around her studying every detail, "wasn't her Mother-?"

Prime paused, took a deep breath and shook his head before continuing.

"I had her Mother executed."

Entrapta felt a shiver of fear run up her spine. Execution. Even of the mother of one of his children. His mates were truly disposable, then?

"Why?" She asked simply, afraid of the answer.

Prime stopped behind her to begin arranging her hair himself, pinning lavender curls in place.

"When Terr was very young, the woman went mad. She attempted to drown her own daughter. I stopped her just in time, but..." he sighed and pulled away, allowing a pair of clones to begin pinning the white metal headdress in place.
"The sentence for bringing harm to any of my children is death, no matter your position on my court."

He said the last part with a hint of warning and Entrapta swallowed. Keep his children safe and happy and she might survive to a decent age. Or alternatively, she could trip a child and get executed.

"You... really care about you children," she murmured, finding it difficult to contain her surprise, "I didn't expect that."

She caught the almost hurt expression on his face in the mirror before he pushed it away.

"You truly thought I would sire children and not give a single thought to their wellbeing or happiness?"

Entrapta said nothing. It was true. That was her assumption. But the more she thought about it, there wasn't any real evidence to support it.

"Children are the future of this Empire," he explained, "but more than that, of all the creatures in this Universe, nothing is more pure or perfect than a child. Say what you will about my methods, Princess, but we do not harm children here."

She let out a breath she did not know she was holding. He used and disposed of his clones like they were wrapping paper, but at least he wasn't awful to children? It was a start.

"Excellent," he quietly complemented, as he finished his inspection of her. "Perfect. Yes. You are the image of an Emperess."

Entrapta again turned her gaze to the mirror, pulling on what she hoped was a convincing smile. She convinced herself, at least. She did look happy. Was she happy? She honestly didn't know anymore what happiness felt like.

"I live to serve you," she responded automatically, just as she had rehearsed with 828.

A sharp claw guided her chin to the side as he bent over her shoulder, mouth planting tiny kisses where her shoulder met her neck.

"Tonight, you do not serve just me," he reminded her softly, "Tonight you serve the Empire."

"I... hope I don't disappoint."

The Emperor pulled away and laughed. It made her flinch.

"Your job is simple. Lay back, spread your legs and let me work. It will be difficult for you to fail."

His tone was light and airy, but Entrapta couldn't help but feel she was being made fun of. It was humiliating. She was going from being the Frightzones tech genius and Hordaks closest confidante, to little more than a plaything, a walking uterus.

"My Emperor..." she murmured, looking down, "is that really all you need me for?"

In the reflection of the mirror she watched him tilt his beautiful head slightly as he considered her words. He smiled his perfect smile, lifted a lock of hair to his white face and kissed it.

"Of course not, Dear One," he purred, placing his other hand softly against her cheek from behind. She relaxed against him, closing her eyes. "I need your mind as well. You will operate the weapon for me."

His fingers slid down her face, to her neck, giving it a gentle squeeze before sliding to her shoulder and finally her waist. Without further warning, he pulled her against him and placed a careful kiss to her forehead. Then he was gone.

All around the universe, her voice was translated as trillions heard her promise herself to their Emperor.

"To you I swear my undying love and loyalty."
She spoke well rehearsed words with a smile that was painted on. "As my Emperor, I will obey and worship. As my husband, I will adore and cherish."

She was sinking, drowning. Above her, the world glistened, shining, unfocused, wet. Through tears, she tried to concentrate on her Emperor, her husband. She tried to make them appear

tears of joy. The slight flash of green teeth made her think he was buying it.

"T-the stars will not shine and the Universe will not spin unless you are beside me."

In the honeymoon suite, 828 silently worked, shaking hands preparing the marriage bed. He bit his tongue as her vows slithered into his sensitive ears, implanting itself in his brain for all time. He knew he would never be rid of today, this burning rage, this pain like an inferno engulfing him entirely. He was swallowed by a flame and it grew red hot in his chest, smouldering.

As he smoothed out the pillow she would lay on, he whispered with her:

"*From this moment until my last, I belong to you alone."*

It ended with a kiss, sealed with a stamp. Legal. Official. The taste of mint lingered an hour after he pulled away, swooping her up in his strong arms. Her head and heart and limbs felt numb and clumsy. All thought seemed to cease.

She was a doll. Just like one of his clones. Pretty smile, glossy eyes. Bendable limbs, perfect for posing as he willed. His words came out of her mouth, her voice pitched up just a little higher than normal. Perfect and pleasant and porcelain.

She stood in front of her friends now, his large arm encircled her waist, holding her in place.

"Deepest congratulations, Entrapta," Queen Glimmer said, forcing a smile. Behind her, Princess Perfuma sniffed. Mermista crossed her arms awkwardly and looked away. Netossa and Spinerella held hands, looking as if they were attending a funeral, not a wedding.

"Thank you for sharing in my joy," she replied formally, stiff, smiling. She was a puppet. He held her strings and she would dance at his bidding. His hand around her waist squeezed lightly and she added, "*Our* joy."

"We shall name our first daughter after you, Your Majesty," The Emperor purred, letting go of Entrapta to bow before the Queen and hold a hand out to her.

Entrapta watched Glimmer swallow what ever insult she had resting on the tip of her tongue and give him her hand with a thin smile.

"I would be honored," she responded robotically, "Brightmoon is yours to visit as you see fit. We will keep the royal suite ready at all times."

The Emperor placed a formal kiss to the back of her hand. As he pulled away, Entrapta watched him gently caress her fingers, smirking at the gifted ring she now wore. A shiver ran up the Queens spine as she pulled her hand away. Luckily, Prime hardly seemed to notice.

Scorpia approached, but stopped the instant one of the Emperors eyes fell on her. What ever she was about to say to Entrapta died in her throat and all she could do was wave a claw in her direction. Aside from Hordak, Scorpia had been her best friend. All the data said she was, anyway. And anecdotal evidence suggested it as well.

And she wasn't even going to get a chance to say goodbye.

Entrapta felt her painted smile crack and she immediately looked away. It would be the last time she saw Scorpia and she knew it. The last time she would probably see Glimmer as well. Or Bow. The teen caught her eye for a moment, only an instant before she was ushered along by her husbands firm grasp.

"Glad to see your friends again?" He asked, lips close to her ear.

She nodded, biting her tongue. She could feel his breath on her neck, his teeth close to her jaw. He smiled and she felt a fang drag lightly across the sensitive flesh there.

"My good little wife," he purred, "always so very eager to please."

"Will I ever see them again?" She asked, gasping slightly as he placed a kiss to her neck. He hummed, considering.

"Perhaps," he whispered, "if you can give me a child and figure out the weapon. Do both and I may consider it."

Entrapta hesitated, but agreed. What choice did she have? There was no arguing with an Emperor. Not now. Not here. She simply smiled and allowed him to guide her to a gathering of aliens, well dressed and exotic, mingling together. Among the cluster of beauty, Entrapta noticed Talullah.

As soon as the Emperor approached, all gathered bowed.

"My Dear One," he whispered against her ear, "come meet the rest of your family. My wives. And husbands."

And when Entrapta looked, she saw it. Two apparent males among the gathering. Both beautiful. One wore a nail guard identical to Prime and as Entrapta looked at him, he smirked and brought it to his plump golden lips.

"My Loves," he purred, holding Entraptas hand up, "I would like to formally introduce Entrapta, my new wife and your Emperess."

It was clear this was not a shock to the gathered beauties. She saw one woman down the rest of her beverage, looking bored.

"Dear One, allow me to introduce the rest of the family," he moved to walk her by each of his lovers as he introduced them at a breakneck speed, "This one is Dhar, that's Ryha, Sveletta, Rawnie-"

Entrapta nodded to each of the Emperors lovers, smiling. For the most part, they all smiled back too and offered a shallow bow, save for the one Talullah had warned her about. Rawnie was a beauty. Humanoid, with piercing violet eyes, long limbs, thin like a spider and graceful. She tossed her white hair over her shoulder and looked away. The Emperor didn't stop long enough to notice.

"You already know Talullah, of course. Then there are the twins, Aleiz and Ajna."
Two sets of three pink eyes settled on her and Entrapta saw them whisper.
"Fleick, Lenneh, Karena, Shereiz, Scolopendra,"

Lenna, Felick and Shereiz all smiled politely. Karena and Scolopendra leaned in to whisper to each other. Karena tucked kelp-like hair over her shoulder and Scolopendra met Entraptas eyes with careful indifference. Her braids- no. They were not braids, Entrapta realized. A thousand tiny legs wiggled from the "hair" hanging over her shoulder. It reminded her of the centipedes on Etheria.

She looked at each beautiful face. Plastic smiles and pitiful eyes in some, haughty indifference in others, but over all, when the Emperor look at them individually, they looked back with genuine love.

He stopped in front of one wife, a brilliant golden woman with bright ruby hair and eyes like diamonds. He reached out to run a finger across her cheek with a purr. Aside from Talullah, she was the only spouse who did not look back at him as if he were divine.

"And this is Zallah."

"My love," the golden woman murmured, sparkling crystal white eyes sliding to take in the tiny Emperess. As Entrapta met her gaze, she swore she saw fear for a moment, but it was gone before Entrapta could be sure.

He turned his full attention back to Entrapta, grasping her hand and bringing it up to his lips, smirking.

"Well then, my dearest loves," he chuckled, sinking into a shallow bow, "I think it's about time we take our leave. But please, continue to enjoy the festivities."
He turned two eyes to Entrapta again, talon tracing across her collarbone as he reached across to pull her along.
"After all," he added darkly, just loud enough for her to hear, "the wedding night is the important part."

"Is that going to be broadcast too?" She snapped under her breath.

A second after the words left her mouth, she realized the mistake. But it was too late. He stopped walking with her, gently pulling her to face him. All eyes on her, he reached up to run a hand through her hair, plucked out a small white blossom from a strand and held it up for her to see.

"Oh no. Tonight is... personal. We will have only one witness tonight." Every word dripped with meaning, warning. The slit of his pupils somehow seemed more narrow now. "Be patient, my Dear One. You will have me all to yourself. Very. Soon."

He plucked one petal, then another with every word. She watched them fall, bruised by his claws. She understood. She was afraid.

And she was right.

828 was burning. Entrapta had noticed the second she saw his large green eyes. The blazing hate behind it. He was absolutely on fire with a white hot rage. An Inferno he was barely containing.

But he did not move. He seemed almost trapped, held down by something invisible. It wasn't until Prime walked into the honeymoon suite behind her that she understood.

"Ah. Our witness," he mocked, "I have had him restrained, of course. Can't have him looking away."

"Restrained...? But, why-?"

Prime tilted his head at the look of complete horror on her face, silencing her at once. One eye went to the clone while the other three remained on her. He hummed as he looked her over.

"He has been... defiant," he explained, lifting a lock of violet hair to his face, "Tonight he will take a lesson from this... as will you."

She closed her eyes, frightened, expecting pain. He simply let go of her hair and walked by. When she looked up at last, he was already by the bed.

And He was perfect.

Every inch of his body was without flaw. Any woman should have felt happy tonight. He was a beautiful bed mate, the most powerful man in the Universe and her legal husband now, a bond unbreakable save by death.

And tonight she was wishing for death.

He stood in the pool of white silk at his feet, nude form now free from his robe. In one hand, he held a glass of some bubbly teal liquid.

As she awkwardly looked him up and down, he held the glass out for her.

"Drink," he ordered, "tonight will be easier for you if you've had a bit to drink first."

Entrapta had not noticed that she had been holding her breath until he spoke to her. She let it out like a sigh, taking the glass in her small hands. As instructed, she took a sip, finally able to identify the taste on his lips. It was this.

Delicious. She took another long sip, came up for air, then another. By the time the glass was drained, her new husband had silently stepped around her until he was just behind. A hand gently slid across her hip.

"*He* never touched you like this."
His breath, sweet and minty, tickled her ear as she glanced at 828... no, *Hordak* still standing silent in the corner of the room.
"Has anyone besides me? Or is this truly your first time?"

"I've never..." she breathed, eye lids fluttered as he placed gentle, feather light kisses down her neck. His hands traced along the curve of her waist, across her imperfect tummy, the slight dips in her hips, lower still until he felt her stiffen under his fingers.

"Mmm... Still so innocent. I will try to control myself, my Dear One," his breathy, husky whisper sent a shiver through her entire body. "But I can not promise not to hurt you."

He seemed to be waiting for something, a nod of consent, a whispered love confession, a breathy, needy moan. All she offered was a shaky sigh. It was enough for him.

His hands moved from where he was holding her waist, pulling away entirely with a nod to two of his clone attendants. Two white clothed clones stepped forward to take her by both arms. In a panic, she shoved them off with her hair, but a simple growl of irritation from her husband put her back in her place. She stood still as each clone began to carefully peel away her dress.

She'd been nude in front of him before, but this was more dangerous. Intentional. She glanced at Hordak still as stone, eyes twitching, unable to close, unable to look away. As the two clones began to peel away her undergarments, the full gravity of her new life really hit her.

"Get on the bed," her husband ordered, words hitting her like ice water.

She looked down at her feet, watching as they obeyed his orders without hesitation. Her body no longer seemed to be her own around him. Much as everyone else in his life, she existed for his pleasure now.

Letting out a deep breath, she nearly dove under the blankets. She lay on her back, shakily holding the covers to her chest, feeling much like a child hiding from a monster under the bed.

Wordlessly, he slid under the sheets next to her and ran a claw through her hair, staring down at her.

"Are you afraid?" He asked gently, talons still raking through her hair.

"Yes," she confessed, trembling as he ran his other hand across her collarbone. He seemed to hum at her, lost in thought. He was being so slow, gentle. Perhaps this wouldn't be so bad after all?

"*Good*," his voice took a hard edge, "that will make this fun."

She didn't have the chance to react before his wandering hand grasped her throat, squeezing, while the other stopped its gentle petting if her hair, instead grabbed the lot of it roughly by the scalp. He leaned in as he shifted his body, teeth so close to her ear he could tear it off.

"What I am about to do is inevitable. Resist and I will hurt you more."

He settled between her trembling thighs, and she did not move. Even as the wires in his hair came to life, slithering threatening across her face, chest, arms, she lay still as stone.

"But do feel free to scream, Dear One," he chuckled softly, "we are being listened to. Let us put on a good show."

And scream she did. He gave no warning. Beneath him, she sobbed as his entire length tore through her, hard, fast, filling her

to the hilt before withdrawing again. Her eyes glazed as waves of pain rolled theough her body.

Entrapta didn't hold much care for sentiment. The concept of virginity was outdated, archaic. But there were some things that she had dreamed about. A romantic, gentle first time had been one of them. And now that dream had been shattered and thrown to the winds before her eyes.

The Emperor paused, pulling away slightly, then flashing a green grin as he glanced down between them. He trailed his hand down from her neck to where their bodies joined. When he lifted his fingers again, they were coated in thick red blood.

"Innocent no more," he taunted, turning his attention next to the clone at the far end of the room. He held up his bloodied fingers like a trophy. The clone didn't respond. Didn't move. But every cell in his flawed body was screaming.

Three eyes snapped back to her once again as he raised his bloodied fingers to his mouth, licking them clean as he thrust into her again and again, harder each time. Her throat felt raw, eyes stung with tears. He tugged on her hair, pressed hard against her thighs. She could feel bruises begin to pop up already.

He groaned as he fucked her, his now clean hand went to her hip, claws digging deep. Two of his eyes closed in apparent bliss, the other two were split between watching her and one of his clones.

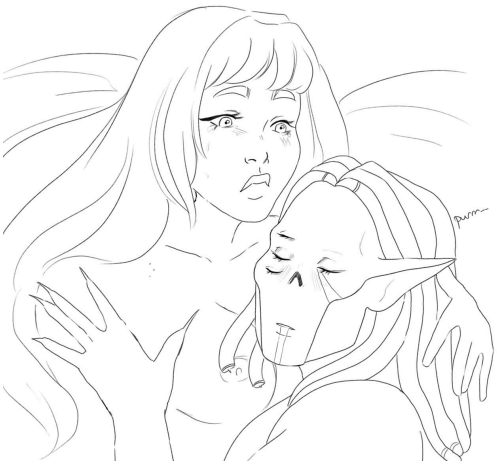
Below him, Entrapta writhed in agony. She clutched the sheets below her, tearing at them with her polished fingernails. She felt her husband lean in close, teeth at her throat. With a tug at her scalp, she turned her head to give him full access to her neck.

That was when her gaze met *his*. Eyes that flickered red and green, a face contorted with pain. Hordak watched and wept.

Her husband sunk his teeth deep into her neck as he came, growling and snarling as his body shuddered. Between her thighs,

she could already feel his seed spilling out before he had even finished. Messy, bloody, sticky.

As his body recovered from his orgasm, he nipped her neck, murmuring something in that strange language of his. His hands relaxed on her, and the instant he pulled out, it was as if she shared a bed with someone else entirely. He touched her gently, lay his head on her chest, kissed over her heart. Like a lover.



A snake-like cord slithered up to her face, wiping away a tear to her surprise. She looked down, noticing his top eye studying her. She felt she should say something, but when he closed his eye and pressed his face to her chest, she lost her nerve.

How could he be like this? So cold and cruel and then immediately shift to warm and needy? After several long minutes, the pain eased enough that she could move her bruised arms. Slowly, uncertainly, she brushed a hand through his hair. The cords shifted as his entire body stiffened and Entrapta feared she had made a giant mistake. Then, at once, he relaxed and the cords coiled and settled against her chest. He sighed blissfully and reached up to her neck, frowning.

"Forgive me. I did not intend to bite so hard," he murmured, tracing the bloody mark under her ear.

It seemed so odd to Entrapta for him to apologize for that, considering the damage the rest of her body had taken.

"It's... do you always bite?" She asked, shakily. He looked up at her with one eye and nodded.

"If you had mated with the one you called Hordak-" she shivered as he spoke his name, both glancing at the now very green eyed clone, "he likely would have done the same. Did you not notice the mark on all of my spouses?"

Entrapta thought back. No. She'd been distracted, too much so to notice.

"Is there a purpose to the bite?" She asked, genuinely curious. It felt better to collect data. Made her feel a little more like herself.

"I like to mark my own," he explained, "It also allows others to track when I've mated, so that when a wife conceives, there can be little question about the parentage."

"So it's a social thing," she concluded, "fascinating..."

Silence again. Awkward. Suddenly, his hair cables retracted as he pulled himself into the sitting position between her legs. He looked down at his work, the bloodied sheets, her scratched hips, her bruised thighs.

He smiled and rose from the bed. Entrapta hissed as he pushed her sore limbs aside, and pulled the sheet up to cover her damaged body.

"You aren't... staying?"

"I am a busy man, Dear one. I must still sign Etherias idiotic peace treaty."

He leaned over and gave her a kiss on the forehead. Two clones immediately stepped forward to assist him in pulling a robe on over his nudity.

"Ah, my sweet, little wife. Take heart in knowing that tonight you served you Emperor well." He chuckled, checking his reflection in a looking glass held up by one clone as another adjusted the white ropes of his hair.
"Tomorrow, I believe I will have you serve me again. Keep your... busy schedule open for me."

He glanced at her with two of his four eyes, smirking as he studied her. His little wife, his Emperess. So small, shy, unsure under the bloodied bed sheets. And now entirely his.

"And your legs," he added with a chuckle. He turned his attention to Hordak, snapping his fingers. At once, his eyes flashed from green, to yellow, then back to green, then he crumpled to his hands and knees.

"Your Emperess is a mess," he sneered, "see to her at once."

With that final command he left her alone on her wedding night. Alone with... *him*. She pulled her sore knees to her chest, buried her face in her hands and wept.

Chapter End Notes

> The beautiful artwork above is by the lovely and talented AppleFuell. Find her on Twitter and Tumblr and maybe throw a donation in her Ko-fi.
> Cuz shes great. <3

Silver

Chapter Summary

A more Prime focused chapter for you! Enjoy.

828 could not speak his feelings. It felt like a block every time he tried to speak his own words. His tongue couldn't cooperate, his throat closed and all he could manage was a frustrated growl.

She needed him. She needed his voice, his words. Comfort. Care. And he couldn't give it. All he could do was what he had done. Draw a bath, quietly shoulder her grief, allow her to sob as he carried her to the warm, soothing waters. He set her down carefully, afraid to shatter her. The cracks were so fresh, so visible.

She hissed as the water washed over her still fresh wounds. The water swirled with red, turning pink and finally disappating as her blood clotted. She wept openly, unapologetically as he scrubbed her body clean, being careful to avoid her lower half.

Suddenly, she snatched the wash cloth from his hands and plunged it below the water, hissing in pain as she attempted to scrub him away. He didn't move to stop her, not until blood began to turn the water pink again.

"My Emperess," he nearly whimpered, "*please*-"

His begging tone snapped her out of it and she looked down, face going pale. She swayed and Hordak caught her, propping her up in the water. His touch sent her spiraling, his face was too familiar. She shoved him away, covering herself.

"Don't touch me. Don't *ever* touch me again."

Her words hurt, but pain was something he was used to. But *her* agony enraged him. Anger again. It never seemed to go away

now. Not at her. *Never* at her. But at everything else in the Universe.

He silently stood up, draped a towel beside the tub and moved to the bed. As she soaked, he folded a nightgown and left it on a chair for her. She sat there for an hour before Hordak approached again. He dipped a claw in the water, frowning at the now chilly water.

"My Emperess, you must get warm."

"Go away."

He nearly reached out to her, but hesitated, pulling back.

"Your wellbeing is my first concern-"

"Then why did you let him-?!" She cut herself off, curling in on herself as the memory of the night played back in her head.

He opened his mouth to speak again but snapped it shut again with an audible click. At that moment, a knock on the door inturupted his internal struggle.

"Entrapta?"

828 felt his eyes narrow involuntarily. That voice. Why did that voice irritate him so much? Lady Catra was a valued member of The Emperors Etherian Council. He had no reason not to trust her.

But when she was around Entrapta, he wanted nothing more than to claw her throat out.

Entrapta was facing away from him, sunk down deep in the cold water, barely able to keep her head up. She needed someone. Someone who wasn't him. Someone who wouldn't care if she didn't want help.

He eyed the star shaped scar on her back, frowning. Why did that scar make him think this was a bad idea?

He opened the door for Catra, glaring down at her. For a moment in the silence, he thought he remembered something. A spark. Violet. She had pulled something from him. Taken something precious. He shook his head and stepped aside, allowing her in.

"Lady Catra is here, your Majesty," he announced, bowing slightly for the feline.

Catra stepped past him, not meeting his eye. Refusing to. She looked horribly uncomfortable in a set of long white robes, the same ones she had worn earlier that day for the wedding. It was not a flattering look.

She glanced around the room, frowning and then outright snarling when she saw the new Emperess hunched over in a tub of cold dirty water.

"You're supposed to take care of her!" She snapped, reaching up to grab 828 by the collar, "what am I supposed to tell Prime?"

"She ordered me not to touch her," he growled back, slapping her hand away to her shock, "did you want me to force her? Like *he* did?"

Catra stepped back, mouth open in shock as she looked the clone up and down.

"*H-Hordak*...?" She whispered, then shook her head. "Ugh! We're wasting time! Whoever you are, just help me with her. The Emperor is coming."

Out of the corner of his eye, Hordak saw his Emperess flinch. He couldn't contain a growl.

"Wow. You're really mad, aren't you?" The Feline asked quietly, "you're always grumpy, but this? This is actually pretty scary."

He didn't respond. That block again. All the anger. All the rage. He was forced to swallow it down like bad medicine.

"You *are* Hordak, right?"

His fingers fiddled with the lace on the nightgown he'd just picked up.

"Shall I prepare a dress more suitable for an Emperial visit?" He asked automatically, prompting a sigh from Catra.

"Maybe not Hordak after all," she grumbled, sounding relieved. "Probably won't matter what she wears. He won't be here long anyway."

"What... does he want?"

They both turned to the source of the voice. Entrapta had tilted her head, staring up at the high ceiling of the Brightmoon suite.

"It doesn't matter. Out of the tub, Entrapta," Carra snapped, "I don't have time and I need to talk to you. Before he takes you away for good."

She grabbed her by her wet shoulder and hauled her out of the freezing water, half dragging her across the room.

"Hordak, 828, what ever you are, grab a towel and a brush. We've got work to do."

He hated taking her orders. He hated her voice. But he obeyed like a good little puppet. He passed a large towel to the feline, being extra careful not to touch the lady in her arms. Catra paused, mismatched eyes taking in the full gorey picture of her wedding night before she covered her broken body, looking away

"Go grab her some new clothes. Something... something that covers everything."

And for once, this was an order Hordak was happy to obey. He vanished into a closet, knowingly giving the two women time to speak in private.

"She Ra is in hiding," Catra hissed as soon as the clone was out of sight, "The Alliance is working with her to free you, but it might take some time. They wont be ready before you leave. Sparkles- err, Glimmer says she is sorry. She didn't want to do this."

Entrapta sunk into a chair, trembling hands in her lap.

"We *will* rescue you. It might take years, but we will. She wants you to know that it's a promise. She said... 'No Princess left behind.'" Catra looked away, biting her lip. "The sword. Hes bringing you shards of She Ra's sword. We had to surrender them as part of the peace treaty. But not all. Theres a peice missing. You *can't* repair the sword. Promise you wont. Stall for time."

"I'll... do my best," Entrapta whispered, looking down at her shaking hands. To her surprise, Catra grabbed them and touched the scar on her palm. It was at that instant a jolt of realization hit her.
"You. You hid me in the vents. You gave me the crystal. You... you tried to save me?"

Catra didn't respond. But a twitch if her ears gave the truth away.

"I'm so sorry, Entrapta. For... everything." She let go of her hands and turned to leave, but not before calling over her shoulder. "Believe in Adora. Please don't give up."

As she left the room, 828 reappeared, carrying a very conservatively cut silver dress. When he looked his mistress over again, he was shocked to see something new in her shining crimson eyes.

Hope.

"My darling wife," purred The Emperor, circling his new legally wedded bride, "it has only been a few hours, but I have missed you like the stars."

He traced a claw across her shoulder blades, causing a shiver to run up her sore back. 828 watched his Mistress keep her head high, despite the pain pulling her down. The crushing weight of trauma, the pressure of what she knew now, the sheer density of her future stretching out forever. And she was powerful enough to bear it.

Her fingers traced across her palm, reminding her if what she had forgotten.
She managed a smile and that was enough for him.

"My husband," she greeted, "to what do I owe the pleasure?"

828 watched the Emperors smile twitch and two of his green eyes narrowed some.

"Oh, I simply wished to check on you, Dear one. How do you feel?"

Entrapta did not flinch, even as he stopped in front of her, claws extended, tracing her bruised hips. Her face was set like a priceless jewel, though her eyes were dull as lead.

"Sore," she answered honestly, simply. And 828 knew it was the correct response, the one Prime wanted. His smile widened, green teeth flashed.

"My poor dear. Apologies. I often do not know my own strength." He sighed and placed a kiss on her forehead. Sweet, gentle. Like a different person entirely. Entrapta was starting to get used to this drastic personality shift.

"How was the meeting?" She asked, hoping her tone sounded conversational as he gently pressed into the small of her back to guide her deeper into the room. 828 bowed as they stepped past, but remained by the door with the Emperors clone attendants.

"Dull," he answered, sounding as bored as he no doubt felt as he sunk into a couch, dragging her with him, pulling her nearly on his lap. She quickly adjusted herself to sit next to him instead, hissing slightly at the pain the effort took.

"Much longer than I prefer. This princess with a red tail kept interrupting to ask about you. I eventually had to threaten to remove her tongue if she did not stop. You Etherians have a very shallow sense of relavance. I can see allowing your world to maintain it's own government was a mistake."

"...Scorpia asked about me?" She asked quietly, staring at her hands in her lap.

Prime snapped his fingers and an attendant approached with a tray while the other poured him a drink from it.

"Oh yes. Bothersome girl. Well. No matter. Soon we won't have to see her again. We leave in two days," he swirled his drink, holding it to the light to inspect it.

"Leave? To go where?" She asked nervously.

The Emperor tilted his head back, taking a deep sip of that bubbly teal liquid. He always seemed to be drinking. Part of her wondered if his anatomy worked the same and if he could get drunk like an Etherian. Her working hypothesis was a disheartening one. He was always a bit drunk every time she saw him. She'd have to conduct further studies.

"I must see to a small rebellion on the other side of the Galaxy. Nothing you need concern yourself with," he snorted dismissively, "you have a simple job-"

"The weapon?" She guessed, a little too quickly.

"*Children*," he corrected sternly, "your job is to give me heirs. But yes, also the weapon."

He sighed and quirked a finger at his clones. On demand, one produced a silk scarf covered tray and approached, kneeling in front of the couple.

"I am told this is the key," he pulled the scarf from the silver tray and, as expected, the shards of She Ra's sword lay scattered in jagged bits. "It was broken, but Queen Glimmer insists that if anyone can fix it, you can."

Entrapta reached out to wrap her small hands around the impossibly powerful hilt of the shattered sword. She held it up, watching the light dance off the scratched golden body, the sparkling Runestone at its center, still so alive, nearly sparking with strength.

"Well?" He snapped, pulling her at once from her daze, "how long?"

Entrapta placed it back and picked up another silver shard, this one now felt feather light, the geometric pattern flickering with every flash of light from the lamps. She hummed thoughtfully before placing it back.

"Months. Possibly years. I won't know for sure until I can examine it in my lab."

She caught 828's eye and he gave her a tiny nod. Good. A noncommittal answer. Prime seemed disappointed, but not angry.

"Shame, well I will allow you to work as much as you must then, with the assistance of my own science teams. I trust you will get to the bottom of it," his voice took on a sudden edge that made her nervous, "because I know how much you would hate to see me... disappointed."

As the tray was taken away, he reached out to her cheek, guiding her face to his. His lips ghosted over hers, not quite a kiss, but a threat of one. Then he let go and rose to his feet, leaving her shaking on the sofa.

"Go to sleep, Dear one. I promised to visit you tomorrow. I intend to keep my word."

There was a shocking softness in his tone and she knew she should be afraid, but somehow, when he spoke to her like that, she could almost pretend he loved her. In a sick, sad way, she wanted to pretend to love him back. In this turning, tumbling sea, love was all she could cling to.

The next day, he returned, just as he had promised. And also as he had promised, his intent to bed her was made obvious at once.

He wasted no time in sweeping her up, pressing a kiss to her quivering lips, sliding his tongue over hers. But as she was quickly discovering, her husband could be gentle as well as destructive. Today's lover was passionate, but careful, charming and sweet. He whispered gentle promises in her ear as he pulled her up into his arms bridal style and lay her down on the bed.

"I know you may still hurt, Dear One," he whispered soothingly, "I will go slow tonight. Inform me if I hurt you."

And, to his credit, when he began to undress her and she hissed in pain, he paused, asking where she hurt. He pressed a row of gentle kisses to her bruised hips. As he pulled her nightgown up her ravaged thighs, he took a moment to softly apologize for every scratch and every bruise as his lips met her flesh. And despite her better judgement, she whispered a soft exoneration for each one.

He paused suddenly, hovering over her desecrated womanhood. He let out a pitiable sigh, cool breath making her squirm.

"I am horribly ashamed, my love," he whispered, "could you forgive me for my terrible behavior? I had never intended to harm you so."

She swallowed the retort that nearly forced it's way up her throat. Had he not plainly spoken his intent to hurt her? But perhaps she imagined it. Was that possible too? He seemed so different.

She felt her mouth twitch Into a smile, hands reaching down to brush gently through his white ropes of hair. He purred against her fingers, placing a kiss to her vaginal lips, watching her face with one brilliant green eye.

"I-!" She gasped, squirming under him, "I f-forgive you for everything."

He grinned and pressed another kiss to her battered center, then again, going lower, then pressing his pointed green tongue to her entrance, monitoring her reaction.

Entrapta groaned, but not in pain this time. He withdrew and chuckled lightly as she sighed, disappointment evident as well as a touch of impatience.

"Hmm? Are we feeling better, my love?" He purred, reaching up to teasingly run a claw up her now warm wet slit.

Entrapta writhed, back arched. He withdrew a moment, studying her reaction cautiously until it became clear this was not pain, but pleasure. He smirked, repeating the motion, careful still, but bold. A similar reaction greeted his efforts. He caught her eyes in his, held her gaze, giving a sweet, reassuring smile as he pressed a finger inside.

She hissed, but this time he did not immediately pull away.

"Shh, Love," he soothed, pressing in further, "the pain will give way to pleasure. This is promise."

Eyes like rubies sparkled back at him, so broken, so trusting, so... needy. Perfect. He waited now, smiling kindly up at her until at long last, she dipped her head giving a single nod of consent.

It was enough. He lowered his mouth to the sensitive, erect little bud near the top of her lips, teasing it gently with the tip of his tongue. She gasped, fingers clutching the back of his head and pressing him in. He bit back a chuckle.

This reaction was difficult to fake convincingly. He'd seen many attempts at faking it during his youth. Wives who were too eager to please, too willing to inflate his ego. This was not that. And he was hardly young and naive anymore.

He pushed another finger inside the instant she felt suitably wet, flicking his tongue in time with every thrust. Soon she was rocking her hips against his motions, crying out loud enough that the wet sounds from his tongue and fingers were nearly drowned out. Nearly.

The pitch of her voice was thrilling, even more so, the sound of her mounting pleasure filled him with an almost boyish giddiness. He watched her with his top eye as she writhed in pleasure, shaking as waves of orgasmic bliss built like a tidal wave, crashing through her like a tsunami, before finally settling like a gentle ocean wave.

He waited, patient as her body settled under him before at last he pulled his fingers free of her tight grip. With a sly smirk on his face, he crawled up between her legs, hovering over her, mouth close to her ear.

"Enjoyed that, wife?" He whispered, then waited for her affirmation. Once she gave a nod, he leaned in, pressing a sweet kiss to her lips. He did not expect her to return the kiss, but she did and for the first time in a long time, the Emperor of an entire Universe was caught off guard. It was... nice?

He pulled away quickly, blinking. Shaken. Why? Her hands played with his hair, her eyes studied him with such an... innocence. He was lost. Her lips were moving, but it took him a moment too long to realize what she was saying.

"What's wrong?"

"Nothing," he answered too quickly, closing two eyes and taking a deep breath. "I am... simply-"

He growled under his breath and clumsily untangled himself from her. What was wrong with him? Was he sick? He hadn't been Ill in literal centuries! His body modifications should have made it impossible to fall ill!

He rose to his feet, ignoring the bewildered look on her face as his attendants redressed him.

"I-I'm sorry," she apologized quickly, clearly confused and perhaps a little hurt? He grit his teeth.

"Do not apologize," he hissed, feeling warm from his cheeks to the tips of his now drooping ears, "I simply believe a night of rest will be beneficial to you. I will return tomorrow."

He hurried from the room, leaving a bewildered Entrapta behind shivering in the bed with an equally shocked Companion approaching from his designated corner.

"Wha...? What was that about?" She asked 828 who could only blink and shake his head.

"I have no idea," he replied slowly, narrowing his eyes, "but what ever that was, I am glad for it. You need to sleep. Tomorrow will be a long day."

The Emperor of everything paced the royal shuttle, far too shaken to risk being seen in the palace of Brightmoon. Two clones stood at attention outside the shuttle, leaving the most powerful man in the Galaxy alone inside.

Alone. He hadn't been honestly alone like this is ages. He always had at least one clone with him. Who else was better to watch out

for him than himself? But suddenly the sight of them made him feel sick.

No. *She* did. The way she had looked at him just moments ago, the way she ran her fingers through his hair, the way she smiled and sighed-

"These are not my memories," he reminded himself with a growl, "these feelings are not my own."

He made his way to a mirror, studying his silvery reflection. The sight made him audibly gasp. His hair was disheveled, ropes of cords snaking around each other, confused, tangled. His lips quivered, makeup smudged and cracked. Under his eyes, dark circles from streaking eyeliner made him cringe.

No. Wait. Why was his eyeliner *streaking*? He raised a hand to his face, hissing when he pulled it away. Wet.

No. No. No. Not now. I haven't done anything. Nothing happened! Why-?!

He turned on a tap, warm water running out into a silver basin. Snatching a towel, he snarled as he scrubbed at his face, wiping it all away. The perfect being drained down the sink and when he looked back up, his reflection looked worn, tired. White face slightly discolored in some places, circles under his eyes a pale gray from too many days spent awake, full lips just a little thinner, but mostly the same as before, if not for the now visible scar above his lip.

He ran a claw over the almost pearly line, wincing at the memory.

"*Darling, you look terrible*."

Eyes widened, he tilted the vanity mirror until a beautiful, smiling face greeted him.

"Talullah," he sighed, clearly relieved, "what are you doing here?"

"Oh relax, Darling," she purred, sauntering over on her tentacles to place a kiss to his bare cheek, "nobody else saw you. It's just us. I know how you hate being seen without-" she waved a tentacle to the various products lining the vanity, "all this."

The wife snatched a fluffy white stool and pushed it against the back of her Emperors knees, prompting him to sink down onto it with a sigh.

"Why don't you tell me what's got you looking so messy, darling?" She soothed, massaging his shoulders with another tentacle. "I thought you'd be with the new girl tonight. Was big bad Entrapta mean to you?"

She was teasing. Prime hated being teased.

"I am your *Emperor*. Showing such disrespect-"

She pressed a particularly tense spot and he groaned, immediately forgetting his warning.

"Oh hush," she laughed, "how many years have we known each other? You know as well as I do that your posturing doesn't work on me."

He snorted, but shrugged in agreement.

"You didn't hurt her, did you?" Talullah asked, digging into his spine with practiced tentacles, "I'm fond of that girl. She is very sweet."

The Emperor looked away.

"*Anillis*!" She gasped using his first name, sounding outright scandalized, "we've talked about this!"

The Emperor growled under his breath, but still said nothing for a long time. Not until she pressed a light kiss to the back of his head.

"She is a complication," he mumbled, looking up at the ceiling, "I have... emotions."

"Of course you do-"

"I mean, about her. Specifically."

The tentacles on his shoulder froze and she moved around to look him right in his eyes

"Wait. Are you actually in love?"

"Of course not!" He snarled, avoiding eye contact at all cost, "I believe that when I probed the mind of that defect, I may have allowed too much of his emotions in. That is all. It will pass."

The woman shook her head and rolled her eyes.

"You know, it wouldn't kill you to show some small bit of genuine emotion now and again. All this acting, playing. The hot and cold... would it be so bad if you did fall in love with your Emperess?"

All four eyes studied his reflection and once more a claw rose to touch that thin, ancient scar on his face.

"Yes. It would," he answered darkly, "it really would."

Gold

Etheria looked impossibly small from up here. The planet floated in an ocean of black, surrounded by a thousand silver fish.

Entrapta placed a hand against a thick window in her royal chambers, tracing the outline of her home. She was far from sentimental, but she still wanted to memorize every lake and valley and mountain. Hold it in her heart and never let it go.

Because there was hope now and that was enough to keep her going.

"Your Majesty," 828 called from the other side of the room, "it is time."

She pressed her scared palm to the cold window for a moment more before letting it drop with a sigh.

"Alright. I'm ready now."

828 looked his mistress up and down once more, brows knitted together in concern. She looked so tired, worn. Her hair, beautiful, powerful, angelic, now dragged limply behind her. Her eyes, even brightened by six different makeup products, looked lifeless and dull. Her dolls smile was so automatic now, like a mask she could slip on and off.

She still looked beautiful, 828 never for an instant thought otherwise, but it was a very quiet beauty. A cold beauty. She reminded him of freshly fallen snow, hushed and shining, but devoid of real life.

The Emperess pulled herself away from her planet at last, not knowing when or if she would see it again. But it was stil there. Knowing it was there was enough. For so long, she had dreamed about this, leaving, exploring the stars, the wider universe.

And now that her dream was at hand, all she wanted to do was go back.

The Emperor waited impatiently on his throne, long perfectly manicured nails tapping in time with his heartbeat. She wasn't late, not yet, but he still hated to be kept waiting. He hadn't seen her since this morning as they departed from Brightmoon. She'd been especially captivating, dressed in a glittering gold gown, matching his own garments. A tribute to Brightmoon and, in extension, Etheria. They should be honored.

Instead, the crowd had been silent, stone faced. And Prime felt... off. Uncomfortable. Of course he played his part. He smiled, waved, kissed his Emperess and mourned the shortness of their visit, vowing to return soon and often. A threat more than a promise. A personal visit from the Emperor was rarely good news.

"Her Imperial Majesty," A clone announced in a crisp monotone, breaking the Emperor from his impatient daydreaming. He rose to his feet at once, nearly leaping down the dias and crossing the large throne room to greet her as she entered with her Companion close at hand.

Prime did not even wait for 828-1075 to bow and hand her over. He swooped in and pulled her close, breaking her light grasp on the defective clones arm with ease. The clone blinked, looking unsure of what to do, but bowed and stepped back at once to blend in with the rest of his kind.

"My Dear One, has it only been a few hours since I saw you last?" He murmured, pulling away to bend slightly and pull her hand to his lips, "You look more radiant with every passing second."

Entrapta raised an eyebrow at him as he straightened up and led her away. He said it so quietly. Did he mean to? Normally everything he said was so loud, so theatrical, so purposeful. Soft

words only for her in a public setting? This was new. And this with his odd behavior the night before...

She glanced behind her at 828, catching his eye for only an instant before he looked away, cheeks going red.
What was happening?

On either side of the throne room his spouses were lined up in order of rank leading to the seat of power. Behind them, nearly four dozen children of varying ages stood and waited as well. Amongst them, she spotted Terr, tail swishing as she waved from her place by the throne.

It was enough to distract Entrapta. Enough that she didn't notice the gold silk covered foot sticking out from under a pooling skirt.

A hush fell over the gathered royal family when the Emperess stumbled. She was caught by her husband quickly, but the damage was done. She looked up at her Emperor, and caught his frown. Displeasure. She righted herself at once.

"Are you alright, wife?" He asked stiffly, guiding her up the dias.

"I... guess my skirt was a little too long?" She glanced behind her catching a flash of gold as it vanished under yards of fabric.

"I will have your wardrobe readjusted," he murmured, gripping her arm almost painfully as they ascended the stairs. Anger? She assumed it was anger, or he was simply trying to prevent her from tripping again.

He sunk into his throne, graceful, beautiful. His long limbs folded neatly into place as he pulled her hand to his lips once more before carefully guiding her to the right side of his throne to stand.

She felt awkward. Embarrassed. All eyes were on her now. In a sea of white and gold, she stood above the rest. Too bright. Too noticable. Too... visible. She hated this.

"My friends, my *family*, today we leave victorious," her Imperial husband declared, "for, without a single drop of bloodshed, we have liberated another world and brought them under our glorious protection. Let us now welcome Etheria into our happy little family."

He smiled at Entrapta and she smiled back as he rose to his feet once more. He reached for her hand and pulled her to the center. Panic. Fear. Obedience. At the back of the crowd, she saw 828 watching, but she quickly lost sight of him when the Emperor touched her cheek.

From off to the side, a gold tray with two crystal goblets full of a strange rosey liquid was presented and her husband released her. He grabbed both goblets with shining talons and held one to her. All around, the spouses as well as the older children were obtaining glasses as well.

"*Etheria*!" He called to his court, raising his glass.

A chorus responded in kind, "*Etheria*!"

Entrapta didn't move, didn't speak until four crystal green eyes focused on her. She cleared her throat, raised her glass and murmured the name of the only home she had ever known.

"Etheria."

Entrapta stood still as stone, biting her lip as her husband gave the order to leave Etheria at last and the gathered court gave a cheer. Entrapta desperately wanted to leave, to run to the nearest view port, watch the stars speed past. It was something she had only ever dared to dream about. Traveling the stars. Once she even entertained the idea of leaving Etheria with Hordak to do it.

She again looked out across the sea of glittering, beautiful aliens, catching her Companions eye. Well. In a way, perhaps she was doing what she'd dreamed.
Not *exactly* what she had envisioned, not the way she had wanted it, but it was her dream come true none the less.

The joyful Emperor sunk back down in his throne, dragging Entrapta down onto his lap with a laugh, spilling his drink, careless. And at once, the atmosphere changed. All around them, the court burst into life. Music played, drinks flowed and food was brought out.

"Ahh, my Emperess," he sighed, lips close to her ear, "Now we celebrate in public, but tonight, I would like us to celebrate in private as well."

"What are we celebrating, Your Majesty?" She asked automatically, still gazing out across the festivities at her Companion who was standing still and quiet against a wall. He may as well have been a piece of furniture for all anyone else seemed to care. But to Entrapta, he was the most important person in the room.

A claw at her chin forced her gaze to divert. Her husband flashed his green grin at her and gently laced the arm that was still holding his drink around her waist. As he pressed her back against him, his firm erection dug against her spine.

"Why, we are celebrating *you*, Dear One," he whispered "you've absolutely captured the hearts of my subjects across the Universe. My approval ratings have never been higher."

He chuckled and dipped his face into the crook of her neck, nuzzling her like a lover.

"That ridiculous Queen was right about you," he purred, "you are like a flawed jewel. All you need is a little polishing."

Entrapta looked away, face neutral. She was learning how to hide her fear well.

"And I... intend," he whispered, trailing his lips up her neck, planting kisses like seeds, "to polish you... my Dear... until you... glow."

A shiver ran up her spine and she quickly brought her glass to her lips, distraction as well as function. He said it himself, after all, it would be easier if she had a bit to drink. The liquid tickled her tongue, but was not unpleasant. In fact, she found herself wishing for a second glass by the time hers was empty.

Luckily, Prime seemed to notice and with a chuckle, waved an attendant to fill her goblet before she had to ask. Each sip tasted better than the last. Each swallow eased the pain in her heart like anesthesia. She caught sight of another wife in the crowd tilting her head back and drinking deep as well. The beautiful one with golden skin. What had her name been? Zalah?

She looked up at Entrapta catching her eye for an instant before Entrapta looked away blushing. Eventually she knew she would have to get to know them. Soon. But Entrapta, for all her social awkwardness, was self aware enough to know she was often times grating and hard to spend more than an hour with. The only one who never seemed annoyed with her quirks was Hordak. And he was...

She glanced again across the throne room where he was still standing like a statue. Her eyes kept drifting to the other end, to him. It was only a matter of time until her husband noticed.

Emperor Prime was not used to jealousy. He was not used to being ignored either. Yet here he was, watching his wife stare wistfully across the room at a puppet. He squeezed her waist, trying not to frown. Too many eyes on him now. He had to smile, he had to be joyful, peaceful, perfect.

She glanced back at him over her shoulder and his heart skipped a beat. There it was again. That look in her eyes.

Oh, The Emperor was well acquainted with love. He was a being capable of much affection, who had fallen in and out of love more times than he could count. And every love was deep, *real*.

But there was something in her eyes that made him question himself. His motives, his entire purpose.

He touched a lavender tendril of hair, ran a finger over it in a daze.

"*Entrapta*," he whispered, too quiet to be heard over the laughing and music. It was the first time he had really used her name, the first time he really appreciated the weight of it on his tongue. It felt like home, safe, warm.

She reminded him of someone long gone, he had realized. A woman who had been his first Emperess. And it *hurt*.

It hurt so good.

"Your Majesty?"

The velvety voice of Rawnie pulled him from his dark thoughts. He realized at once that his smile had vanished and he pulled it back on like a scarf in cold weather.

"My dearest," he greeted as the wife approached and dipped into a graceful bow. He held a hand out for her and she took it, pressing her perfect gold painted lips to the back of his fingers before rising.

Ah, she was a beauty. She reminded him of a nebula, the way her pale violet eyes sparked and shifted, never quite the same from one moment to another. Much like her smile. He observed the way it twisted up at the corners, the way her eyes squinted at his new Emperess. She bowed to her as well, but, he noted, less deeply.

"Some of the others wanted to really meet our new... sister," she practically sang, looking from Entrapta to her husband, "May we borrow her?"

Prime held his nearly empty glass out to be filled, sobriety creeping up on him too quickly.

"Dear One?" He asked the woman on his lap, "would you like to?"

Entrapta looked nervous, but she nodded. He held back his disappointment and let her slide off his lap.

"I'll bring her back in one piece," the woman promised, clasping Entraptas hand and pulling her down the stairs. And despite being in a crowded room, the Emperor found himself quite alone once more.

"Do you dance?" Rawnie asked in her sweet, sing-song voice. It reminded Entrapta of chocolate, smooth, heavy, rich. It was no wonder Prime had taken her as a wife. Entrapta herself could fall for this sirens song of hers.

"Dance? Uh, no. It was never necessary."

The other wife looked at her with pity.

"A shame," she sighed, pulling her along still, "our husband *loves* to dance. Did you know? He is as graceful on his feet as he is in bed."

Entrapta blushed and looked away. From through the crowd, the face of Talullah caught her eye. The other woman opened her mouth to say something, to rescue the newest wife, but a sea of courtiers flooded by and she lost sight of her.

"I am sorry," Rawnie laughed like raindrops, "I had assumed he consummated the marriage already. Did he not...?"

"H-he did," Entrapta replied, shivering and touching a bruise on her arm.

"Oh. Then was it not... *satisfactory*?" She raised a thin white eyebrow, golden lips pulled into a teasing smirk.

"It... It hurt," she admitted, choosing her words less carefully than a more socially graceful woman might.

The wife laughed once more, turning Entraptas face a brilliant shade of scarlet.

"Well of course it hurt!" She cried just a little too loud, "but were you not satisfied? Oh, perhaps you are used to sleeping with his clones?"

In the middle of the throne room, Entrapta froze.

"*Excuse* me?"

She pulled her hand from the other wife's grip, face set in a near snarl. The other woman turned back to face her and Entrapta caught a flash of a familiar golden slippered foot peeking from under her gown

She's the one who tried to trip me, she realized at once.

"Hm? Don't you *know*? That's what everyone is saying. That you were sleeping with that defect," she laughed again, violet eyes sparking like stars, "so is it true? I think it is. Our husband did well to erase him. Personally, I would have put him down permanently. A defect like that. Tell me, did you enjoy his coc-"

A slap rang out through the throne room. The stinging in her palm told Entrapta what she had done before she could even process it herself. She stared in wonder down at her throbbing hand, then back to the other wife who was now holding her pale pink cheek. Her gold lipstick was smeared, but her eyes shone with victory.

This was exactly what she had wanted, and Entrapta realized far too late. She had fallen into her trap.

By this point, she was acutely aware that a small circle had formed around them and the large throne room was eerily quiet.

"I-!" Entrapta opened her mouth to apologize, but the crowd parted like a roaring mouth and the tall, beautiful form of The Emperor approached, two clone attendants a few paces behind him. The crowd bowed like a wave as he passed, and Entrapta couldn't breathe. She looked around, frantic, drowning.

All four eyes narrowed, focus cut between both women.

Then he sighed.

"Jealousy is unattractive," he declared, "An apology will be made."

Entrapta nodded, swallowing. She cleared her throat awkwardly.

"I'm so-"

"Not you," he snapped, turning all four eyes on Rawnie, "*you*."

The other wife stared at the Emperor open mouthed, shocked.

"Me?!" She nearly shrieked, voice immediately losing it's musical quality, "but she-!"

"*Defended her reputation from slander.*"

The voice that spoke next was one Entrapta did not recognize until the beautiful golden Zalah stepped out from behind the large form of the Emperor, head high, proud, like a glistening beacon of justice.

Prime took her golden hand in his and lifted it to his lips.

"Thank you for informing me of the situation, my love," he murmured, before dropping her hand again to step forward. "Apologize. Now."

For thirty seconds, neither woman said a word and then, Rawnie slowly lowered herself to the floor, kneeling at her feet.

"I apologize for my words. They were out of turn."
She sounded robotic and snooty, like a child, but Entrapta didn't care. She simply wanted this humiliating moment to be over.

She glanced to her husband for guidance, but he was not looking her way, in fact, he almost seemed to want to look anywhere else. No sign from him on how to properly end this so she did what she'd learned from her Princess friends on Etheria.

"Its okay! Let's be friends!" Smiling, she held out a hand, expecting the other wife to take it. Instead, she simply rose to her feet and bowed once more.

"Thank you for your mercy," the robotic voice once again said.

"You are dismissed," Horde Primes airy tone was colder than anything Entrapta had heard in her life and judging by the desperate look on Rawnies pale pink face, it felt the same for her.

The other woman bowed to the Emperor and left the throne room as fast as she could, her clone Companion following close behind.

The instant the doors slid closed again, the Emperor turned on his heel to step back to his throne, leaving Entrapta behind. At once when he sat down and crossed his legs, the music started again, but the atmosphere had changed dramatically. Nobody would quite look at her, not even him.

She approached the throne anyway, bowing as she stepped forward.

"Your Majesty," she greeted, feeling her heart sink a little as one of his husbands stepped around from behind the throne. The pretty golden haired one with the matching nail guard. She watched him trail his metal clad finger up the Emperors arm, smiling coyly down at her.

"Mmm? Dear One, are you well?" He asked distractedly, two eyes on her while the other two wistfully watched the other man kneel at his side, running his long mocha colored fingers up the

Emperors hand, kissing it with painted lips, dark tongue gently flickering against a claw.

Entrapta tried not to stare.

"I just wanted to... thank you. For coming to my rescue."
Her voice felt impossibly tiny and she looked away, blushing. Not only was it humiliating to thank her captor, but she could see the other man begin to suck at his fingers, his moans loud, even over the music.

"I am not the one who deserves your gratitude," he sighed, suppressing a moan, "Zalah noticed and reported to me. Thank her."

"O-oh. Right..." Entrapta glanced behind her, then back at her husband who now had the other man stretched across his lap, running kisses up his broad, powerful chest, leaving gold lip prints behind.
"I...um, may I be excused?"

The Emperor simply waved a hand and Entrapta bowed once more before heading back down.

"I will visit tonight," he called after her, making her blood run cold, "be ready for me."

Entrapta glanced behind her as her husband moaned loudly, the golden haired male now sucking lightly at his neck. It was only for an instant, but it was enough. The heat in the pit of her belly was unimaginable. She needed to leave. Fast.

On the way to the exit, the crowd parted and a sea of courtiers bowed for her. She looked for Zalah in the crowd, but her savior was nowhere to be seen. She made a silent promise to seek her out at another time, maybe invite her to tea. *Did* they drink tea? Did anyone here drink tea? She'd never been offered tea. Fizzy drinks and small desserts then, she decided as she approached the large doors leading out of the throne room.

828 slid beside her, offering an arm, which she took, but very lightly. Touch. She was still so averse to touch, he noted. Her words echoed endlessly in his mind like a song.
Don't ever touch me again.

The instant the door closed behind them and they were no longer being watched, she dropped her hand from his arm and hurried ahead, following the familiar path to her chambers. And like a good companion, 828 followed without a word.

It was not often that his word was broken, but as The Emperor thrust his hips into his kneeling and mewling husband, he knew he would not be keeping his appointment with his Emperess that night. He would have to send his regrets and a gift, but for now, his every focus was on the golden haired Prince panting beneath him.

He ran his talons up his perfect spine, admiring the sharp angle of the bone, the way his rippling muscles quaked and flexed with every jerk of his hips, his toned and smooth legs, athletic and beautiful.

The Prince moaned and whispered something in his own language and Prime responded in kind, loving and affectionate. As he neared his limit, he nuzzled the back of his lovers neck, murmuring his permission to orgasm, an order the Prince was more than happy to obey.

The Emperor followed and pressed his hips deep inside of him with a low, breathy groan. As he collapsed, panting, next to his husband, the cool air of his chambers sent him shivering until his lover pulled the plush covers up to warm him. Prime sleepily muttered his thanks and pulled the Prince close.

For a long time, they said nothing until they managed to catch their breath.

"Dhar?" The Emperor opened one eye as his husband moved, looking up at him with a smile.

The golden Prince smirked down at his Emperor, twinkling orange eyes mischievous. He held a strange violet crystal to the light, head tilted to the side.

"LUVD," Dhar read after a moment, "That is what it says, yes? Eternian isn't my first language, of course, but I think that's what it says."

Prime frowned and quickly reached up to snatch the crystal from his hands.

"Aww, what's wrong my love?" The other man teased, running a hand through his white ropes of hair, "*jealous*? Is that why you keep this beside your bed?"

The Emperor sat up suddenly, fingers tightening over the crystal.

"Out," he ordered, tone turning icy, "Now. I am tired."

The Prince opened his mouth to object, but seemed to think better of it. He stepped out of the large white imperial bed and his companion stepped in at once to assist him in redressing.

"Touchy! Fine fine, but if you decide you want round two, Love," Dhar called, winking at his Emperor over his shoulder, "you know where to find me."

The Emperor said nothing, did not even nod in acknowledgement that he heard him. Once Dhar was gone and the Emperor was alone, he opened his palm, all four eyes studying the Etherian writing.

"*Loved*."
Frowning, he lay it back down on the white table beside the bed. "Inform my Emperess that I will be unable to visit her tonight," he called out to an attendant, "send my regrets and my... love."

Pink

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

For two days, Entrapta waited in her chambers. 828 nervously paced the length of the room, his slightly discolored claws pawing at his robes. Entrapta had never seen him nervous. She didn't even know he was capable of being nervous. Not like this.

"He should have come to visit again," she heard the clone mumbled to himself as he paced, "it is her fertile period. Why is he not here? He only bedded her once. Did-?"

"I'm *glad* he isn't here," Entrapta snapped, staring up at the stars in the transparent ceiling, "I don't want to have his heirs."

828 stopped his pacing, looking up with an absolutely unreadable expression.

"If you do not, then he can set aside the marriage."

"Good," Entrapta snapped.

"No. *Bad*," the clone corrected, "if that happens, then the peace alliance with Etheria will be broken and he can legally eliminate you, maybe the entire world if the mood takes him. If you can't keep his love-"

Entrapta sat up straight, shaking. He was right. Catras words played in her head once again, reminding her of her duty.

"What can I do?"

"You... came to see me?"

The Emperor raised a brow at his newest bride. So small at the foot of his throne. He should be annoyed at her. He should punish her for bothering him while he worked, especially without first seeking permission. 828 had not informed him of this.

To his surprise, he did not mind the sudden intrusion. In fact, he was rather... *thrilled* by it. It was a curiosity, the feeling this female gave him. Love wasn't quite the right word, was it?

"Oh. Was I not supposed to? Sorry. You just come to see me all the time, I thought-"

"No. It is acceptable," he nodded, focusing his gaze just past her shoulder, "you are my wife. You are welcome to come and go as you please."

His own words surprised him. He was essentially giving her free reign. Still, he supposed she couldnt possibly do any... lasting harm. Two eyes slid to the clone standing one step behind her, silently giving him a warning. He was to tell him ahead of time from now on, but not stop her. He wanted to win her over, while also maintaining order. A bit of preplanning would be needed to maintain the illusion of freedom, but it was essential.

"What can I do for you, Dear One?"

His wife looked uncomfortable for a moment, but stepped forward, trying to look him right in the eye. At least one of them.

"Nothing. I just thought I should visit you every so often. You're always coming to see me. I read somewhere that relationships of the romantic variety require effort from both parties involved."

The Emperor blinked, stunned, honestly truly stunned. It took a moment for him to recover enough to actually form a reply. He was thankful that the only ones in the throne room at the moment were mindless drones. He cleared his throat, hoping the heat on his cheeks was not obvious.

"So there is no reason for your visit other than to simply... see me?"

She nodded.

"I'm sorry," she murmured, looking down, "Did I make you mad?"

"No," he answered a little too quickly, "no. I am simply unused to being approached in such an... informal manner."

He took another deep breath, wordlessly dismissing two of his attendants, although two at the door remained as well as 828.

"Come," he beckoned to her, sounding almost tired.

She obeyed, stepping up the dias, approaching the throne. She had been on this throne before with him. But never like this. The empty throne room felt large without anyone else here. With nobody to show off to, the gesture felt natural. Affectionate. *Loving*.

He held a hand out to her and she took it as she always did. She would not dare ignore his beckoning claws. With a gentle, caring grip, he guided her until her back was facing him.

"Do you see it?" He whispered, tracing a hand across her hip, "An entire Universe laid out before you. This is the view from the top."

She swollowed, breathing deep. From this distance it all looked so... *small*. His grip tightened slightly as he guided her close, between his parted legs. Her eyes studied the throne room as his hands explored her thigh now through the thin gown she wore. His breath was deep, even, but had a hiss to it that betrayed his intentions, his desires. Before she even felt his manhood press into her back, she knew exactly what he would want.

Emperor or not, he was still a creature of instinct.

"Sit, Dear One. Enjoy the view. It is a treat I offer so very few."

She obeyed because she had no choice. Acting was not anything she had a talent for, so she simply did not try. But she did exaggerate her eagerness to spend time with him. She bent the truth. But would not break it. If she outright lied, he would know.

So when he ran a hand down her leg to tug her skirt up, he found her excited giggle to be genuine. Entrapta was a creature of instinct too, much as she hated to admit and his touch could feel... so very good. Talullah was right.

"You... didn't visit me last night, or the night before" she sighed as he pressed his mouth against her neck, "I thought you might be mad."

He pulled away suddenly.

"Because you slapped Rawnie?" He tapped her thigh thoughtfully. "I was... disappointed, I admit. I wish for all of my loved ones to get along perfectly. But she can be a challenge. It was kind of you to offer her friendship."

Entrapta wasn't certain how to respond so she reached down to grasp his hand. She was full of such uncertainty, such fear. Was this right? Was she offering enough affection?

The way he clasped her hand back told her she was on the right track.

"I want to... try," she murmured, "to be a wife. Will you, um, accept my apology?"

This seemed to stun her husband. He put a claw to her chin and guided her face to look at him over her shoulder.

"Apology? For what, Dear One?"

Entrapta swallowed and bit her lip, eyes wandering around the throne room, anywhere but him.

"I'm not sure," she answered with a nervous laugh, "but you don't want to come to my bed. So I thought I must have done *something* wrong."

The Emperor was certain now that his cheeks must be the color of her eyes. Pink and glowing. He swallowed, flustered, feeling like a boy with his first crush. Feeling like he did when he first met... *her*.

"I believe I am the one who owes an apology," he mumbled, "I have been busy. Rebellions to put down, a universe to rule, you understand."

Entrapta nodded, but she didn't believe it. Not really.

"You said I could come to you for, um, sexual stimulation?" She asked, waiting until he gave a stiff nod of confirmation, "um... s-so can we...?"

"Here?" The Emperor raised a brow ridge, smiling in a way that made Entrapta all too aware of the ache between her legs.

"Yes," she replied hesitantly, meeting the eyes of 828 for a little too long before adding, "please."

828 looked away, but he could hear what was happening a little too well. The words the Emperor whispered to his bride would make anyone witnessing uncomfortable. Even the door guards seemed to shift, looking in opposite directions from the scene playing out before them.

Entrapta giggled, yet 828 remained silent as the grave. He stood, still as a doll on a shelf, unblinking, politely averting his eyes while in the prison of his mind, Hordak raged.

Every sound hurt. Every gasp, every squeal, every giggle. The way her voice hitched when the Emperor licked her neck, the way she groaned when his fingers fell between her legs, the way she sighed and purred when he brought her pleasure.

She let out a sharp cry and 828 looked up again, worried for his mistress. The sight sent his mind tumbling. He fought to look away, pushed and pulled, struggling. It sunk him like a stone in the ocean.

She sat on his lap, legs spread wide. Her skirt was pulled up to her thighs, but the top of her dress was pulled down exposing her breasts. Hordak roared, struggling to reach for the Emperors claws, wanting nothing more than to pull them off her soft hips. He would pull him apart, rip his green teeth out one by one so he could never bite her again. He would break his talons off and shove them deep into his manhood so he could never do this again. He would make him feel it, make him hurt. Every bruise, every scratch, every scar. He would pay for it all.

But still 828 did not move. As the Emperor bucked his hips against her, pulling her down against him, 828 remained still. As Entrapta grit her teeth, allowing herself to be used, enjoyed, the green gaze of 828 remained focused on the couple.

Every passing second, he saw the light in her ruby eyes die a little. Soon her lifeless eyes found his, half closed in reluctant pleasure. He wanted nothing more than to touch her face, whisper something soothing. At the front of his mind, he was sure this was necessary. This was what he had been programmed to want. This was meant to be. But still the beast inside raged and a new emotion crawled to the surface.

Jealousy.

Over her shoulder, four brilliant citron eyes met his. It was only for a moment, then they squeezed shut as a shiver ran through his body. 828 watched as he thrust hard into her, holding her tight until his talons tore fabric and flesh at her waist. A flash of green teeth was all he saw before they sunk into her neck.

And then it was over. And Hordak grieved.

Panting against her neck, the Emperor licked at the bloody bite. His hands softened on her body as he held her against him. Again in his strange language, he whispered words of affection for her, pausing between praises to lap up another droplet of blood before it could roll down her neck.

Entrapta felt nothing. For not the first time, she felt such a vast emptiness, she was certain it rivaled the vaccuum of space. She waited patiently to be released, having done her duty. That was all it was. Duty. A job.

"I should go lay down," she finally said, "I heard that it's better for conception to lay on your back after."

If Entrapta was being honest, she wasnt sure if she actually did read that, or if she was making it up. Either way, it got her out of her husband's arms. He slouched almost lazily on his throne as she pulled her dress down, wincing.

"Visit me when the mood takes you, my love."

The throne rotated, facing a bright screen, a map. As Entrapta silently made her way out of the throne room, the Emperor found himself clutching his chest, breathing just a little too deep. He swallowed hard as the door whooshed shut, leaving him nearly alone.

His two clone attendants approached and he quickly waved a hand, dismissing them before they could reach the throne. Nobody could see him like this. Nobody could come close. It was happening again. That feeling. Everything about her felt familiar. He hadn't noticed until recently, but her every expression, her voice, even the warmth of her body against his, it was all identical to her. His late wife. His first Emperess.

They'd brought the Universe to its knees together. He'd loved so many, but never quite like her. And then she was gone.

Shaking, the Emperor touched the vivid green gemstone on one of his bracers. Memories played in his mind like recordings. Her

pretty pink hair had fascinated him. She smiled like sunrise on a clear day and her eyes glowed like the night. For centuries, he loved her, *exclusively* her. And though they had no children, she had been at his right hand while he built his empire. And he was happy. He'd been so content with just her.

He pulled away from his memories, falling forward to bury his face in his hands.

"She isn't her," he reminded himself, "she never will be."

And yet, the feeling in his heart was so very similar.

"This will pass. These feelings are not my own. This will pass," he whispered like a prayer, "this will pass."

Entrapta *did* lay down when she returned. It wasnt a complete lie. After a long bath, of course. She wanted to go to the lab today, but she just couldn't make herself get up.

"We must prepare you for the evening, your Majesty," 828 murmured from his place seated beside the bed.

Her eyes snapped to her companion who had been nearly silent since they had returned from the throne room. He picked at a gown of hers on his lap, seemingly annoyed with the way some bit of embroidery was laying in the fabric. A defect in the garment. An imperfection.

"Leave it be," Entrapta murmured, sitting up in bed.

"Your Majesty. You can not attend to your duties in a flawed garment."

His voice was so small, he avoided her gaze. Somehow, Entrapta wasnt sure they were still talking about the dress anymore.

"Its okay," she whispered, sliding off the bed and reaching down to cover her companions shaking hands, "flaws are fine. Imperfections are... beautiful."

His shaking hands loosened on the dress and he stopped his nervous picking. Green eyes flashed for only a moment when he looked up. Recognition. Green, yellow, orange. Nearly red.

She squeezed his hands, certain that this time would do it. She would reach out, pull him through.

And then a knock sounded at her door and Hordak- no, 828 rose to his feet, passing the dress to his Mistress while he went to answer. A few words were exchanged and when 828 reappeared, he carried a tray full of pretty pastries. Tiny ones.

Entrapta tilted her head as the tray was laid down on a low glass table.

"828, what's this?"

The clone blinked down at the plate of bite sized pastries on the low table.

"A gift, I assume," he replied slowly, "Ah, a note."

He lifted the folded paper, reading the sharp alien writing, sighing.

"A gift from his Imperial majesty" he announced, "I assume this means he is quite pleased with you. These were made with berries from his personal garden."

Entrapta pulled her fluffy white robe closer around her body as she eyed the large bowl of sweet looking fruit confections.

"He gardens?" She raised a purple brow, sinking into the pretty white sofa in front of the table.

"Is that really such a surprise, My Love?"

Entrapta jumped and looked up, blushing a deep pink. 828 bowed deeply and made himself scarce as the Emperor strode into the room. On his handsome face was a passive smile as all four eyes explored his Emperess. The small woman scurried to her feet to bow, but he stopped her with a raised hand as he sunk into the sofa next to her.

"Well? Have you tried any yet?" He gestured to the pastries in front of her, and frowned when she shook her head. In response, he reached for the plate with one hand and pulled her against him with the other.
"Eat," he ordered, "I am told they are delicious. I had the finest chef prepare them for you based on an Etherian recipe."

Entrapta felt her traitor stomach growl just then and give her away. Well, in her defense, they *did* look quite delicious. She reached across his lap to where he was holding the tray to grab one and quickly pop it in her mouth.

Then she grabbed another. And another. And before she knew it, a third of the pastries were gone and now her husband was chuckling while he guided one to her pretty painted lips. They opened without protest, accepting the offered treat eagerly. Almost *too* eagerly.

The Emperors eyes widened, betraying his surprise as her pretty pink tongue darted out to lick at the sugar on his fingers. A familiar stirring rose in him. So soon. Too soon, or so he had thought, but the tightening under his robe told him differently.

Wordlessly, he met her eyes, holding her now somewhat playful gaze steady as he brought another to her smiling lips. Her tongue curled around a finger and he allowed her to suck on it. With a pop he pulled them away then grabbed another. On cue, she opened her mouth, fingers trailing along his thigh.

He blinked at his own reaction then chuckled.

"What has gotten into you today, Dear One?" He whispered, grazing the tiny treat over her smiling lips.

"*You*," she breathed, "you did, I guess."

He pulled away slightly from where she was now nipping at his fingers and chuckled.

"My Love," he reached for her chin to guide her face to his, "why don't we take this to the bed?"

He could feel her breath on his lips, feel her heart hammering against him like a caged bird desperate to escape, smell the sweet berry tarte on her tongue. She leaned in close, lips ready to touch his in answer-

"*Your Majesty*!"

At that moment, just before his lips could touch hers, a pretty white haired girl burst through, holding a blinking data pad. Entrapta knew who this was by now, of course. Her husbands personal assistant and adult daughter, Beck. She paused, taking in the scene with a blush and diped into a formal bow, apologizing for the intrusion.

"Beck. Explain. Now," he attempted to keep his irritation out of his voice, after all, were it not an emergency, nobody would have dared interrupt his alone time with a new wife.

"Sir, the rebellion. Theres been another attack. This time on the Cloning facility-"

He stood up with a sigh, silencing his daughter at once. He would have to see to this immediately. *Personally*. With great force.

"Apologies, my love," he murmured, placing the now nearly empty tray back on the table and reaching for her hand. Behind his calm, cool demeanor, he was enraged. Under the flowing gray robes, his arousal was obvious. He almost had her again. Ah well. He would survive without an orgasm for a few hours.

He placed a gentle kiss to the back of her hand before flipping it over to kiss her scarred palm as well. LUVD. He read the words again and frowned, dropping it at once. Without another word to his wife, he turned on his heel and left, Beck hurrying after him, filling him in on all the details of the attack.

Entrapta was relieved. The instant he was gone, she let out a shaky breath that she didn't even know she was holding. 828 approached cautiously but froze at once when he saw the look in her eyes. The tears.

"Was that... good enough?" She asked shakily, "I thought maybe it might convince him if I..."

Her shoulders shook as she looked away. From where 828 watched her, he knew she was weeping. Her knees were tucked against her chest, her breathing was unsteady. Fear. She was afraid. He knew she was, but her orders still stood and he would never touch her without permission. Not again.

"H-Hordak, are you in there?" She whispered between sobs, "I *need* you."

828 did not answer directly. He couldn't. There was that wall that held him back, that held Hordak at bay. Silently, he pulled a blanket from her bed and set it over her shoulders. He couldn't say why this seemed like the right thing to do. Not really. A distant memory, being wrapped in a blanket, safe, warm.

It didn't make sense to him, but she stopped weeping and that was enough for him. She was staring at him for a while before he noticed. Her wet eyes locked onto his and he blinked back, face hot.

"Hordak, you're blushing," she noted and 828 lifted a steady claw to his cheek, knowing full well that it would be warm to the touch.

"Get some rest, your Majesty," he finally managed to choke out after a momentary struggle to subdue the pink on his face.

"Okay," she whispered, falling sideways on the couch, wrapped in a white blanket, "you'll still be here when I wake up, right?"

828 took a seat across from her with only the table and the nearly empty plate of berry pastries between them.

"I wont leave your side," he whispered as she closed her eyes, "I promise."

When Entrapta awoke, 828 was still sitting across from her watching her, silent, steady. His eyes never left her. He was a good companion, a protector. But behind his careful plaster white smile, a hint of worry could be detected as she sat up, swaying from the effort.

"You are unwell?" He guessed rising to his feet to promptly fetch anything she may require. Perhaps soup? He recalled her saying soup always made her feel better. When had he heard that?
It didn't matter.

"I have an elevated body temperature and my muscles feel fatigued. Possible I've contacted a virus. It will be fascinating to study the effects of an alien virus on my Etherian body," she moved to stand up, "I should go to my lab and take a sample, if I can, to identify it. I-"

828 gasped as she sunk back down, hissing in pain. He rubbed his eyes, certain he was imagining it, but as she curled up on the sofa, he could not deny his own eye sight.

"Entrapta, you are-!" He struggled for the right word. Fading? Shifting? Disappearing?

She looked down at her hands, or rather, looked through her hands, then back to 828 in shock. It took only a moment for her

brilliant mind to work it out.

"D-Doomberries?" She stuttered, "But... Hordak, the pastries! D-don't..."

828 could only watch helplessly as she fell sideways, unconscious. His eyes flashed from his fading and ailing mistress to the pastries, confused, scared, distraught. He would be punished for this, he knew it. But still, without a second thought, he called for medical intervention. It was better to face the wrath of his brother than face the pain of losing her.

"Sir?"

The Emperor was watching a holographic display with intense, slitted eyes. His face was set in dark determination as he watched his forces rip through the Rebel encampment like tissue paper. He left no survivors, not the leaders, not even the lowest soldier. It was simply a massacre. No great speech given, no public execution. They all died in anonymity, forgotten the second their bodies fell.

"Sir?" Beck tried again and this time one of the Emperors eyes snapped to her.

"Beck, have this world wiped from the map. The civilians will be relocated, but they must understand what Rebellion means. Ensure it is known that the *Rebels* destroyed the planet and they have been saved by their Emperor."

"Sir! Yes, Sir!" She snapped to a stiff salute, but bit lightly at her lip. "Sir? I've received a report from the royal infirmary. Your Emperess has been admitted."

Now all four eyes were on her. Beck handed her father the data pad the instant he held his hand open.

"She is in serious condition, suspected poisoning. Her Companion has already been removed and is in custody. She is currently in the care of-"

He passed the data pad back before she could finish, silencing her with a look.

"See that my orders are carried out. I am finished here."

Beck bowed, shaken by the curious tone in his voice. He sounded tired. No. Beyond just tired. He sounded almost broken.
And he never left a planet eradication without seeing it through himself.

"Father!" She called out as he was nearly to the door, "shall I inform the family of the situation?"

He paused and Beck watched as he seemed to be seriously considering something.

"No," he answered, "not until we can confirm this was an assassination attempt. Until I have more information, we will say nothing."

Beck bowed once more, her pretty round face contorted with worry, but she pulled it together the instant he was out of the throne room. He had given his commands and she was his voice now. She would see that his orders were carried out to the very letter, or else she would see to it that someone paid. Dearly.

828 hung suspended by nearly a dozen wires affixed to his ports. He was conscious, but he truly wished he wasn't. The pain of having your mind ripped open and prodded and sorted through was excruciating. Every stray idea, every act, feeling, desire was analyzed, turned this way and that, then neatly tucked away for later use.

As his eyes flashed from green, yellow, red, the Emperor watched, frowning. His hands rested at the small of his back as he sorted through the moments before his wife collapsed, then further and further.

"B-Brother! Please-!" The clone begged between sobs of pain. The Emperor ignored him, pushing deeper, being much less careful than he otherwise might.
At least, until he spoke again.
"S-she knows what this poison is," he cried, struggling to keep his mind from absolutely melting long enough to get the information out, "S-She said d-doomberries. The... pastries."

He stopped his frantic searching, and withdrew the cable at the base of his skull. As he reach to touch his poor defective clones cheek, his face could not help but betray his concern, his anger, hurt.

"If you are lying, I will know and I will kill you," he warned, softly, sadly.

And despite the pain, the torture, the intrusion into his most intimate thoughts, Hordak leaned into his touch, eyes closing so the Emperor could no longer see their color. It didn't matter any longer who was in his cluttered head now. What ever it was, was being honest. That was all he needed to know.

He pulled his hands away from the face of his clone, withdrawing every cord from every port, leaving Hordak, 828, *whoever* he was, to drop to the floor like a rag doll.

"Doomberries..." The Emperor whispered, teeth clenched, "How... *interesting*."

He swept his cables back into place as he thundered through the vast halls of his ship. Behind him, his two attendants scurried to keep in step.

As he reached a branch in the hall, he wordlessly pointed and an attendant went that way, having received his orders telepathically.

The first place they would investigate were the kitchens. Someone had poisoned his bride by switching out the berries he had picked for her personally, and that was almost more insulting than the attack itself.
Almost.

A moment later, he dismissed his second attendant. He would next investigate the Emperesses chambers, collect the left over pastries as evidence and have the berries analyzed. Punishment was on his mind, of course, but the most important thing at the moment was finding out exactly what this poison was and how to counteract it. Having a new Bride perish under his care, *especially* his new Emperess was... unacceptable.

"Never again," he hissed as he reached the medical bay, "*Never. Again*."

Entrapta awoke several times, mostly due to the pain forcing her consious, but there was also something else. A voice at her side, a hand holding hers.
And a silhouette outlined by the bright white light of the medical facility.

She opened her mouth to say his name, to smile, assure him that she wouldn't suffer long. His long ears were low, parallel to the ground, his head bowed.

How long had she been here? How long had Hordak stayed by her side, running his fingers over her palm, the scar, murmuring? How long had it been since she had last faded? Not long ago, really, and it had lasted almost a full minute. She heard Hordak tell her as much, admitting that he thought she was gone for good that time.

She moved her hand as much as she could, squeezing his with all her strength. Another fade was coming. She could feel it. There

was so much data to collect, so much to learn. She had always wanted to study the effects of doomberries, but she had not been aware that dying from them would cause her such pain.

And she *was* dying, wasn't she? That's what this felt like. But she had read somewhere a theory that doomberries caused you to blip into another demension. It was a fascinating theory, but one that she was feeling about 86% sure was incorrect.

No. This was death. She *wanted* death. She had *wanted* death from the instant she'd been captured. Now she would finally have it.

But here at the end, as her body began to flicker and fade one final time, she wished for just one more moment with him. Just an instant to tell him how she felt.

He knows, she assured herself, *Somewhere in there, he knows.*

She closed her eyes and smiled as he pressed a kiss to the scar on her palm. Happy. If she had to die like this, in pain and writhing, she was glad she had Hordak beside her.

She felt his hands shake, his shoulders quake as he trembled with grief.

The last thing she knew before it all went dark.

He let out a single quiet sob as a tear hit her fading hand.

Chapter End Notes

> BOY! What a busy holiday season! Sorry it took me so long. I honestly didn't expect the Holidays the kick my ass like that!
>
> But anyway, thanks all of you that stuck around and kept checking in and I hope you enjoyed this new chapter!

Orange

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Surviving was sometimes worse than not. As Entrapta lay staring at the l endless universe above her bed, she was filled with the greatest regret.

Death had been close, nearly in her grasp. There was no reason for her to live through that ordeal, no reason for the assassin to not succeed. And yet, here she lay, alive.

And hating every instant.

At her side, one of the Emperors blank slate attendants watched over her. Constantly. His large unblinking green eyes studied her breathing, her movements, even her bathroom use. She had grown to resent the poor creature, despite knowing full well that it was hardly his fault.

Sighing, she sat up.

"I'm better. I want to go to my lab."

The clone stared at her for a long time before finally offering a stiff shake of his head.

"You remain until Brother says otherwise," he answered slowly, voice deep and unmoving like a boulder.

Entrapta had quite enough of stubborn, unmovable men. She pulled her blankets off and slipped out of bed. The clone did something she did not expect.

He moved aside, ears dropping, frowning. She paused, really studying his expression.

Was that fear?

"Will he punish you if I leave?" She asked slowly and the clone only hesitated a moment before nodding. Entrapta slid back under the covers again and the clone looked visibly relieved.

"What is your-" she cut herself off. She almost said name. "What is your batch number?"

"704-0015," he answered automatically, looked towards the door then cleared his throat. "They say you gave your Companion a name. H...Hordak?"

Entrapta felt like she'd been slapped. Her large magenta eyes went wider until the clone stepped back, afraid he had caused offense.

"My apologies. I-"

"No. It's okay," she murmured, looking up at the black nothingness above, "but I didn't give him that name. He named himself."

The clone sunk into the chair beside her bed, hands firmly placed on his knees as he leaned in like a child waiting to hear a story.

"Did you... want a name?" She asked slowly and was immediately met with an eager nod. For the first time in so long, Entrapta laughed, genuinely, happily. "Alright. I can suggest a few for you, but you have to pick it yourself."

The Emperor paced in front of his gathered spouses. For a full five minutes he had simply walked back and forth in front of them, face set, impassive, pausing only now and then to sigh and shake his head.

When he finally spoke, it was in a tone the gathered family had not heard in some time. He was angry.

"An assassination attempt was made on my Emperess," he explained, "a failed assassination attempt, luckily. Yet, I am not satisfied simply in knowing the plot failed. My experience tells me that this assassin will make another attempt."

In front of him, several of the spouses exchanged alarmed looks. The Emperor sighed.

"I want each of you to be on high alert. You will be assigned a food taster and will have an additional guards to watch your quarters. If any of you see anything suspicious, I encourage you to alert me as soon as possible."

"My love?" Zallah asked, "and what precautions are you taking for yourself?"

The Emperor turned two of his eyes to her, smiling kindly.

"Oh, I would not be concerned for me, my dearest one," he chuckled, "I am... *invincible*."

A small polite laugh trickled through the family before quickly dying down.

"All except for Tallulah and Zallah, you are dismissed," he concluded, holding his hands out to both women, "My darlings? Walk with me."

"So, it's decided then. Your name is now Theo," she nodded to the clone, who was excitedly tapping their feet on the cold white tile, "it's nice to meet ya, Theo!"

The clone seemed to almost chirp in excitement. Only once had she heard a similar noise from Hordak. After she made him the

new armor. He'd been testing it out, excited by his new strength. She hadn't been sure she'd heard it back then at the time, but now she was certain.

"It is a pleasure to serve you, my Emperess!" The clone exclaimed, standing up to bow. Entrapta stopped them with a laugh, using a tendril of hair to gently push him back down into the chair.

"Call me Entrapta," she insisted, then hesitated, thinking it over, "err... call me Entrapta in *private*, at least. I dont want you to get in trouble."

The clone was grinning, green like her husband, but there was something in their expression that made her feel...

Better. More at home. Hordak used to smile at her and it always seemed genuine. Maybe not this innocent or playful, but it was a level of sincerity she hadn't seen since her time with Hordak. He never lied. She missed the truth.

"Hey. Theo?" She asked and the clone perked up, delighted to have someone use their chosen name. "Do you know where Hordak is?"

"Oh, he's in holding cell 3!"

The tiny voice seemed to come out of nowhere and both Entrapta and Theo looked around, confused. It wasn't until she looked down that she finally noticed a pair of furry little feet sticking out from under her bed along with a twitching tail.

"Oh, hi Terr," Entrapta yawned as she reached under to wrap a tendril of violet hair around a furry ankle to pull the tiny girl into view. She smiled her wide, toothy grin as Entrapta pulled her up until she was hanging eye level upside down.

"Hi! Rawnie said you were dying. I told her she was mean and ugly though. I'm glad you didnt die!"

Entrapta exchanged looks with Theo before setting the child back down carefully.

"I was just a little sick, Terr. I'm better now."

Terr scrambled to her feet, still grinning excitedly.

"I heard you named this clone. Mine has a name too! They should be friends! Come to my room some time soon! We can play a game! Kusi is really good at games! He wins so much!" The girl was practically bouncing on her furry little paws now, "but you're so smart! Maybe you can finally break his winning streak!"

"Kusi? Oh! Is that the name of your attendant?" Entrapta smiled at Theo, watching them as he processed this information. Other clones had names too. She could see delight in his eyes, pure and glittering like the stars around them.

"Uh huh! He's my best friend! Entrapta, if you're better, do you wanna come play now? We can go and-"

"Tomorrow maybe, Terr. I would love to play a game with you, but your Father wants me to stay in bed for now," she sighed, "but, um, you said Hordak was in a holding cell?"

"Uh huh," the small girl plopped down on the edge of the bed, kicking her feet, "Father had him sent there when you got sick."

Something about that just didn't seem right. It didn't add up. Why? He should have been here. He was sitting next to her not long ago, holding her hand, crying, saving her life.

Right?

"Terr?" Entrapta bit her lip lightly, hesitant, "Can you do me a favor?"

The Emperor was rarely this quiet, rarely this reserved. If Tallulah was being honest, this concerned her. Greatly. For years, he had been a source of endless fun. Exciting, entertaining. His smile was constant, his laughter contagious.

Now he looked sad. Worn. Old, even.

"Darling, what happened?" Tallulah asked the instant the trio was alone in his bed chamber, "Entrapta lived. She's recovering and you still look like someone died!"

Zallah flashed her a look and Tallulah raised a pink eyebrow. Her pretty crystalline eyes narrowed as she jerked her head in their husbands direction.

"Tally," the other woman whispered, "*please*. He needs comfort."

She was right. Tallulah watched her dearest friend and lover sink into a tall white chair, burying his face in his large hands.

"The poisoner," he announced quietly, voice quivering with a force that could shatter the hardest of hearts. "I suspect it was one of my spouses."

The two women exchanged a look and Tallulah noted a hint of unease from her friend and fellow wife. After all, theirs was a tight knit group. For one of them to attempt an assassination was unthinkable. Sure, rivalries came up. But murder?

"Who?" They both asked at once, but Talullah was nervous about the answer.

Slowly, his hands lowered. For a while, his eyes remained closed, but when he opened them, all four focused squarely on the beautiful, golden Zallah.

Tallulah followed his line of sight, shocked. There was no way. It couldn't be possible. Zallah was the Emperors favorite. An old friend. A true wife, loyal. She would never-

Bewildered, Tallulah looked back to her husband who was now rising to his feet, face unreadable until he began to walk forward. He was halfway to his golden bride before he sighed.

"No more games," his tone was commanding, yet affectionate. Gentle. "She can be trusted."

That was when Zallah changed. Right before Tallulah's eyes, her beautiful golden body shifted, color dulling, turning dark, then green like oxidized brass. Her lovely diamond-like eyes blinked sideways, turning yellow. She morphed, a dark shadowy black overtaking her form, narrowing and twisting. The shadow bowed and when they rose, a green skinned, long tailed humanoid stood where Zallah had been moments ago.

"Tallulah, allow me to introduce Double Trouble. My new spy."

The green humanoid bowed to her, grinning.

"Apologies for tricking you," they purred, placing their hand in the Emperors waiting palm, "but please tell me, what did you think of my performance? Was I properly in character? I am open for constructive criticism."

"It was a brilliant performance," The Emperor chuckled, lifting their hand to his lips, "truly, you are a master of the theatrical arts."

Tallulah blinked, looking from her husband to the imposter, then back to her husband, hands on her full hips.

"Are you going to explain, darling?" She snapped, "or are you going to keep flirting?"

The Emperor allowed the shape shifters elegant hand to fall through his as he turned his attention entirely to Talullah.

"My love, I thank you for your patience," he purred, dipping his perfect pale head respectfully, "allow me to explain everthing. What i said previously is true, there is a great chance that the

culprit could be among our little family.
Double Trouble here has been keeping an eye on things there for me since we left Etheria."

"I've been undercover," they explained, "and my! It's been such a delightful character study! So many different personalities! So many intriguing-"

"*Enough*," Tallulah snapped, "just tell me who tried to kill Entrapta so I can suffocate them with my tits."

The Emperor sighed deeply and shook his head. Double Trouble frowned and watched the man sink into a chair, looking distressed once more.

"It's a little complicated," Emperor Prime murmured, "We suspect the poisoner is a spouse, however... there is more to it. A wider plot, or so we believe."

He rested his head on a hand. Two eyes closed while the other two studied something in the shadow of the bed chamber.

"Zallah, the real Zallah, has had her suspicions for weeks," Double Trouble explained, "she noticed things. Irregularities. We've been working closely anticipating an attack on the Emperor, but... "

"*But*," a silky smooth voice interjected, "we did not foresee an attack on his newest bride."

Tallulah followed their gaze to a darkened corner of the chambers where Zallah herself in all her radiant beauty stepped out from behind a curtain.

"*Zallah*-!"

"I am sorry, Tallulah," she sighed, "I didn't want to trick you, but we had to be sure-"

"Sure that you could trust me with this... dirty little secret?" She gestured vaguely at Double trouble who pushed out their bottom

lip, pouting.

"Rude," they sniffed, "I am an artist!"

"You're good, I'll admit," Tallulah snorted, "but your Zallah impression needs some work. You made her nails too long and she has never once called me Tally in front of Anillis. Do a little more research."

Double trouble blinked, scoffed and crossed their arms, but Tallulah caught them examining Zallah's hands just a little closer, pursing their lips.

"Enough," Prime snapped, "let us get back to the heart of the matter. The *traitor*."

Tallulah sunk into a plush sofa with an impatient sigh.

"Who poisoned Entrapta?" She asked once again. "Nobody seems to want to tell me."

"Tallulah... We don't know for sure, but we suspect it was one of the twins," Zallah murmured, sinking down to sit next to her and placing a gentle glittering hand on one of her tentacles.

"Only one?" Tallulah raised a perfect brow, "But those two do *everything* together. Don't they?"

All eyes went to the Emperor. If he was embarassed by the implication, he did not say it. He generally kept his bedroom activities to himself, not wishing to embarass any of his lovers.

"There are... moments where they prefer to be apart," the Emperor admitted, looking away with four eyes in different directions, "but until we are certain, I am unwilling to make a move just yet. The only ones we've cleared of all suspicion are in this room. In fact, it is *why* you are here. We must weed out the traitor at once. If there is one thing I have learned, it is that a failed assassin will strike again, especially if they feel desperate."

"Are you suggesting we set a trap?" Tallulah asked, already feeling tired.

But clearly not half as tired as her husband. Still hiding his face in his hand he nodded stiffly.

"They could have *killed* me," he murmured, voice deep and dark like a thunderstorm rolling in. "I nearly ate one as well. I was about to kiss her. How close I was to death..."

The gathered party was silent, avoiding looking at their Emperor at all cost now. To kill an Emperess would be a tragedy and be a strike against his sparkling reputation. But to kill the Emperor himself... just *thinking* about his death was considered treason.

"I mourn," he continued, quietly, sadly, "because I know when we find the poisoner, they will have to die. And I..."

Tallulah stood and crossed to her husband. Zallah appeared to have the same idea. As Tallulah gently massaged his stiff shoulders with her expert tentacles, Zallah leaned in to where he sat and pressed a chaste kiss to his forehead, murmuring calming words to him.

"We know, my love. You care about us all. You are our loving husband," she soothed, "but you are an Emperor still. And this you must do. Just as you've done before. You can not excuse treason."

All four green eyes snapped to focus on Zallah's crystalline gaze. Tallulah pressed herself against his back and the Emperor groaned despite himself. These women had learned long ago how to best bring their husband cheer. One of his eyes fell to the shape shifter, standing to the side, looking uncomfortable.

"Double Trouble," the Emperor purred, flashing a playful smile, "you say you can become anyone, yes?"

The shapeshifter blinked, then tilted their head with an impish smile.

"I can be and do anything you command, your Majesty."
The Emperor reached out a hand and Double Trouble reached back.

"*Anything*?"

The instant Double Troubles hand touched his, they transformed once more. In a moment, the Emperor found himself face to face with an exact copy of himself. Not a clone, but a mirror image. Exact. Perfect.

Ideal. The mirrored Emperor leaned in close, lips inches away from his own as he whispered in a borrowed voice.

"*Anything*."

828 sat alone as he had for... how long had it been? Days? It had to be days. He was sure of it. His mistress had fallen Ill. His Emperess. His...

His friend. Entrapta.

He buried his face in his shaking hands once more. Was she well? Was she alive?

Doomberries. She had said doomberries. That had been what she'd been poisoned with. He had managed to pass the information along before he fell unconscious. Was it enough? Was it quick enough to save her?

Clones were not meant to do this, yet here he was, weeping into his open palms. It was the unknown that hurt the most. If she was gone, he wanted to know. This felt like losing her all over again.

Again? When did I lose her before?

It made little sense, but he recalled weeping like this before over her. She had been gone then too. Dead, or so he had been sure.

He wiped his eyes, sniffling, feeling ashamed. He was imagining things again. He was seeing memories that simply weren't his. They couldn't be.

But why do I keep calling myself Hordak? Why do I-

"Hi Hordak!"

828 jumped, quickly wiping his wet eyes on the corner of his white cape. Outside the energy field of his prison cell a small furry child smiled at him. One of Primes children. Terr. He remembered now. He rose to his feet, trying not to sniffle as he sunk into a stiff bow.

"Little Princess," he greeted politely, "with respect, I am 828-1075. How might I assist you?"

The little girl tilted her furry head, frowning.
"Entrapta said your name was Hordak, so that's what I'm calling you. She sent me here to check on you."

The clone went still as stone the instant her name was brought up. A familiar thundering in his chest, heat on his cheeks. He felt both electric and on fire. And both sensations were so very comfortable.

"Entrapta..." he whispered, one hand going as it all too frequently did, to the base of his throat, just over his heart. "She is... alive?"

Terr blinked, then looked sideways to her personal attendant, a very bored looking clone covered in brightly colored patches with messily braided sections in his otherwise slick white hair.

"Entrapta was just a little sick. That's what she said. She said to tell you that she'll get you out soon! So don't worry!"

Her sunshine yellow eyes glowed with such a bright innocence. And it was so very reassuring. Despite every ounce of programming in his body, he was so very happy. So relieved. So thrilled.

Grinning, he sunk to his knees. He was so weak. During his time in here, his daily treatments had stopped. He was fading like a dream, likely to die if he did not receive treatment for his condition soon. But he could not possibly feel more joy, even if his crooked, defective body was suddenly restored.

She was alive. She was well. It was all he wanted.

"Thank you," he whispered, "Tell her... Tell her I lo... Tell her I look forward to serving her again."

The child didn't respond. Not really. She seemed perplexed, confused. If 828 was being honest, he was confused too. He had almost said something just then. Something impossible, before his better judgement stopped him.

The little girl reached out for her attendants hand, then walked away without another word. Out of sight.

828 leaned against the wall of his cell, breathing deep. He let the back of his head touch the smooth wall behind him as he felt his nerves leave his body like a fleeing spectre. When he finally opened his eyes again, he caught his reflection in the mirror smooth surface on the prison wall.

His reflection blinked back with eyes wide, full of surprise,

and *orange*.

Chapter End Notes

> Back from vacation! Man! It's been a busy few weeks! Thanks for your patience!

Black

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"You seem to have recovered well."

Four eyes focused on his wife who was now sitting up in bed, warming her hands on a cup of exotic tea. Anillis had prepared it himself with herbs he had personally picked from his private garden. Knowing what he knew now, his faith in his kitchen staff was shaken.

"Yes. I feel basically back to normal," she replied, staring into the spicy brown liquid. "Um... when can I have my regular Companion back, my love?"

The Emperor shrugged, seemingly indifferent.

"I had forgotten about him. You will be reunited at once.

Two of his eyes drifted past his bride, focusing on something in the distance. The truth was, he hadn't forgotten. He had simply... hoped she would forget. Foolish of him, but it was true. He would never admit to it, but he often felt a pang of jealousy when he recalled the clones memories with her.

"Dear One," he said after a silence that felt too long, "you must be ready to get out bed, yes?"

Entrapta nodded enthusiastically.

"Why don't we take a walk to the lab? It has been some time since you've been able to do your work, hasn't it?"

He offered his hand and the instant she reached for it she knew. How could she not? That familiar chill, the way it clutched so posessively.

"Doomberries," she said, as she slid out of bed, "I ate doomberries."

The Emperor helped her to her feet, seemingly unaware of her point.

"Yes," he replied, "you did. And your poisoner is going to-"

"I ate doomberries," she continued, ignoring his apparent annoyance at being interrupted. "There's only one cure. Did you know?"

The alien took a deep breath, closing two eyes to calm his rising annoyance.

"No, dearest, I don't, " he answered, as if addressing a child, "you simply recovered on your own after every known remedy failed."

Of course he didn't know. She stopped dead in her tracks, pulling him to a stop as well. He did not fight it and simply turned his distressingly calm gaze to something directly over her shoulder. If Entrapta didn't know any better, she would say he seemed upset.

"You were attempting to cure a magical ailment without magic," she explained, "there is only one known cure."

Now he met her eyes. She had his entire attention, a rarity as of late, she was discovering. He opened his mouth to speak, but quickly closed it, seeming to think better of it.

It was... funny. He towered over her, a giant, yet here she had him backed into a corner and speechless. Slowly, she raised his hand to rest lightly against her cheek, leaning against it.

"Someone must shed tears for them. Just before the end I saw..." she hesitated and that seemed to be enough to break the spell.

The Emperor pulled his hand away, busily adjusting his hair wires and gazing at a mirror that a clone was now holding out for him.

"Enough," he said stiffly, "however it happened, let us just be glad that it did."

"It was you," she pressed, "Wasn't it? You cared. You cried for me."

"My dear, I do not know what you're going on about," his voice had a dangerous edge to it, but in the reflection, there was a hint of a blush on his perfect cheekbones, "but if you want to go anywhere today, I recommend you drop this ridiculous line of questioning and get dressed."

On cue, Theo approached with garments neatly pressed and laying across his open arms. As she had since gotten used to being dressed, she did not fight it when he tugged her sleepwear from her body, leaving her naked to her husbands leering gaze.

"You appear to have lost weight," he noted, "for the best, I suppose. You were a little too thick in the middle. This is much closer to the ideal Etherian form."

Entrapta had never considered her weight, or what made her 'ideal'. It had not once come up in her life, nobody had ever looked at the little pouch of fat on her stomach and commented on it. Nobody had ever told her to cut down on what she ate to achieve an ideal figure.

What *was* ideal anyway? Surely all bodies were different. Surely one could not just push an entire species into one small box and label that "ideal". But here, that was what perfect was. A tiny container and she would be expected to chop of bits of herself to fit in it.

She allowed Theo to dress her, only speaking to mumble a 'thank you' when he finished. As she stood in front of the Emperor waiting for his approval, she noted the way his eyes seemed to widen, the way his cheeks went rosey again.

She looked down at the white jumpsuit, a far more practical garment for lab work, one she was grateful for. All she had to

wear had been gowns thus far.

"Do you... approve?" She asked cautiously. That seemed to snap him out of what ever daze he was in long enough to banish his blush.

"It is acceptable," he relented, "more practical for lab work.

Acceptable. Entrapta knew what that word meant. Passable. Imperfect, but good enough. But the look on his face said otherwise. His eyes, they seemed to linger just a little too long on her stomach, the slightly rounded outline of her hips, where they dipped and curved, the peaks and valleys of her breasts.

He thought she looked spectacular, like a supernova, like a new star being birthed.

He wanted her. And she knew it.

And she wanted to scream.

Entrapta was at home in this lab. White, and sterile as it was, this was comfortable, familiar. It lacked the charm and character of Hordaks lab, but it reminded her of those times. When she was happiest. When he was always there.

When she felt safe.

"Dear One, come along," came the call from her husband, pulling her out of her sweet stroll down days ling past, "come. You may get to work soon, but I have much to show you."

And like a good wife, she followed, barely holding back a sigh as he pulled her from her work.

"I never did show you how I did it," he continued, offering an arm to her as he led her to a green glass elevator on the other side of the lab. "Stay," he instructed his guard and the blank faced clone obeyed, standing beside the elevator.

"Did what?" She asked reluctantly, unsure that she honestly wanted to know.

He simply smiled and curled his claws around her chin once they were both inside the elevator, forcing her to meet his eyes.

"The clones," he answered as they began to descend, "I perfected the process myself, after all. You thought your 'Hordak' was a good lab partner? My dear, you haven't a single clue what I have in store for you."

She found herself brought to silence as she watched layer after layer of steel zoom upwards. Just how deep did this elevator go? Down to the heart of the Velvet Glove? Lower?

"Knowledge is power," each word was punctuated by a deep pause and the effect was ground shattering. A shiver ran up her spine at the sheer weight of his words. The meaning.

"Knowledge is *knowledge*," she argued, "power shouldn't have anything to do with it."

He burst out laughing, just as the elevator came to a stop. His claw released her and he stepped out into a long narrow hallway. Entrapta followed, watching as he ran a finger under his lower eye, flicking away a tear of mirth.

"You are a funny one," he chuckled, "it is true enough, I suppose. When this all started, I was young and idealistic too. Naive. I would bring order to the chaos, right the wrongs and make life perfect, easy for the lowest of the low."

Entrapta nearly stumbled and the Emperor stopped.

"What?" She was caught by one of his strong, powerful arms. "If that's true, then why all... this?" She gestured around vaguely. "The conquests, the battles, the death."

The Emperor stepped away from her, looking her up and down thoughtful, looking to all the Universe like a man seriously considering her question.

"How would one bring peace to a Universe without uniting a universe first?" He asked, raising a brow ridge at his young wife. "Did you know that the vast majority of my Empire joined me willingly? Poor planetary systems in need of my protection, my resources. And I gave them that. All I asked in return was that they follow a few simple rules. A small piece to pay, do you not agree?"

He began walking again, approaching a large set of doors, flanked on each side by a set of blank clones.

"...and the ones who don't surrender? The ones who don't volunteer?"

She had a feeling she knew the answer. He stopped in front of the door, reaching out to a clone. At once, the instant the Emperor was in front of him, the clone seemed to at last come to life. He leaned in, eyes flickering shut as the Emperor cupped his face.

"What is it you Etherians say? You had a charming saying that I heard while I was there. What was it?" His hand moved to the clones jaw, thumb gently running along his bottom lip. "Ah. Yes. I remember."

His hand traveled down, clawd lingering near his throat, dangerous, threatening. And Entrapta froze, watching adoration and lust replaced with fear in the clones frantic green eyes

"In order to... bake a cake, one must first break a few eggs," he whispered and Entrapta looked away, certain to hear a crack of a neck, or splatter of blood.

Instead, all she heard was the door whoosh open and the clone sigh with relief as the Emperor released him and strode past.

"Come, wife. There is much to see."

She met the clones eyes for a moment, noting the way he touched his throat, the light pinpricks of blood on his face from her husbands claws. She was starting to wonder, did he love himself, or really truly deeply detest himself?

She moved past, stepping into a large chamber lined with glass vitrines, much like the ones in Hordaks lab. The liquid inside was a familiar shade of green, but unlike the creatures from Hordaks sanctum, sickly, small, young, many of these clones were nearly grown, strong, durable. Deadly. In fact, they were big. Much bigger than the standard clone.

Entrapta stopped, leaning in to look closer, one hand pressed lightly against the glass. Inside, the nearly grown clone twitched, fingers stretching, claws extending and retracting. A reflex. Much like a child in the womb.

"Impressive, aren't they?" He asked smiling at one clone in particular, "come. Look at this one. He will be ready soon."

She did as she was told, moving to stand next to him, waiting. The clone floated, curled in on himself, another flawless copy of the man watching through the glass.

"I've been considering moving on to another body," he confessed, "this one would have been the body I took, but look there-" he pointed to the glass as the clone squirmed and turned in his tank, "do you see it?"

Entrapta squinted, really looking. It didn't help that she had no idea what she was looking for.

"No, I don't," she answered, "is it-?"

"Ah, your Etherian eyes are less sensitive to such things, of course," he said with pity, "on his back, a flaw. Just below the surface. A degradation."

He sighed, pressing a hand to the glass, peering at the poor creature inside.

"He will die. Slowly. Painfully," he murmured, "unfixable at this stage. Had I found it sooner... well, had I found it sooner, I could have begun again with a fresh clone."

He leaned in closer and Entrapta watched as he pressed a gentle kiss to the glass. In his beautiful green eyes, she found regret, pity.

"But at this point, it would be a waste to dispose of him. I will have him conditioned, treated and sent off to battle. Then-"

"That's cruel," she snapped, angrily turning her head to glare up at the large man beside her, "it isn't his fault and you're sending him off to die!"

"He will die eventually," he countered, one eye sliding to look at her from the side, "disease will take him and he will suffer. He will grow weaker day by day until his lungs stop working on their own, his muscles rot and he will rely on machines just to keep him upright. Tell me, is it kind to subject him to that? To keep him alive while every second is pain? Or would it be kinder to give him a quick death? An honorable death?"

Three more eyes snapped to the tiny Emperess. She was his entire focus, his world now, his stars and sky.

"We... aren't talking about this clone anymore, are we?" She asked slowly, and he shook his head, confirming her fears.

"Where is Hordak?"

"He is here," the Emperor confessed, moving ahead through the row of tanks, "just as he was from the start. His tale began right

there, in fact. In this tank."

Entrapta followed his long finger to the opposite end of the row to where a dark tank sat alone, separate from the others. So dark it was that she almost didn't see what was inside. Almost.

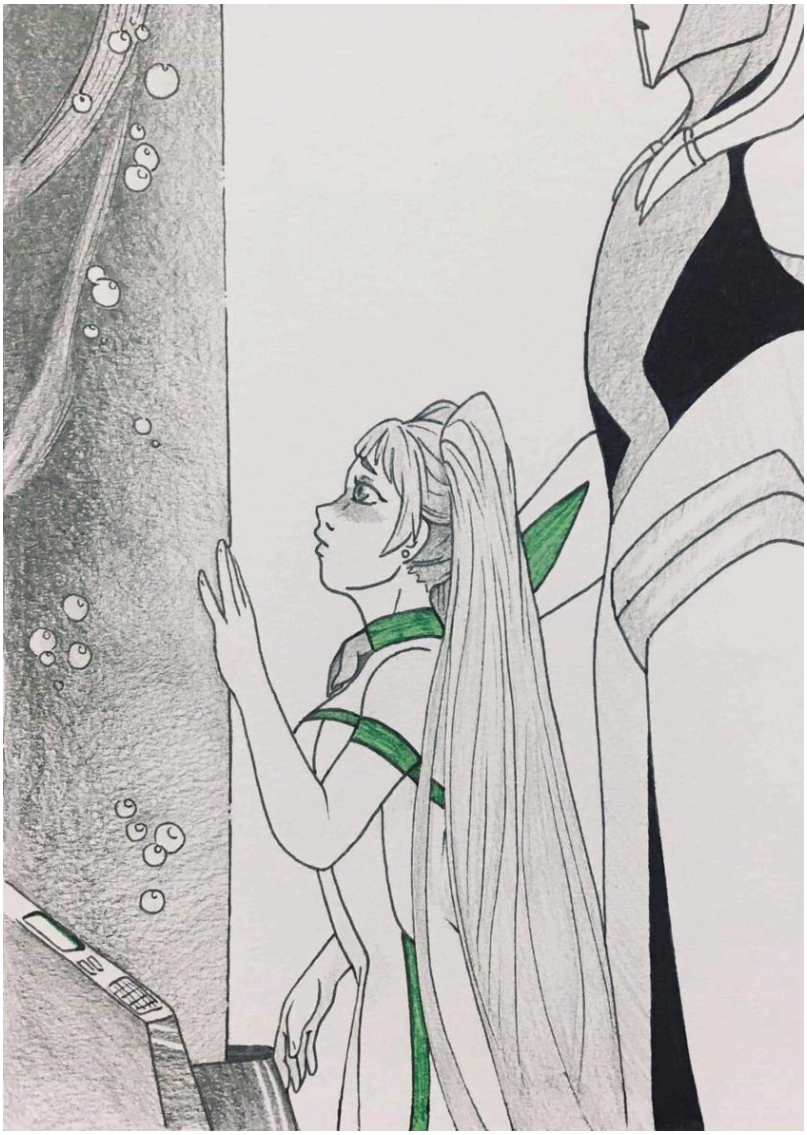
The heels of her shoes clicked loudly on the black tiled floor as she hurried to his side. Her hand pressed against the glass, heart thundering as she peered into the darkness. Something was hanging in there, floating, covered my tendrils of wire attached to every port. She knew it was him, knew by the way he made her head swim and her hands tremble. She knew by the way her heart sang and her lips muttered his name on instinct.

He was there.

"I grow all my generals here, did I tell you?" The Emperor continued speaking as if she were not on the edge of tears an inch of glass separating her from the love of her life. "The average clone can be grown without issue. But there is something about the process of growing my generals that can lead to defects. A shame, truly. I give them small differences, intuition, the ability to think separately from me. Oh yes, they all may operate individually, of course. They aren't... entirely machine after all. But my drones simply do not have the same capacity for individual thought that they do. I suppose you could say that these ones are... family."

Entrapta felt his hand touch the back of her neck, cold like a winter chill, freezing straight to her bones.

"My... little Brothers," he murmured, pressing himself against her from behind.



She knew what he wanted. How could she not? He was clear as day about what he expected of her from the instant they met. She was his wife, wedded and bedded. Owned.

"Please, not here-"

He pressed her to the glass, rough, careless for her whimper.

"Here, there, *anywhere* I want, my love," he hissed into her ear as one claw went to the front of her jumpsuit, "look at him. Look close."

She did as she was told. She always did. The alternative was... unhelpful and possibly dangerous. It wouldn't ever make a

difference if she fought. She understood that now. Her options were always few.

She peered deep into the tank, thankful, at least, that he was unconscious and would not have to watch. It was a small comfort.

"What I said before was true. He is dying.

Has been for years."

His fingers grasped the pull at the front of her jumpsuit, pulling the zipper down, one agonizing inch at a time.

"It really is a wonder he survived as long as he did."

"Can he be saved?" She asked, her desperation apparent. Quickly, she attempted to remedy her careless words, but she knew the damage had been done. She'd shown him her hand. "I-I mean, for the pursuit of scientific knowledge, of course. If we save him we can learn to save the others. Less... wasteful that way."

She winced at her own stupidity. She was no good at this. Manipulation, lying, twisting the truth. Hordak never required lying. He preferred the truth, even if it was not what he wanted to hear. And he would never lie to her. Anybody. He was always so truthful with everyone.

Except *himself*.

"Hm... perhaps you are onto something, my Dear One," he purred, peeling her white jumpsuit down her shoulders. Pressing his lips to her exposed flesh, he purred, trailing his tongue, lips, teeth down to chase the fabric as it slid down her waist, hips, thighs.

"If you're a good girl, if you do your duty and do it with a smile, perhaps we can talk about your... little friend."

It was hope. The only hope she had. So she arched her back, placed her hands on the glass and stared into the darkness as he entered her. This was her duty. This was her purpose. And it was how she would save him.

When she caught her reflection in the abyss, she expected to see a woman hurt, broken. Instead, the eyes staring back at her in the glass were full of hope.

Despite everything. She was still herself and it was a good feeling.

For the next week, Entrapta had a routine again. She awoke, was dressed by Theo, then she took breakfast in her room before heading to the lab. She worked there until it was time to prepare for lunch. She would go back to her chambers to change, have a light lunch (with a clone on hand to prove it had been test tasted before hand, of course) then it was time to pay a visit to the throne room to play pretend with her husband.

Most of the time, she would simply stand at his side as he worked, checking progress of his invasion from his tall seat. Sometimes he would speak to his generals and those were the hardest times. He was so friendly with his generals, treating them, much as he said, like brothers. They joked, laughed and shared anger when a strategy failed.

But the brotherly relationship was a strange one. One sided. Inappropriate. Once he invited a clone to join them in the bed chamber after. It had been an awkward experience and her husband had seemed far more interested in his clone than his wife. Still, she did her duty without complaint, with a smile. And if she were being entirely honest, it could have been worse.

Her husband was a good lover, even if he was difficult to navigate around. He was complex in a way that Entrapta was certain she,

with her limited "people skills", would never understand. Even Tallulah confessed to her, during an afternoon visit over tea, that she didn't entirely understand him.

"His mood can change like the weather," she said, looking into the murky brown tea, "it's impossible to predict."

Entrapta opened her mouth to respond when the doors slid open. Immediately, Entrapta was on her feet, scurrying to catch the frail figure as he hobbled forward.

For the first time since the doomberry incident, 828, Hordak, was back with his mistress.

It was pure bliss. Hordak had not hoped to see her again. Not really. While a small optimistic part of him had imagined seeing her once more, a larger more sensible side was certain he would die before his release.

He had not minded, not really. She was alive. That was enough for him and he was nearly himself again. Nearly aware. Nearly whole. His heart was, at least. But his mind was fractured still, a mess. Healing, but not fast enough.

"En...trap-"

The instant she touched him, he collapsed against her, nearly knocking her off her feet. She steadied herself, tangling her hair around him, embracing his fragile body, wrapping him like a gift.

"Hordak," she whispered, pulling him close, encasing him in her arms. In her protective embrace, he let it all go. He had no fear of death now. He had seen his worse fear already, endured it, survived, overcame. And in the end, she had survived.

In this perfect, beautiful Hell, surviving was more than enough.

He buried his face in her fragrant hair, breathing in safety and love.

Tallulah cleared her throat, reminding the Emperess and her barely conscious Companion of her presence. But more so, the presence of the tall imperial figure behind them. As quick as light, they separated, and Hordak was left to collapse to his knees in front of the looming monarch.

"My Love, I can exp-"

"Tallulah, walk with me."

His order was hard, cold, a winter storm, beautiful and terrible. Threatening without needing to say a word, without needing to even look their way.

Tallulah slipped by, only meeting her eyes a moment before both she and the Emperor were gone.

"My love, please don't punish them," she began the instant the door slid shut behind her, locking the Emperess inside, "he fell and she was simply helping. Do not be angry."

The Emperor did not speak, simply looked down at her as they walked. Why was he being so quiet? Why didn't he seem ready to tear someones face off? The Anillis she knew-

He blinked, eyes turning yellow, eyelids closing from the sides.

"Double Trouble!" She hissed, swatting their arm, "I should have known better. The Emperor would have never been out without an attendant at least. Sloppy."

"Still," they replied in the Emeprors beautiful voice, "it fooled you well enough."

Tallulah frowned, but conceited. They were right.

"What were you doing there?" She asked, keeping her voice low as her Companion followed a small distance behind them, "did my Husband send you?"

"Of course he did," they murmured, "he's a busy man, after all. Can't be expected to escort his wife's companion back himself. Besides..."

They leaned over as they walked to whisper.

"We still have a little job to do."

Tallulah nodded, face set, determined. She was ready to move on, focus on her work ahead when Double Trouble decided to open their mouth again.

"So, *that's* Entrapta. I was wondering what she looked like." They sighed, "you know, to make Hordak fall for her and then land an Emperor? I expected a Goddess. This Entrapta girl isn't as pretty as I thought she'd be."

"Don't talk like that in front of His Majesty if you want to keep your tongue," Tallulah warned, watching in disgust as their long tongue flicked out to moisten their lower eyeball. "I recommend you also forget what you just saw in that room."

"Oh?" They snickered, "will the Emeperor kill me if he finds out his new wifey is still carrying feelings for someone else?"

Tallulah grabbed his arm, stopping the "Emperor" in their tracks. She rose up on the ends of her tentacles until she was perfectly eye level with them, leaning in close so her whisper could not be misheard.

"No. But if you hurt that girl in any capacity," she hissed, "you will find yourself touring the Universe... *outside* the ship. Was that clear enough?"

Two eyes slid to the side nervously, then back to the dangerous, tentacled beauty.

"Of course," they answered slowly, "consider this little secret a freeby. But the next one you ask me to keep? Well, that one I'll have to charge you for."

Tallulah lowered herself once more, a new smile on her pretty, plump lips.

"Deal." She wrapped an arm around theirs. "This feels like the start of a beautiful new friendship."

Entrapta was waiting, holding Hordak on the floor. She was certain she would be taken, that her husband would come back, that he had seen it all and would hurt her for it.

But after five minutes, then ten, then an hour passed, she was beginning to wonder if he had simply not noticed or not cared.

"Entrapta," Hordak eventually whispered, reaching up to touch her cheek. She looked down and he quickly pulled it away.

"I am sorry," he murmured, "I know you said not to touch you. Forgive m-"

A tendril of hair closed around his mouth and he did not fight it. Couldn't. Even opening his eyes was a chore. After being asleep in a tank for a week, suddenly being awake felt like an impossible task.

"He says you're dying," she murmured, avoiding his gaze as she had the entire time they'd been back together, "it's true, isn't it?"

Hordak swallowed hard and nodded.

"I receive treatment," he admitted, "but... Yes. My body is failing."

Now she was looking at him, really looking. And he was looking back. And in her gaze, they shared a heart, one that beat together, broke together.

"Your eyes," she mumbled, "they're orange."

"Yes," he breathed, "I am... defective."

"Yes," she whispered, placing the palm of her hand over the empty slot in his exoskeleton, "you are. You're broken. Like me."

It was like a magnet, the way she drew him in. Despite the pain, his weakness, he found himself pulled to her, eyes locked, souls entangled like a mess of cords.

"*But*..." she breathed, face less than an inch from his now, "maybe our broken pieces can still fit together."

Chapter End Notes

The beautiful artwork was done by Ararouge on Instagram!! Go check them out, give them a follow. They do great work.

Indigo

Chapter Summary

Gruesome death ahead. But also... some nice stuff?

A bit of a mixed bag.

Kissing was a universal sign of affection. This was a little known fact about the Universe and one the small scientist likely would have found fascinating.

On every planet that Hordak had been to, he had witnessed this. Between family, friends, lovers, people of all races if they had lips, would press them to another as a show of love.

Etheria had been no different. It was one of the first habits he had noticed about the alien planet. When it's dominant species wished to bind itself to a mate, they sealed their bond with a kiss. When they said goodbye, many did so with a kiss. When they greeted old friends, a kiss was often exchanged.

A kiss meant so many things. And yet, Hordak had never experienced one.

Until now.

Poets had tried to describe a first kiss using flowery metaphors. Song writers had attempted to express the feeling with melody. Not even the scientifically minded Hordak could describe the sensation in any sensible way, save for wet. Wet and salty.

Her kiss was a tidal wave, her lips an ocean. And he was drowning, breath gone, gasping. Dying.

And what a beautiful way to die.

But then she pulled away and once more, he could breathe. When he finally opened his eyes, it felt like life had begun again. He was

viewing the Universe anew. She was life itself, light, water, air.

On her eyelashes clung the ocean water he had nearly drowned in, a watery red sea, overflowing, spilling down beautiful golden shores.

Without thinking, he caught her tears with a claw, wiping her face clear before her makeup could run too much.

"Hordak."
His name was a whisper in the air, barely audible over the sound of his racing heart.

"Entrapta."
Her name was a prayer, spoken by a worshiper, kneeling at her altar.

Hordak did not know or care what secrets the Universe held, but as she leaned in, closing the distance once more, he was certain that he had just solved every mystery life had to offer him.

The next hour was a blur. The soft mattress beneath them was certainly made of stardust. They explored each other like an ancient temple. The soft body above him was a Goddess. Their voices were a choir.

The rythm of love was a slow dance. In life, love takes many forms. Sometimes, love can burn bright and brief. Sometimes, it's glow is dim but long lasting.

But sometimes, love is a bright burst and an eternal fire. Sometimes love is a sun.

Entrapta placed her palm on his chest, eyes half closed in bliss as she rolled her hips into his. His hands traced up her bare thighs, wondering at the olive scars at her hips, the dips at her waist, the veins spread out like indigo tree roots. Imperfect, flawed, cracked, broken.

And no matter what, she would not be fixed. But she did not need to be. He was broken too. And their missing pieces fit together so perfectly. He filled in her cracks and she filled his. Not perfect. *Never* perfect. But stronger than ever. They would not break again so easily.

She leaned against him, lips searching desperately for purchase. His fingers tangled in her wild hair. Red. Violet. Not one word needed to be spoken.
As their dance reached its inevitable end, as they reached for the limits of the Universe, falling together like stars, their vows were exchanged in their eyes, forever shared on their lips.

From this moment until my last, I belong to you alone.

Finding a spouse who hated the Emperor was not hard. After all, not every spouse had been a willing one. Several had been political marriages, daughters and sons of powerful families on their own conquered worlds. Never anyone less than royalty, of course. If there was one thing Tallulah could say about her husband, it was that he had standards.

She had eliminated several suspects already. Scolopendra had been with Karena at the time, off at some exotic spa. Lenna had been with Sveletta in the Emeprors chambers. Tallulah did not need to ask why. It didn't matter. The alibi checked out.

Shereiz, Ryah and Fleick had been around at the time and they had been suspects for a while, but Shereiz was always a terrible liar and when questioned left Tallulah more than convinced of her innocence. Ryah and Fleick were two that Tallulah knew hated their husband, but murderers? Unlikely. Fleick couldn't even eat meat without crying, let alone harm anyone. And Ryah, frankly, seemed to lack the brain power.

That left her top suspects. Rawnie, who had the motive and the means. The twins, who had been caught in several lies during Tallulah questioning. And then there was Dhar, sassy, drama queen Dhar.

She was at a standstill now. The berries had to of been acquired on Etheria. Entrapta said they were a native plant. But who had the time and the contacts? Who could have the know how? Who would *want* to?

Tallulah didn't have answers.

But it *seemed* apparent that Horde Prime had not been the target. No. All the suspects had one major thing in common.

They all adored their husband, didn't they?

She was trying another strategy now. And it involved, unfortunately, using Entrapta as bait. Or, well, someone who *looked* like Entrapta.

Tallulah was currently watching Double Trouble in a live video feed do their absolute best Entrapta impression. Impressive enough, considering they had met her for about one minute. Well, it wasn't as if she had much interaction with the other wives either.

Across from "Entrapta" sat Rawnie, staring down at dark liquid in her cup.

"Thank you," she murmured, "for... everything. Especially agreeing to meet with me."

The false Entrapta tilted her head with a smile.
"Of course! Let's be friends!"

Rawnie looked up, shock in her pretty nebulous eyes. Then, she smiled, seeming to relax.

"I would like that," she said, then took a long sip of her drink.

"What did you ask me here for?" Double Trouble asked, mimicking Entraptas voice, "not just to have tea, right?"

Tallulah leaned in to the monitor, holding her breath. On all sides, clones waited outside the room, waiting to rush in if Rawnie attacked. Tallulah trusted Rawnie as far as she could throw her. Which was not that far. As willowy as Rawnie was, she was also ridiculously tall and heavy.

"No," Rawnie sighed, setting her drink down, "I... wanted to tell you something. Something I... Listen, I feel I owe you one. F-for the incident at the ball? I wasn't very nice to you. I was jealous and it was awful of me."

Double Trouble tilted Entraptas head to the side, smiling and Tallulah winced. She'd forgotten to fill them in on that incident. Still, she was able to breathe again when they shrugged and said, "Don't worry about it! Now, what did you want to tell me?"

Love can start as a small thing. So quiet you can pretend not to hear it. But it gets loud. Deafening. And you can't ignore it anymore.

Horde Prime could hear nothing else. The moment Tallulah announced she had concluded the investigation, he locked himself away, alone and would not even allow Zallah or Tallulah inside.

He sat alone at his vanity, sipping on his seventh glass as he studied his nearly perfect face. He reached up, tracing a talon down his cheek, following the salty trail of his wet eyeliner.

There were few who knew this, but Anillis was a *lover,* not a fighter. Not really. It had been ages since he had seen battle personally. And he was glad for it. He did not miss the chaos of battle, the scent of blood, the bodies piled to the sky like a monument. Certainly, there was the rush of battle, the surge of adrenaline. But that was nothing compared to the rush love gave him.

Yes, love. The act of loving, being in love, having that love returned. It was the greatest feeling in the Universe. It was why he did this. Why he conquered. To take the Universe under his loving care.

That was why this hurt so bad.

Was it truly not enough? Had he neglected them? His lovers? Did he do this? Was it his fault?

What more could he give?

He took another sip, draining his glass. Zallah and Talullah were gathering his lovers, all save Entrapta. She was locked in her chambers, away from what he was about to do. He was still trying to win her heart, after all. There was no need for her to see such unpleasantness.

He poured himself another glass, emptying the crystal decanter. He would have to go soon, serve his justice, do what an Emperor must do to traitors.

He would rather pluck out one of his own eyeballs than do this, but what choice was there? His law was made and there was no going back on it. If the Emepror could not follow his own rules, why should anyone else?

Taking a shaky breath, he set his glass down and began to reapply his makeup. When it was all over, he knew it would need fixing again, but for now, appearances had to be maintained.

The inky void above felt friendly. Each star winked like an acquaintance. Every passing world seemed to wave from a thousand lightyears away.

And Entrapta smiled back.

In her arms, nestled against her bare chest, lay Hordak. As she ran her fingers through his hair, a soft purr rumbled from somewhere deep in his throat. Entrapta knew that sound from her nights with her husband. It was the sound of satisfaction.

"Hordak?" She whispered, hand pausing at the base of his skull. The purring stopped and he sleepily opened one eye to look at her. Still orange. Close enough.

"I am awake," he murmured, "I am simply... memorizing the moment."

Entrapta didn't ask him to clarify. She knew exactly what he meant. To count each perfect second, lock the feeling in a cage inside your heart, commit every breath, sigh, every heartbeat to memory as if it might somehow prevent time itself from escaping.

"We can't do this again," she murmured, "if Prime reads your thoughts-"

"I know," he whispered, light, airy, almost carefree, "don't worry. I won't let him."

Entrapta closed her eyes, sighing. This was a mess. In the heat of it all, she forgot the risk. She forgot her insanely controlling husband, that Hordak wasn't supposed to even be Hordak, that Prime had already threatened to kill him next time they were caught being too close.

"We're lucky he's been distracted," Entrapta continued, "but soon he'll have to notice these-" she placed a polished finger between his eyes, "can you change them back?"

"No. Not voluntarily," he sighed, shifting his head to rest over her heart, "the color is a sort of... error signal. Green means I am a perfectly ordinary obedient clone, yellow indicates stress. Orange is... well."

"What does red mean?" She asked, smiling playfully. She knew the answer already.

Suddenly, her lover shifted once more, hovering, teeth dangerously close to her neck.

"Danger," he whispered, canines ghosting over the still raw and healing bite Prime had left the night before.
The temptation to leave another new one was great, but he had enough self control, fractured as he was, to resist that urge. Instead, he pressed his lips to her pulse point, licked her salty skin.

And below him, she opened her legs to him once more.

For the last time, he reminded himself sadly, then immediately pushed that knowledge out of his mind as she pressed her hips against his. He hissed in pleasure as her velvety soft, wet slit enclosed around his member. Her arms draped around his neck, fingers digging lightly into the imperfect flesh there.

Through half lidded eyes, he watched her beneath him as they made love. And that was exactly what it was. They both knew, how could they not? As hips met, as they became one flesh, one heart, once again, he said what had been at the broken edges of his mind for months, from the instant he saw he again. He hadn't been able to say it before, but now he had his voice again. And words only for her.

"I love you."

Her fingers traced shapes into his delicate flesh, her eyes widened, cheeks flushed. But she wouldn't look away. As he neared his limit, he began to pull out but she wrapped her legs around him and held him close. She placed a kiss against his ear, pushing him over the edge as she whispered,
"I love you too, Hordak."

When he came, he was still buried deep inside her, panting, collapsed against her as he laced arms and hair around his trembling body. Together, they lay for as long as time would allow.

Tomorrow, she would have to make her excuses, tomorrow she would have to make a plan.

But for now, this moment was the *only* moment, and she would keep it forever.

Tension hung in the air like a fog, dense and unsettling. A dozen men and women stood in a semicircle in front of the throne. Some exchanged nervous looks, others appeared simply confused. And then there was Tallulah, stern and almost sad.

For a moment, the Emperor sat, throne facing away from his gathered lovers, his family. The only thing visible were his hands on the armrests, beautiful, sharp, dangerous. Each claw had been sharpened for the occasion, Tallulah noted, and tipped with molten silver for strength.

Tap. Tap. Tap. Each claw lifted and fell, creating a beautiful cascading rhythm like raindrops. Calm to all the Universe, but inside, a storm was raging.

"Zallah, Tallulah," his silken smooth voice called, "present your findings."

It was Zallah who stepped forward first, bowing her beautiful mass of ruby hair to the back of his throne.

"My Love," she greeted as all wives did, "after an in depth investigation, we have determined that there indeed is a plot against you. Furthermore, we are confident that we have uncovered the identity of this traitor."

The tapping ceased and the silence was deafening. Another moment stretched on, punctuated by a sigh.

"Continue."

The Emperors perfect claw waved impatiently, but he still sat facing away, staring out at the endless Universe.

"As we all know," Tallulah said, pulling up her holographic notes from a strange crystal in her hand, "last week, Emperess Entrapta was poisoned and nearly lost her life. The poison came from a curious berry native to the planet Etheria. The berry was placed in the kitchens, replacing the ingredients our loving Emperor had picked personally from his garden-"

"But how did they get into the kitchen, you ask?" From the edge of the throne room, a clone stepped forward, or rather, sashayed forward. The Emperor did not move still. Not a sign of irritation. In fact, from what little Tallulah could see, he seemed to almost expect it.

"I didn't ask," she murmured, "but go ahead, you absolute Diva. I know you can't stand not having the spotlight for twenty whole seconds."

The clone guard did a stage bow and when he straightened up, they shifted, body warping until Double Trouble stood before them all. The spouses whispered nervously about the shape shifter.

"The crime was designed to appear a horrible accident. Perhaps we would think a strange Etherian illness took her? What the murderer did not see coming was our *little Emperess* being smarter than them. They didn't see her recognizing and naming her poison before-"

"Watch your tongue," the soft, yet icy voice of the Emperor warned, "show respect for my Wife."

The shapeshifter blinked, appearing somewhat sheepish.

"Apologies. I was getting into character. I've been reading the Mer Mysteries series. Wanted to emulate the main character," they explained.

The Emperor sighed impatiently and waved a hand for them to continue. With him still facing away, it was impossible to tell if he found this irritating or amusing.

"A-anyway! There were several obvious suspects, of course and most we were able to rule out without a shadow of a doubt. During our interview process, we sadly found we had come to a dead end. We thought the case had run cold, but then something happened. Someone finally came forward."

Tallulah saw Rawnie's eyes widen as realization struck her. She had not spoken to Entrapta after all.

"That was-!"

"Yup. All me," Double Trouble laughed. Turning their hair into a mass of violet then back again, "sorry to trick ya, love. But hey? Thanks for solving this puzzle for us. We couldn't have done it without you."

Rawnie looked down, avoiding the stares from her Family.

"Ladies and gentlemen, allow me to introduce our poisoner- Rawnie dear? Take a bow!"

The fair haired wife looked around, stunned.

"M-me?" She squeaked, "but I didn't know they were poisoned! Aleiz said they would cause minor skin rash. I wanted to ruin her complexion, not *kill* her!"

A silence fell. Rawnie gasped at her own words, hands going to her mouth as the answer to it all slipped from her lips. All eyes turned to the set of twins, holding hands.

"Bingo," Double Trouble smirked, "Rawnie was an unknowing pawn in this. Our mastermind used Rawnies jealousy to their advantage and fully intended to frame her for the crime."

At last, the throne turned. The Emperor stared down his slitted nose at the nervous twins.

"Aleiz," the Emperor finally said, raising his claws to examine their sharp silver tips, "you have been accused of attempted murder and treason. Do you deny these accusations?"

"No, your Majesty," Aleiz said quietly.

"No?" He asked, voice dangerously gentle
She nodded in reply. "Aleiz," the gentle boom made them tremble, "did you act alone?"

The silence was deafening. Slowly the twin on the left nodded, let go of her sisters hand and stepped forward.

"I-I did, Majesty," she stuttered at first, but soon her voice gained strength, "my sister was uninvolved. Punish me, but leave her out-
"

"No! Your Majesty!" Her twin shouted, "it wasn't just her! Punish me too! Don't make me live without her!"

Zallah sighed, stepped forward again and pulled up a hologram. She seemed to look for something, and when she found it, she highlighted it then flicked her fingers. An instant later, the words appeared on a crystal in the Emperors arm bracers. He frowned.

"Ajna had left to visit her home world after the wedding and only just arrive back-"

"I gave no clearance for a visit to Paharna," the Emperor cut in, glaring across the throne room.

"-*Without* your permission," Zallah continued, "Aleiz covered for her, using the time away from her to carry out her plot. Ajna is guilty of lying to you, my love, but she was not involved in the crimes of her sister."

Two clones approached from the edge of the room. One restrained the guilty twin, although she offered no struggle, no sign of apology, no regret, at least not until her sister began to weep.

"Please!" Ajna begged reaching to grab for her sister again, "have mercy! She's all I have! Please-!"

The other Clone was having a significantly more difficult time with the innocent sister. She fought, clawed, bit and tore her gown trying to reach her lifelong companion.

Aleiz winced, glancing behind at her sister. *Now* she looked regretful.

The Emperor was still as stone, face unreadable as his numerous eyes scanned the room, roving this way and that. For some time, the silence lingered, punctured only a few times by the shaky sobs of Ajna as she struggled.

"Aleiz, you are stripped of your rank and our marriage will be removed from public record. As we have no children to consoder, your property will be seized and distributed to your next of kin."

The clone who was holding her by the wrists with one large claw, reached up to snatch the green jewel hanging around her neck. She did not protest.

"So I am to die then?" She asked slowly, prompting another wild sob from the still struggling sister. The Emperor nodded stiffly without hesitation.

"Have you anything more to say?" He asked, "I will give you a moment."

Aleiz took a deep breath, seemingly stilling her spirit for what she would say next.

"I owe you an apology," she began and was immediately cut off by the Emperors snort.

"Indeed you do-"

"Not *you*! I owe *you* nothing!" she snapped, then turned her attention back to her weeping sibling. "Ajna, I am sorry. I wanted to avenge you. I wanted to avenge our people. I failed. I-!"

"Enough!" Emperor Prime snarled, rising to his feet. "Silence!"

"*Never*! I will never be silent again!" Aleiz shouted back, "For the rest of my life, I will speak the truth! I will fight you! To my last breath!"

Each step down the short dias sounded like the roll of thunder, deep and threatening. Ajna broke free as his foot touched the last step. She ran to her sister, pulling her into a brief hug, sobbing into her loose, wild aubergine hair.

"Remember who you are, Ajna," Aleiz whispered in her ear, "you are the Queen of Paharna. Hold yourself tall and proud."

It was an instant before they were torn apart, fingers touching until the last moment.

"You stole us," Aleiz shouted, "you took us from our home. You killed our family and stole Ajna from her throne!"

"I said *enough*!" He snarled, stepping ever closer.

"The rebellion is alive! We will never stop until you're dead! You think those berries were meant for just *her*?"

In an instant, he had the rebellious alien Princess by the throat, lifting her off the ground. In her shining pink eyes, her final seconds were powerful, without an ounce of fear. Despite the claws closing her airways, crushing bone and cutting through flesh and muscle, she managed to mouth the words *For the Rebellion.*

A sickening crunch, a splash of indigo blood, and the sharp clear sound of grief powerful enough to move the stars themselves. Her head flopped back, held to her shoulders by battered flesh.

The Emperor dropped the body without ceremony, without a single sign of disgust or even grief. All four eyes studied his now deceased wife while a claw went up to flick a speckle of her blood from under his cheek. His long green tongue carefully found a droplet that had landed at the corner of his mouth.

"I want you all to take a lesson from this," he slowly, deliberately addressed his collected lovers, "rebellion will be dealt with. Harshly, without mercy. And not even my love for you, great as it may be, will save you from this fate."

One eye snapped to Ajna who was now on the ground, clawing at the clone, trying to reach her sisters broken body.

"Ajna," he snapped, stepping over the corpse and the ever growing puddle of blood, "clean this up. That will be your punishment for deceiving me."

The grieving woman looked up with fear, anger and something Prime had seen enough to recognize immediately. *Hate*. Pure, unfiltered hate.

"You are all dismissed."

The collection of beautiful men and women moved from the throne room without a sound. Not a one could meet the eye of the other, but as they each shuffled to their private quarters, each one buried the memory somewhere dark and deep.

For Rawnie, she buried Aleiz in a bottle of strong green liquor. Dhar laid her to rest at the bottom of his jewelry cabinet.

But Tallulah didn't know how she would cope. It was her fault after all, wasn't it? She had thought she was doing what was best. For her husband, her Family. For Entrapta. But what she had said in there, her strength, her voice, so strong until the last instant...

"Ooh, well, I must say, I didn't see that coming," Double Trouble murmured, sneaking up to her side as she headed back to her

suite. "Such a temper. Tsk tsk! But, guess now he has an opening for a new spouse huh? Maybe I should-"

"A girl just died," Tallulah snarled, "Her body isn't even cold yet. Have some respect!"

"Oh come on. You didn't even like her," they sniffed, "surely the Emperor is looking for someone to fill in, right?"

"Leave him alone," she hissed, "and let the man mourn. He lost his wife today."

As she approached her chambers, Double Trouble sped up, trying to get close enough to sneak into her personal quarters with her.

"Did we not just watch him kill her?"

"Yes," Tallulah murmured, "and even so, he loved her. And he lost her. Stay away from him."

The door opened, she swayed her hips as she entered, knocking the shapeshifter onto their back with a comical 'Oof!'

"Oh, and by the way," she snarled in the door way, "my husband only weds royalty. Sorry to break your heart, *love*."

The door shut behind her, leaving Double Trouble outside alone. The instant she was alone, she slithered to the pool of crystal clear water in the middle of the room. Home at last.

She would bury her *here*, she decided, deep below the darkest depths of the pool. Under the water, in the shadows. She would drop Aleiz in the blackest corner, the deepest indigo. It was where she let go of all of them. Where they all floated to the bottom.

Out of sight, out of mind.

Far below the clean white laboratory, a man wept. In the shadows of a empty dark glass vitrine, he knelt, one hand on the glass, another covering his face.

He mourned, but not for the dead
Not for what once was.

He mourned for what *never* was. He mourned because love had not only deafened him, but it had blinded him also. He had given his heart, and she had not cherished it.

Could he have been kinder? Possibly, but had he not given her enough? Had he not bought her affection? Her jewels, were they not bright enough? Rare enough?

He slammed his fist on the glass, sending a long crack up the length of the tube. Gasping, shoulders heaving with each rattling sob, he looked up at the dark, terrible reflection. Hair a mess, makeup smeared by indigo blood and tears, the crack further distorting his view of himself.

Shakily, he reached up to touch the side of his face without the additional eyes.

Perhaps he wasn't enough. That must have been it. He simply wasn't good enough yet. Not beautiful enough. Not yet. Unlovable.

But he could change. He could fix it.

Behind him, the imperfect clone floated, ready for life, duty.

Yes, he was imperfect, defective. But... he had two good eyes.

"You will be useful after all," he murmured shakily, rising to his feet, unsteady as a drunk man. "I will be... *perfect*."

And then he would finally be happy.

With shaking hands, Entrapta plugged a cord into the port at the base of Hordaks head. They both sat, half dressed on the bed, blushing at the memory of an hour ago. How their lives had changed. And how this idea of hers had to work. There was no choice.

"Okay," she whispered in a voice that she hoped seemed soothing, "I'm in. Are you... sure you want me to do this?"

Hordak bit his lip, took a deep breath before answering, "y-yes. You must."

Entrapta took a deep breath, then got to work. In silence, she typed in the tiny tablet she had been able to smuggle into her room from the lab. With the Emperor having some important meeting in the throne room, sneaking in had been easy. And even this ship had a ventaliation system she could fit through.

But now she wasn't sure her plan would even work. What had she done? She knew what they'd done had been a mistake. And yet, how could she resist it? Hordak was there, for the first real moment in what felt like ages.

And he loved her.

"Hordak, I'm going to do it now. Last chance to change your mind..."

Hordak gently shook his head, glancing over his shoulder to smile at her.

"It's alright. I trust you, Entrapta."

"...If I mess up, you'll forget everything," she reminded him, doubtfully.

"Well then," he chuckled, reaching back to lay a hand over hers, fingers going to her palm to rub the scar, "I guess you'll just have to remind me again."

Entrapta hesitated, then leaned in to place a careful kiss to his cheek before she finally hit the button.

In the dark of the room, a rainbow of color flashed. Orange, yellow, red, then at last, green.

Cyan

Chapter Summary

> OOF! It's been a minute. Sorry fam. I've been busy and then the flu killed me.
> But I'm alive again!
> Anyway, have something a little more positive than the last chapter. <3

Life could change in an instant. One step left instead of right might be enough to cause a ripple that could form a wave.

Entrapta was facing down a typhoon.

As she approached the throne, her husband fixed her with six eyes glimmering like a sea of stars. His smile was one of pure delight. She had done well, she knew. He was pleased. She would be rewarded.

But still she felt his noose tightening on her throat.

"*Well*?" He asked, two eyes scanning his gathered court, "is it true?"

Entrapta swallowed and nodded.

"Y-yes," she answered, just loud enough to be heard, "I am pregnant."

An excited whisper was allowed to tremble through the colorful collective. Entrapta captured her husbands gaze now entirely, his smile only for her.
She hated him more than ever, yet she smiled back, rewarding him a thin pull of her lips.

"A proud day," he boomed, rising to his feet, "in two months time, we shall make a formal announcement. Every creature living in my

Empire will know and celebrate. And you, my Dear One," he began to step down the dias and Entrapta shivered, "you will be worshipped. The vessel that will secure the future of my Empire."

As he approached, raised a hand to cup her face, she allowed herself a blink of an instant to meet Hordaks eyes, standing straight and emotionless next to her.

"I live to serve, My Lord," she replied, meeting her husbands adoring gaze. It had been some time since she'd been bought and even now she couldn't quite figure out the proper way to interact. In the privacy of her chambers, she would practice, panic and cry. In public, she kept herself as quiet as she could. It was easier. But today, she had leverage. And it was worth using. She had to try.

"M-my Love?" She hesitated when he turned six eyes to her. Now or never.
"I have done what you wished of me. May I- err, w-well, can you do me a favor?"

His hand stiffened against her cheek, but his ears twitched as if to show he was listening. She swallowed hard, hesitated for only a moment before she pressed on.

"My companion," she explained, "he is dying and..."

Two eyes snapped to study the defective clone companion standing a short distance from his Mistress. For a long time his green eyes studied him, face as unreadable as his clone.

"You wish for a new companion? A healthier one? Consider your wish granted-"

"*No*!" Her hand clutched her husbands over her cheek. He regarded her suspiciously, brow raised. She took a deep calming breath. "No. I do not want a new one. I am used to this one. I want to attempt to cure him."

Her husband tilted his head, mouth twitching into a little smile.

"A waste of resources, do you not think, my Dear One? Tell me, what would the purpose be?"

"Your generals," she whispered at once, and it was all she had to say. She saw it in his eyes, the wheels turning.

Still cupping her cheek, he leaned in to place a soft kiss to the top of her head.

"I will consider your request. Care for your health, Dear One," he whispered, "I will visit later."

A threat or a promise? Meant to put her on guard or excite her? She never could tell.

As he let her go and headed back up the dias, she dipped into a shallow bow along with her attending Companion. As she made her way out, the Emperor called for drinks to be served and a celebration to be had.

Entrapta did not want to stay, even if she *had* been invited to. It was better to just go back to her chambers and lay down. She knew illness often accompanied pregnancy, or rather, she'd been told this by her physician at the time of diagnosis.

She certainly *felt* it. The instant the doors closed behind her in her chambers, she fell to her knees and emptied her stomach into a large, expensive painted vase. As she gagged and coughed, a hand gently patted her back. When she looked up, two green eyes watched her with worry.

"I'm alright," she promised, shaking, "don't worry. They say this is normal."

"You're crying," he observed, kneeling to where she now sat on the cold white tile, "Entrapta-"

"It's alright," she insisted again, quieter this time, "it's just for a few months."

The clone narrowed his eyes as tears fell freely down her cheeks, then without warning, placed both hands on her shoulders and pulled her to his chest.

"It's *not* alright. *You* are not alright," he hissed, letting her weep into his chest, "Entrapta... we must leave. I do not know how long I can pretend to be a mindless drone. And..."

She pulled away, tears streaming down her cheeks as she shook her head.

"We can't. Not until we can fix you. Either cure you or get you a new body. The one I was going to use..."

She trailed off and a ghastly silence fell between them. It had been a few weeks since she had discovered her husband, hunched over the bloodied body of that defective clone, two new eyes swollen nearly shut as they healed in his skull. He had been laughing, half mad and before she could sneak away unseen, he had caught her.

She still had bruises from his violent "love", over the eyeless corpse of his clone.

"Entrapta, we are running out of time," Hordak whispered, "we should forget the new body. What ever time I have left, I will use it to make sure you're safe back on Etheria. I've heard rumors. The Rebellion is alive and well. They will help."

"I won't let you die," she snapped, rising to her feet, "that is not an option."

"Entrapta! Think of yourself. Think of..." his voice quivered, weakened and when Entrapta looked back he was shaking, looking at his hands. "Think of the child. Is this the life you want for them?"

Entrapta's hand fell to her navel and her eyes welled up again.

"I don't want them at *all*," she admitted, "I don't *want* to have his baby!"

"We don't know it's his, Entrapta," he whispered, rising to his feet, "you must have tracked your cycle. When we... I-I am only saying there's a chance."

They stood two feet apart, eyes locked. Of course she knew. How could she not? But it was the first time either of them had admitted the possibility. When her pregnancy became known to her, his eyes had sparked. She had thought perhaps it was simply a glitch, but now she knew. It was *hope*. He wanted this.

"If you *are* the father," she whispered, "then..."

"Then all the more reason to escape," he finished, closing the distance and placing a hand over hers where it rested on the soft flesh of her stomach, "Entrapta, I may not remember everything, but I remember enough to know one thing for absolute certainty."
He leaned in close, resting his forehead against hers.
"I love you and I would face down the entire Empire if it meant I could spend what time I have left at your side."

Their fingers intertwined. Their hearts grew together like the branches of two trees, reaching for the other. Moments like this were too few. Seconds slipped away before either of them could reach for it.

"Hordak. Please, give me a little more time," she whispered, lips ghosting over his, "you have to help me with... *this*, after all. I can't do it alone."

Hordak chuckled and knelt in front of her like a storybook Prince. Wordlessly, he pressed a kiss to her stomach, then smiled up at his lover. It was such a long shot, all of it.

But it was hope, and that was enough.

It took some time for life to settle for the spouses of Prime after the "unfortunate display", as some had come to call it. But as all things, time healed hearts and minds. Things did eventually fall back into their comfortable places and most seemed willing to forget Aleiz, or act as though her death was simply a "tragic accident".

It was more convenient. Comfortable. Zallah couldn't bring herself to blame her little family for their coping mechanisms. She had her own as well.

As she lay back in bed, her new Companion fussed over a vial and syringe at her side.

"Highness," he murmured, "are you certain-"

"You will do it or I will tell my husband what you told me," she snapped, offering her golden forearm, "Giving yourself a name? What ever will he think?"

The clone winced, hesitant. His heart fought with his brain. Fear was his battleground. In the end, self preservation won out. He nodded and obediently prepared the needle.

"As my Lady commands," he murmured, and Zallah felt a pang of pity for him. It was not his fault. He was programmed to look after her health and wellness. And this? Well, this was *far* from healthy.

"What did you say your name was again?" She asked just as the needle pierced skin.

The drug hit her blood stream and she felt the bed sink under her, felt herself fall. Above her, a bright light shone in the distance as comfort and downy bedding enveloped her entire being.

From far above, a small voice answered.

"*I am Theo*."

Tallulah was more observant than most. She'd noticed the shift weeks ago. Spouses breaking from their groups, spending more time alone, away, doing what they could to sooth themselves.

And that wasn't all. The clones. They were acting funny. Giving themselves names, personalities. The other day her Companion woke her with bright green lipstick applied with great care to their thin mouth. As much as it had surprised her, Tallulah had found the break from the monotony exciting and had immediately sat the clone down to paint their entire face, complete with jewels at the corner of each green eye.

When she was finished painting them up, she passed them a mirror and watched in delight as the clone grinned at the sparkling reflection.

"Is this me?" They asked quietly, experimentally touching lightly at their cheek, "it can't be. So... pretty."

"That's you, Dearie!" She giggled, moving on to address the stiff, boring white hair, "But you're not *pretty*. You're *beautiful*."

Beautiful. The word seemed to strike their heart like a blade. Talullah had seen her husband weep, but what she saw now came at such a surprise that she actually let go of their hair and took a step back from her makeup table.

Their eyes shimmered like a green ponds in a rain storm, welling up with water, leaking over the side.
Clones were not meant to cry. They were simply not meant to have the emotional complexity. But here she was now, watching one weep like a child, smearing dark makeup down their sharp cheeks. Sniffling.

"Oh-!" She rushed forward again, a white handkerchief at the ready. She knelt in front of the clone, dabbing lightly at their face, trying to save the makeup look before it was washed away. "Hush, hush," she soothed, "did I say something wrong?"

They shook their head, but the tears did not stop. Tallulah gave up on saving the look now and instead opened her arms. The clone took the invitation and fell forward, body wracked with sobs.

"Do you have a name too?" Tallulah asked, gently rubbing their back and she felt them shake their head, no.

There were defining moments in every life. Instances that could change the course of everything. As Tallulah held her Companion in her arms and allowed them to stain her garments with snot and makeup, she knew this was one of them.

"Would you *like* a name?" She asked quietly.

The sobbing ceased and they pulled away slightly to look at their mistress as if she were a God. Finally, their face broke into a messy grin and they nodded.

"Alright, Starlight," she chuckled, petting their hair as she might a child, "what should we call you? Any requests?"

She loosened her grip and they pulled away again, searching their face in the mirror again, tracing the tear streaks in wonder, their lips, the hair now loose and wavy in front of their face like bangs.

"Name..." they whispered to themselves, catching sight of Tallulah in the reflection. Beautiful. Dark skin that glowed with a thousand pinpricks of color. Like the stars.

"My name is...S-Stella."

Time is not kind. Time is ruthless, unbending, uncaring. Time can heal just as often as it can hurt.

And for Entrapta, time was not on her side. She worked fast, efficiently, with a half dozen clones to assist.

"Your Majesty, as requested," a clone placed a tool into her open palm and Entrapta reached with a strand of hair to pat his head.

"Thanks, Daisy," she said, and the clone blushed and smiled proudly.

It was something she had been doing lately. Theo had spread the word and more and more lately, Clones had begun approaching her, begging for names of their own. She had joked with Hordak, curled in his arms, that she felt like a mother already.

As sparks flew from her work bench, as her hair whirled around her, she felt a familiar prick at the back of her neck. Intuition, she supposed. Instinct. Entrapta was a scientist, but she knew better than to ignore her gut feeling.

Slowly, she straightened up, set her tools down and raised her goggles. When she looked over her shoulder, she felt a claw fall to her other side. A shiver ran up her spine and she was immediately met with a sharp green grin and six eyes, cold and spider-like.

"You are taking care of yourself, are you not?" He whispered right against her ear.

Her first instinct was the shrink away, push him from her personal space. That was always her first instinct. But with time, with careful reminders, she had grasped some control over these urges. Instead, she smiled and moved slightly as if simply trying to show her work.

"Of course," she answered, "but I do still have a job to do despite my... condition."

On her sterile white work desk, fragments of She Ra's sword were coming together like pieces of a puzzle. A little at a time. It was delicate work, after all, but once they left, she would not have the resources available, and she wanted to have most of it done before returning the Etheria.

"Well done," he complemented, "making wonderful progress."

He pulled away, but left his hand to rest against the back of her neck, almost threateningly. Entrapta tried not to pay it any mind, but she knew she was failing.

"I've decided what we will name our son," he announced, hand sliding down her body. Shoulder, chest, coming to rest over the slight bump of her stomach.

She had questions, of course. How was that able to be determined so early? What methods were used? But instead, she only managed one word.

"*Son*?" She asked quietly, dropping her tools and choosing to give him the attention he seemed to require.

"Oh yes, Dear One," he chuckled, moving to push her chair until she was facing him entirely, "your blood test results are back. Our child is male."

"Oh."

She was expected to be thrilled, but lying did not come easy. Truth was. She had no regard for the child's gender. Male, female? It didn't matter. It almost made it worse knowing because now she would have a name to associate with it. She closed her eyes and forced a thin smile.

"And what did you decide to name our... son?"

The Emperor placed a gentle kiss to her forehead and rose to his feet.

"He shall be called Prince Zed," he informed her, and it was clear it was not up for debate.

"Zed," she murmured, "of course. A nice name."

Chuckling, her royal husband clasped his hands behind his back and turned away from her, heading to the elevator.

"Come, Dear One," he ordered, raising one hand to beacon her, "join me. I have a surprise for you."

Wordlessly and without protest, she followed as she always did when he gave the order. It was safer to obey.

Down into the dark she went, down below the shining white and vivid green. Down into blackness, shadow. The Emperors personal laboratory was a place she went only when necessary, especially after the last time.

"Oh, you will *love* this," he purred, pausing only a moment at the entrance to pet the face of the same clone guardian as before. She could tell from the scars on his throat from the Emperors claws. For an instant, she met his frightened green eyes and she resisted the urge to touch his scars, call him beautiful, name him.

For the moment, she simply strode past, thankful that at least for the moment, he was alive still.

"What is the surprise?" She asked carefully, eyeing the operation table as they passed, wincing at the memory of the last time she had seen it. The color of the blood had been such a deep, dark purple. So dark. So much.

"Close your eyes, my love," he purred, reaching to grasp her small hand and she did as ordered. As he led her deeper, her heart thundered in her chest like a war drum. In a frenzy, she considered what he could have in store. Perhaps he found out about Hordak? Maybe he was leading her to his body? Maybe he was planning to kill her next, just like he did to Aleiz?

But as he led her deeper into the dark and narrow chamber, she could hear excitement rise in his voice as he explained his cloning process.

"-and as I explained previously, I had encountered problems with cloning my generals. I thought perhaps it was an error in the genetic code, you see. Perhaps having to do with the small amount of free will I allowed them.
But I realized something crucial. You actually reminded me of it. The defect always starts to present itself near the ports."

He stopped and guided her open hand to cold glass.

"Open your eyes," he whispered right against her ear. She hesitated, and he must have sensed it because he cupped her shoulder and said again, more forceful, "Open. *Now*."

The sight to meet her was that of another clone, or one in production. Still small, curled in on himself.

"I fixed it," he explained excitedly, sounding very much the way she might after making a scientific breakthrough, "the defect! I discovered the flaw and fixed it! Look! This one," he reached for her hand, guiding it along the cold glass, "he is-"

"*Perfect*," she whispered, "you did this... for me?"

His hand withdrew at once and he turned away. It was as if he were trying to summon a storm, but the clouds simply could not gather.

"It was simply a problem to be solved," he replied awkwardly, "however...you did inspire me to take another look with a clear head."

"So... does that mean, um, my companion-?"

"Hm?" He glanced at her over his shoulder, just his eyes, but the tendrils of his hair rope twitched. "You *still* want that? Why not just get a new one? You Etherians are so sentimental."

Entraptas eyes fell to her feet, her hand went to her stomach. Something in this gesture seemed to catch, like a fish caught in a net. His eyes widened and he quickly turned back to face her, offering a gentle, indulgent smile.

"Anything you request," he insisted, grabbing both her hands in his, "please smile. I will do anything."

She twitched as if she had been shocked by his touch. The gentleness, the desperate urgency in his voice. He was like a young, lovesick schoolboy, promising the stars to a girl on the playground.

For the first time on her life, she understood her power. She frowned deeper, pulling her hands away.

"I owe my Companion a lot," she sighed, "I don't *want* a new one. I'm used to this one."

"Dear One-" there was the slight squeak of desperation in his voice, "he is too ill. His body is beyond repair..."
Entrapta sighed deeply and the Emperor grasped for a new desperate attempt at appeasing his pregnant wife.
"B-but! Perhaps I could... transfer him. To a new body?"

There was reluctance in his tone and she saw him visibly wince when she smiled and excitedly looked to the perfect body in the glass. The one he had planned to use as a replacement for himself when the time came. His reluctance was clear, but when she smiled like that... He may be the Emperor of all, but she was the Goddess of his heart.
Oh, that was dangerous.

"Er... *this* one?" He offered, with a slight grin, "he can have this one."

"Oh!" Entrapta said excitedly, "it's perfect! Thanks!"

She wrapped her arms around his middle and, despite it all, despite being her husband, wedded and bedded for months, he

blushed. It was the most intimate touch he had really felt in years.

"I-"

She pulled away and excitedly prancing away, hair wildly articulating as she went over formulas out loud, brainstorming improvements that he was far too distracted to consider. And by the time Prime was able to articulate what he really had wanted to say just then, she was gone, leaving him alone and shaken.

"I love her," he whispered in wonder to the empty underground lab, staring at his reflection in smooth dark glass. "This is... *unfortunate*."

Yet, despite his grim declaration, he smiled.

Red

Chapter Notes

So! I have some explaining to do!
Its been a month and for that I apologize. I did not mean for that to happen, but a series of, frankly, annoying medical issues popped up.
So. First, I injured my dominant hand to the point where I couldn't type for weeks. Then, when I finally recovered from that, I was diagnosed with the plague (covid-19). That took a gooooood long time to recover from. Its no picnic. But here I am, back and ready to hurt you again!
Because let me assure you,

I absolutely plan to hurt you. <3

Enjoy this chapter. Savor it. Because it's rough from here on out.

The longer Entrapta stayed, the shorter her days felt. Routine wasn't a bad thing, she found, especially now. Her days were a checklist, every hour, every event a box to mark off until she was able to slip into bed.

She found joy in each dying day. Each passing hour was one step closer to salvation. Before the end of the day, she would follow her husband deep down under the heart of the ship and monitor the progress of Hordaks new body.

"It's nearly time," the majestic, rumbling boom informed her, "only another day or so."

Entrapta placed a hand against the glass, smiling at the floating body in the vitrine.

"Thank you," she murmured, "you're nicer than you pretend to be."

It wasn't true. Entrapta had learned to lie in the past few months. A skill Talullah had informed her was 'vital'. Survival depended on it now.

Behind her, Entrapta could almost sense the heat from his cheeks as he stuttered.

"I-I am always kind! I am... I am simply..."

Entrapta turned to face him with a smile and he fell silent. This was a change that she found she actually quite preferred. Her ability to silence him with a smile and send him absolutely reeling when she kissed him. If she were watching from the outside she might have even fooled herself. She appeared to all as a woman in love, cradling her growing belly.

Sometimes at night, she would laugh about it with Hordak. And sometimes she would cry.
And sometimes she would rage, eyes burning and trembling anger dripping from her lips like a dragon's fire.

"I'm sleepy. Think I'll turn in for the night," she informed her still stuttering imperial husband.

"S-shall I escort you?" He offered his arm and Entrapta took it automatically. She knew better than to refuse. It was part of the lie. Even so, there was a hesitation that was difficult to hide.

After all this time, her "love" was a fragile one. She could claim for care for the man and not be caught entirely in a lie. She cared as much as she was able to care for her captor. He was giving Hordak a new body, after all. That wasn't nothing.

As usual, conversation did not come easy to them. Entrapta watched the floor as they walked, one hand cradling the growing bump. The Emperor looked away and attempted to make small talk by pointing out a flaw to be fixed somewhere on his ship, or an imperfect clone.
He fussed about imperfections quite a lot, she noted.

"perhaps we could have this section torn out and-"

"My Emperor, My Emperess," a cheery voice called, and when they turned to look, Beck came bounding forward with spiraling white hair bouncing. She stopped in front of the royal couple and dipped into the perfect bow. "Apologies for the interruption. I bring urgent news On the state of the Etherian Rebellion."

A sharp hush fell over the group at the word 'Etherian'. Although Entrapta was getting better at hiding reactions, she could not quite keep her eyes from widening in curiosity and excitement. And it displeased the Emperor.

"Thank you, Beck. I shall hear more momentarily." He snapped his fingers and a green eyed, smiling clone appeared at his side almost like magic. "You will accompany my wife back to her chambers. Dear One? Will you be alright without me for the night?"

Entrapta bit her tongue, smiled and nodded.

"An Emperor must do what he can for the good of his subjects," she replied, regurgitating a line that had been fed to her by one of the wives, "I will miss you like the stars."

It was in that moment that she cracked a smile. If only he knew what it had been like growing up without the stars? Truth was, it was hard to miss what you never really had.

Before he could respond, she began to walk away, holding the well muscled, healthy arm of one of the clones.
The moment they were out of earshot she asked, "and what is your name?"

The clone grinned, sharp teeth glittering like emeralds.

"Jade, your Majesty," was the simple response.

"Nice to meet you, Jade."

"Why hasn't that pitiful rebellion been dealt with?"

Prime sat upon his throne, face impassive, yet behind his insect-like eyes, a storm was gathering. As he scrolled through images of the uprising on Etheria, Beck shuffled uncomfortably. Child of Prime or not, The Emperor hated receiving bad news from anyone. Her thick white curls bounced as she dipped into yet another perfect bow.

"Majority of the troops that you sent were eliminated, your Magnificence," she answered, "the rest..."

She hesitated and that was a mistake. She bit her tongue so hard she could taste blood, eyes squeezed shut. The silence was deafening. When she finally looked up, the Emperor had banished the hologram and was standing at the top of the dias, watching her with all six eyes.

"The rest *what*?" He demanded, taking the first step down.

"The rest abandoned their posts," she explained quickly, "Some retreated and we assume went into hiding. The others..."

He took another thundering step, and she saw his attendants exchange nervous glances behind the throne.

"The others appear to have joined the rebels, Your Extravegance!"

One foot stepped down to her level, then the other and he stopped. She realized at that moment just how much she had been looking just past him, never quite *at* him. When she saw him face, her blood ran cold. His lips were curled up at the corners, jaw clicking, shifting, contorting. A clawed hand grasped her shoulder and the towering figure leaned in close to the small alien female. Her eyes widened in fear as his jaws widened, seperated, large enough to swallow her whole to her shoulders, a second row of teeth near the back of his throat now fully visible and gleaming.

She closed her eyes, trembling, certain of her end.

"Your Majesty, let *me* handle the big mean rebels."

The voice came from one of the Emperors door guards. Beck opened one eye just enough to glance at him over her shoulder in bewilderment. She was thirty seconds away from having her head bitten off, quite literally. But first, perhaps her Father might devour his clone. Perhaps he would be too full to eat her? She could only hope.

His hand dropped from her shoulder and she heard his jaw snap shut with a loud click.

"Double Trouble," he purred, moving past her, "found your way into my throne room, I see. Risky."

The guard smirked and shifted into a black mass, formless for a moment before taking shape into a long limbed bipedal with a magnificent tail.

"As always, it is my only desire to assist you, Your Radiance," they replied, bowing with a flourish, "surely, you in your infinite wisdom saw through my disguise in an instant. Of that I've no doubt."

Beck glanced from her father to the shape-shifting nervously and took a step to the side. Surely, her Father would crush their windpipe for this insolence. But, no. He began to laugh, and so did theshape-shifter.

"Ah, yes. You have wit, my friend," the Emperor laughed, "come. Have a drink with me and we can discuss your assignment."

"And my payment," The one called Double Trouble added.

The Emperor turned and stepped back up to his throne, sat down and crossed his legs, previous temper seemingly forgotten just as quickly as it came.

"Beck, my Dearest girl," he sang, "call for my generals, then you may have the rest of the evening off. Goodnight, Stardust."

Beck dipped into another flawless bow, clutching her tablet to her chest as she fled the throne room as quickly as her small feet would allow her. Once more, fate had spared her and she was free to play the dutiful daughter.
Survival was the name of the game, and she was an expert player.

"Tonight."
"We can't."
"We have to."
"But-"
"Its tonight or never, Hordak."

For an hour, the couple had argued back and forth. Fear, frustration, anxiety and even excitement could be felt, thick as smog.

When Hordak rose to pace about the room, Entrapta followed.

"But if we fail..." he whispered, but stopped, seemingly too afraid to utter that fate into existence.

"We *wont*," she assured him, "or at least I'm 76% sure we won't. Besides, isn't it like I always say? Failure is a vital part of scientific discovery?"

"Entrapta, this isn't some science experiment," he sighed, shaking his head, "this is our survival. Yours, mine... theirs."

His eyes went again as it frequently did to her swollen abdomen and he squeezed her hand as if the action might somehow make her see reason.

"Jellybean is exactly why we have to do this tonight," she explained urgently.

"J-jellybean?" He cocked his head to the side, browline furrowed.

"A temporary name," she explained, shrugging, "I think it sounds cute. Better than Zed, anyway. It looked like a jellybean last time I got to view its fetal development. The technology here really is incredible. If we weren't in such a hurry I-"

"*Jellybean*," Hordak repeated, with a strange tone in his voice. Suddenly he turned away from her and put his hands to his face, shoulders shaking.

Stunned, Entrapta lifted herself up to his height with her hair, hand going to his shoulder at once.

"I'm sorry! I didn't think a nickname would make you so upset! We can call it what ever you want! I-!"

"Jelly! bean!" He snorted, then burst out in planet shattering peals of mirth. "Of all things- *Jelly bean*!"

Entrapta stared for a moment as her lover doubled over, clutching his sides. Then at once, she laughed as well. Together, they collapsed into the couch, clutching hands, even as Hordak wiped a tear from the corner of his eye.

"Jellybean," he sighed the instant his laughter faded, "a more suitable name will be required in the future."

"Of course," she responded, squeezing his hand, "did you... want to name it?"

The question seemed to take him by surprise somewhat. He blinked, color shifting in his gaze for an instant, green, red, then nearly violet before fading once again to the default. He bit his lip, cheeks going crimson and Entrpta squeezed his hand to prevent him from pulling away.

"I have never named anything," he admitted quietly, averting his gaze, "I do not think I would do well."

"What about yourself?" She asked, "Prime said you gave yourself a name, didn't he?"

Hordak snorted, looking far away for a moment, as if he were gazing through time and space.

"I do not accept credit for that name. It was given to me by the Scorpioni king when I crashed," he explained, "I explained as best I could that I was from the horde and I had no name, but you Etherians are... sentimental. You give names to everything. Animals, plants... children. For me that seemed foolish. But there was no getting through to him. He insisted. I..."

"Scorpias grandfather," Entrapta wondered out loud, "she told me about him. What happened to them?"

He would not look at her. When she leaned forward to see his face, he only turned further away. After what felt like an eternity, he answered.

"*I* happened to them," he murmured, "my first allies on this planet. My first... *friend*. And I took their runestone and enslaved their people the instant I had the power to do so. After all they did for me, a stranger in their lands. After healing me, feeding me, sheltering me. After all the kindness they showed me, I-"

"You followed your programing," Entrapta concluded, nodding solemnly, "you did what your Emperor would have wanted."

"Yes, and look where *that* landed me," he snarled, "hiding under the eye of my Emperor, dead the instant he suspects- And Scorpia. I took everything from-!"

Entrants pulled his hand to her stomach, the only thing now that seemed to calm him when he was in a mood. As she had predicted, the effect was immediate. Like ice, he melted into her touch, wilting to her will, falling into her like a swaying branch.

"*Tonight*," she repeated once more, "we leave tonight. And you can make it all up to Scorpia once we're back."

Against her shoulder, she felt him nod in agreement, then, to her surprise, he began to purr. Much as her husband would do after he had done as he wished, but this felt charming, not possessive. And Entrapta found herself running her fingers through his thick pale hair on top of his head.

In a few hours, everything would change, but for now, she enjoyed her captivity.

"I heard our dear husband had a real nasty temper tantrum today," Dhar snickered behind the safety of a large ruby fan.

Tallulah rolled her eyes and sunk comfortably deeper into her warm pool of water.

"Anillis has always had a temper," she sighed, "ever since we were young. When things don't go his way, he can just fly off the handle. *Childish*."

The golden Prince kicked his feet lightly from where he sat on the edge, sending droplets into Tallulahs perfect curls, much to her annoyance.

"Speaking so openly and disrespectfully!" He gasped, feigning shock, "Be careful, my dear. He's already killed one wife. With his temper, he might just be looking for blood..."
He lowered his fan, flashing a playful grin.
"-even if you *are* his favorite."

Tallulah shot the Prince a dirty look and flicked a wave of water in his direction with a tentacle.

"Perhaps you have a point," she relented, ignoring his shriek and complaints of ruined makeup, "after all... I'm not his favorite anymore."

There was no bitterness in her voice, no hint at anxiety over the fact. It was simply that. Fact. She couldn't be angry for it.

"Ah, yes. The Emperess," he sighed, shaking his perfect golden head free of droplets, "but you don't *really* think she'll hold his interest after she plops out her brat, do you? She's so... dull."

Tallulah frowned, glanced behind her at her current companion waiting a short distance away before turning her attention back to Dhar.

"If she is so dull, then why would he choose her and not you?" She snapped back, shaking her curls behind her shoulders, "surely you could hold his attention better, yes? But then... tell me, Dearie. When was the last time he invited you to his bed?"

Dhar gasped, snapped his fan shut and held a hand to his chest, red jewels glistening on his fingers.

"I-! I simply don't *want* his attention right now!" He sniffed, flapping the trailing sleeve of his crimson robe, "being in my position suits me just fine! Who needs the responsibilities of the Emperors favorite? Not me!"

Tallulah snickered, one tentacle easing ever closer to Dhar as his bare foot bounced impatiently in the water.

"Indeed?" She questioned, "well. I can't say I blame you. That girl is going to have a rough few years ahead of her."

At that reminder, an uncomfortable silence fell between the two.

"Yes, well... perhaps I can afford to show her a *little* more kindness," Dhar relented after clearing his throat awkwardly, "j-just a little, mind you. I won't coddle the girl. But I suppose giving her some fashion tips couldn't hurt. Oh!"
He clapped his hands excitedly. "I could give her a makeover! How fun!"

"Yes," Tallulah laughed in agreement, "I do know how you love to make things beautiful."

"And she is not a *bad* looking girl by any stretch," he pondered, tapping his ruby fan to his chin, "with the right touch, why! She could be a priceless jewel!"

"Speaking of jewels," Tallulah immediately got to the heart of things, "did you bring it?"

Dhar raised a perfect brow with a smirk, unfolding his fan in front of his face.

"Bring what?" He teased, "you will have to be more specific Tally."

He was met with a stone cold glare and he rolled his eyes, fishing something from the folds of his brilliant red robes.

"Ugh, fine. Here," he snapped, holding up a hand.
Tallulah caught a glimpse of a flash of violet before it vanished in his fingers again.
"Ah ah ah!" He teased, "you don't get something for nothing! You didn't think I would do this out of the goodness of my heart, did y-?"

In answer, a tentacle wrapped around his ankle and dragged him stuttering and splashing into the pool with her. While he attempted to save his hair from utter ruin, she snatched her prize from his flailing fingers with a dark tentacle.

"*Rude*!" He snarled, pulling himself out of the water like a half drowned cat. "Absolutely uncalled for! I was teasing!"

Tallulah laughed as she brought the crystal close to her face, reading the inscription out loud with a smile.

"L. U. V. D." She purred, "Loved. Isn't that sweet?"

"Yes, cute," Dhar sulked, squeezing water from his robes, "so charming. Have you any idea how difficult that 'sweet' little stone

was to obtain? Scolopendra had to go at it for hours with our husband before he was sufficiently exhausted."

"Give her my thanks," she shot back, holding the jewel to the light.

"What did you need it for so badly anyway?" Dhar pouted, dabbing at his ruined makeup, "going to pawn it? Import water from your home world? "

"I am returning it to Entrapta," she revealed, "where it belongs. He had no right to take it from her and I will teach Anillis a lesson."

Dhar blinked, certain now that he was witnessing madness.

"*That* was your big quest? Your important life or death task?" He sniffed, opening his soaking red fan with a wet slap. "You are far too kind for your own good. You'll get yourself killed on day, and I won't feel bad for you at all!"

Tallulah snickered and hid the gem safely between her bosom.

"Oh, don't you lie to me. You would be positively beside yourself with grief!"

Her voice was teasing, but Dhar looked entirely unamused. His gaze took on a sad, far away expression.

"I mean it, Tally," he said darkly gazing at the deepest part of the waters, "he isn't the same as he once was. Don't forget-"

He cut himself off and her eyes followed his to where she placed a stone of remembrance for Aleiz.

"I know," she replied softly, "how could I ever forget?"

"She isn't worth you losing your life over," Dhar continued, urgently, "just... promise you'll be careful, alright? If something

happens to you, I'll be left with just Zallah, and she isn't half as fun!"

Tallulah glanced behind her once more to where her Companion, Stella, was braiding a section of Dhars still nameless Companions hair.

"Change is here, Dhar," she sighed, "want it or not, it is here. Still... I'll be careful. I promise."

"You'd better!" He snapped, "or I'll suffocate you with my tits!"

He pressed his golden pectoral muscles together and made a face as if to imitate her own ever present pout. For a moment, Tallulah had no words, but then she laughed, a real, big, hearty, water trembling laugh.

"Oh stars," she chuckled, "I do hope that in all of this, *you* at least, never change."

"Never," he promised, reaching out for his glass of sweet wine sitting in a puddle next to him. Tallulah reached for her glass a well and together they raised them.

"To change," he said.
"-And," Talullah added, "to what remains."

Lavender

Midnight in space was a difficult thing to get used to. Of course Entrapta understood the need to have a specific set of hours for sleeping, but she still did not see the need to turn the lights down so low in the halls of the flag ship. Really, it seemed like a security risk.

"Or perhaps the purpose is to save power?" She pondered quietly as she guided Hordak through the dark towards the secure elevator, "possibly. Maybe routine mantinence is done during these hours to prevent the court from seeing-"

"Entrapta, these are *fascinating* theories" Hordak whispered, "however, I think we should proceed quietly?"

"OH! Right!" She replied, not at all quietly as they stepped into the glass elevator. "Err! I mean-!" She lowered her voice to a whisper, "right."

Hordak bit his lip, but despite his fear, he could not prevent the smile now working its way across his lips. The moment the elevator began its steady decent, the smile slipped away.

"Go over the plan again," he sighed, "just once more."

Entrapta pulled something from the confines of her white jumpsuit. With a click of her finger a small holograohic display of the ships cooridors lit up the darkened elevator.

"We are here. At the very bottom is Primes lab. Your new body is being kept inside here. We just have to slip passed the guard. We have about... six hours, approximately. He is with Lenneh tonight. I think. Marco says he usually spends at least six hours with-"

"Marco?"

"Lennah's companion," she explained before moving on, "that is enough time to transfer you to a healthy body and slip away

unnoticed. Hopefully."

"Hopefully?" Hordak bit his lip, "and you know what you're doing? If its done wrong I could be erased entirely."

"Oh, don't worry about that! Prime showed me how!"

"Showed you-"

"Yes. I asked. He showed me. He... um, wanted me to know how so I could help him when I came time for him to 'move on too."

Hordak fell into silence allowing the Emperess to continue.

"Now, once we handle that, we'll grab She Ra's sword on our way out. Adora is going to need it and... I cant leave it with him, Hordak," her voice went soft, shaky, "he is days away from figuring out how to fix it. Once he does that..."

"Once he does that, Etheria is gone," he completed, "and so is any resistance to his will."

She nodded and pointed to a hangar a distance away.

"We can move through the vents to get to here," she explained, "Jay says he 'accidentally' left a ship fueled and at the ready-"

"Jay is...?"

"Another clone, yes," she impantiently said, "please keep up, Hordak. We should be able to reach a port planet at least and from there, I can barter passage to Etheria with this."

She touched the green jeweled collar at her throat before dismissing the hologram. Hordak glanced at the panel on the elevator. Nearly there. Still time to go back.

"It is... a shaky plan," he sighed, "Entrapta, if one thing goes wrong-"

"Then we do things the Adora way," she insisted, "we improvise."

"Improvise," he snorted, "how did we lose to them so often?"

Entrapta grinned and reached for his hand.

"Don't worry so much," she whispered, pulling his palm to her round stomach, "the plan will work. I am 58% sure of it."

Hordak gave her a look and she cleared her throat, looking away as the elevator stopped.

"Okay, 56%," she corrected, "but it is still adequate."

"56% is considered a failure," he grumbled as the glass elevator doors whooshed open. Entrapta grabbed his claw and pulled him along, following the dark hall as she so often did with her Emperor.

She dropped his hand before reaching the clone guard at the door. As usual, the poor clone met her gaze with an initial burst of fear before it registered that it was only her.

"Hi Juniper," Entrapta greeted cheerfully, "just need to check on the clone-"

"You shouldn't be here without the Emperor," he mumbled, looking anywhere but at the couple, "By orders of Emperor Prime."

The air stilled and Entrapta and Hordak froze. Then, the clone stepped aside.

"Hurry up. I didn't see you," he murmured, still looked away, "You were not here."

The couple exchanged a look before moving on through the double doors. It was best not to argue, lest he change his mind.

The instant the door closed behind them, Entrapta got to work.

"Alright, I calculate we have about thirty minutes before the guard changes. Once that happens, our chances of getting out of here drops to 35%," she chattered, hands flying across a holographic keyboard, "much less impressive odds. Luckily, I managed to set up the system beforehand by insisting we test the transfer process first. So all I need to do is reroute-"

"Entrapta, short version," Hordak snapped, stepping into the empty glass transfer chamber.

"If I move the thing to the other thing, which should take only five minutes, I can transfer you easier," she impatiently explained, using small words and pointing.

Hordak snorted in annoyance, but didn't talk back, especially as she stepped up behind him.

"Finished," she announced, "I had it set up to test on an imperfect clone that Prime was planning to send to the front lines anyway. We were meant to 'test' this tomorrow-"

"You haven't *tested* it?!" Hordak nearly shrieked, just as Entrapta hit a button and restraints claped over his wrists and ankles, locking him in.

"Don't worry," she said, sounding less than reassuring, "I've run the simulations. It's only blown up twice!"

Hordak bit his lip, wincing as she manually plugged tubes into his ports one by one.

"H-how many simulations did you run?" He asked, knowing he wouldn't like the answer.

There was a hesitation before Hordak felt the final plug enter the base of his neck. He hissed and clutched his hands, as the unpleasant liquid made his veins run unpleasantly hot and his saliva taste like metal.

"...Five times," she answered at last, "but we are out of time. Its now or never. Say the word, and I'll stop."

Hordak watched his soul mate as she moved in front of him, to check his ports and run a final test on the connection. As he watched her, his heart cried out for her. A small chance was better than none. If he stayed here, if they did not take this time while the Emperor was distracted, they would never have another.

"...Do it," he whispered, meeting her eye, then, in a voice much stronger, "Do. It. Now."

Entrapta swallowed hard, bit her lip then gave a stiff nod. As she turned back to the control panel, Hordak called out to her one last time.

"I love you," he cried in a shaking voice, "J-just in case I can't-"

"I love you too," she cut him off, too afraid to let him finish his sentence. Her hand hovered above the button for a moment before she glanced at him over her shoulder.

"See you soon."

Then it all went dark.

Ajna was patient. She'd learned to be from years of imprisonment, from watching her kingdom fall, from watching her once beautiful planet reduced to a mining colony, her people, slaves.
She was also resourceful. When her sister died, she did not just leave her with sadness, emptiness and a bloody gown. She left her a gift, one more precious than anything.

Rage.

Oh. She had so much of it. Her entire form radiated with it. It pumped in her veins, filled her lungs. She saw with it, spoke with it, felt with it.

It gave her strength she did not know she had, clarity she did not think herself capable of. And a determination that could move worlds.

Ajna had built a network of rebels, many who, to her surprise, existed in the Emperors own harem. It was Dhar who approached first. He visited in the dead of night and told her of Aleiz and the rebellion. He named names, Ryha, Lennah and Sheriez were safe, he said, but Scolopendra, Karena, and Fleik would sell her out in an instant.

Much to her surprise, they were not the only ones who came forward to help.

Rawnie had changed so much. Humbled, perhaps by her botched poisoning of the Emperess. She seemed to feel such a guilt, not just over Entrapta, but for unintentionally selling out Aleiz. She started off subtle at first. Sorrowful looks across the room, kind words. But it became clear that she had an ally in this woman.

When Ajna passed her in the hall once, the woman dropped her fan. As Ajna bent to retrieve it for her, she saw the words scribbled across the handle, 'Paharna Forever.' She met Rawnies eyes, mouth open, speechless. Even speaking the name of Ajna's planet had become a grave crime. This act of rebellion was telling.

Rawnie proved to be a resource unlike anything she had considered. That woman had the gossip on everyone. It turned out, her large, pointed pink ears were not just for aestetics.

So when Rawnie overheard the escape plan, Ajna found out too. And she was ready. She had allies, resources, and a plan. She would leave with them, one way or another and she would join the Rebellion starting up on Etheria.

Because it was her best bet, her only shot.

"For Paharna," she mumbled, standing over a freshly dead clone, clutching a blaster in one hand as she wiped a splash of clone

blood off her cheek with the other. "For the Rebellion."

Black, the void of space. Endless darkness, stretching forever, reaching for eternity. Hordak had not in his life experienced a darkness like this.
Death? Perhaps. He had never experienced death before, so it was a distinct possibility.

"...dak."

A faint echo called across the inky nothingness. A voice. A nice voice. A little naseley, perhaps, but for some reason, he did not mind.

"Hordak...?"

Her. The voice belonged to a woman. A pretty one. How did he know that? It didn't matter. It said his name in such a nice way. His...

Name?

"Hordak?"

She sounded upset. He didn't want to upset her. He could hear tears.

Don't cry... Entrapta.

Wait-

"Hordak!"

Entrapta!

The eyes that shot open were not his.

No. They were. Now they were. Entrapta stared at them with wonder, admiring the pale blue hue, so alien, so unique.

She watched them study her tear streaked face, widen in realization. She smiled as he sat up like a shot, wide eyed as he studied the limp, lifeless body across the room.

"It..." he paused, crackling voice too new to be used properly. He cleared his throat and tried again, unsure. "I-it worked...?"

Entrapta threw her arms around his new, damp, nude body, crying out in excitement and relief.

"You were out for ten minutes," she cried, "when your pulse died in your old body and this one didn't animate, I thought-"

Shakily, Hordak ran his new hands through her hair, testing his fingers, admiring the ease of movement. He winched, anticipating a pain that never came, then gently pushed Entrapta off of him so he could attempt standing.

"Oh. I brought you clothes," she murmured, tearing her eyes from his nude form with a light blush, "um, let me help-"

"No. No," he shakily insisted, rising to his feet with an ease that he had not felt in far too many years, "I want to do it myself."

Entrapta did not argue. She simply handed him the robe without arguing and turned her attention back to his old body.

She approached it, the only Hordak she had ever known. Fragile, sickly, but he had still been hers. He had loved her with this body. He had given her everything with this body.

And now he was... new? Well no. Not new. Not exactly.

With one hand outstretched, she touched the fingers of Hordaks original body, just one more time.

"We have to go," she said, whipping around suddenly, "we took too long."

Hordak had just finished putting on the new boots when she snatched his hand and practically whipped him across the room towards the door.

"How long did-"

"27 minutes," she answered, checked the time on her wrist and added, "28, actually. And six seconds.

Hordak did not need to hear more. They were out of time. As they rushed back through the doors, they were met with what Entrapta had dreaded.

"Emperess?" There was a measure of confusion on the face that greeted them. Not the same clone who had politely ignored their intrusion.

Entrapta let out a tiny hissed curse before looking up again with a smile.

"Oh! Hi! I wanted to run some tests. Couldn't sleep. You know how it is."

She gestured vaguely at her belly as if that explained everything.

The nameless guard bowed stiffly, but the skepticism on his thin stretched mouth was readable even to Entrapta.

"My Emperess, you must be aware that after hours, it is strictly forbidden for you to be out of your room-" his eyes snapped to the new Hordak, hovering over her small form. "This is not your assigned companion."

Hordak moved to attack, but before he could get to him, a current of brilliant amber electricity ran through his body. Before Entrapta and Hordaks eyes, the clone guard fell at their feet face first.

Behind them, half hidden behind the door, stood Juniper holding a stun baton.

"I. Didn't. See. *Anything*." He stated firmly, but he smiled a crooked, broken little smile and held the stun baton out for Hordak to take. "But if I did see anything, I would tell them to carry one of these."

Wordlessly, Hordak took the offered weapon with a deep nod of respect. Entrapta on the other hand, pushed herself up on her hair and planted a swift kiss to the clones hollow cheek.

"Thank you."

The clone looked away, but the blush on his face was as clear as empty space.

"Go," he grumbled, "hurry."

Hordak grabbed her hand and began to pull her away. As they hurried back to the elevator, Entrapta saw Juniper reach up with one scarred hand to touch the place where her lips touched his skin.
And she knew it would be the last time she saw that battered old clone.

Talullah knew. How could she not? People trusted her. That was fact. And when you were trusted, people talked. Dhar had talked because Dhar was not the carefree pampered prince he pretended to be. And thank goodness he wasn't.

Because now Talullah was waiting by the green glass elevator, arms crossed. As it rose into view, she noted the look for fear on Entraptas face immediately, before the doors even opened. And the clone behind her-
Not Hordak?
Oh. Yes. Of course.

"I'm not here to stop you," she said immediately, holding her hands up in surrender before a word could be spoken.

"What do you want?" The clone growled, stepping forward, stun baton held out, one hand protectively on the Emperesses shoulder.

"I'm just here to make a delivery, Dear," she said through gritted teeth, then she opened her palm, brilliant violet crystal shining against the dark fingers. "This is yours, right?"

Entrapta gasped, hands to her mouth as she stepped forward.

"Entrapta-! Don't!" Hordak hissed, "it could be a trap! She is-!"

"A friend, Hordak. She's a *friend*. And she won't hurt me," Entrapta insisted, reaching forward with a tentacle of lavender hair.

Tallulah held the crystal out between two fingers and allowed her to snatch it away without a fight. Once it was out of her possession, she turned her back, fussing with her thick ringlets of hair.

"Well. That is done then," she murmured, "goodnight. Be well. And be careful."

She began to slither away, looping tentacles flashing under a transparent gown.

"Wait!" Hordak called, "Why?"

"Hm? Why what?" She stopped, glancing over her shoulder.

"Why are you...? Will you report us?"

"For what? Taking a midnight stroll?"
Tallulah shook her head and snickered.
"I've done it countless times myself. No need to worry darlings. Your... *secret* is safe."

Entrapta and Hordak exchanged a look as she held a hand up.

"Go on now," she called, as she reached the laboratory doors, "I'll distract the guards for you so you're not interrupted. Best of luck."

"Tally!" Entrapta called, just as she raised her hand to the door panel, "thank you! I won't forget you!"

Tallulah looked over her shoulder just one more time, smiling. The little Emperess had the crystal clasped to her heart, fresh tears in her eyes.

Without another word to the couple, she pressed her palm to the panel and sauntered out. Before the doors closed, she could hear quite distinctly,

"Ah! There you are, handsome. How about you and you're cute friend come back to my room with me?"

For a full measure, the two were silent, then Hordak said,
"The sword. "

"Right!" Entrapta squealed, "it's here."

She wiped her eyes on the back of her sleeve and hurried to the locked chamber, stuffing the crystal in a pocket for safe keeping. Hordak followed close behind as she crossed the pristine white laboratory.

"He gave me the code to unlock it," she mumbled, tracing a series of complex shapes on a green diamond panel.

"He trusts you," Hordak grumbled, "it's... i used to be the one he trusted. That he-"

As the panel glowed and unlocked, Entrapta glanced at her lover, the pain in his new eyes.

"Hordak, you don't have to think about him like that anymore," she reminded him, "technically, you own a body now that he's

never touched. You're free."

Hordak opened his mouth to respond, but closed it again when the chamber opened, revealing the nearly repaired sword. Nearly perfect, save for a small chip missing from the tip.

"Thank you, Entrapta," he said as she reached inside to pull it out, gently wrapping a silk lavender cloth around the sharp metal. "For... everything."

She cradled the sword like a child, turning her smiling face to his.

"Save the thanks for when we get back home."

"Home?" Stunned, he blinked down at the tiny Emperess.

"Etheria," she explained, "The Frightzone, or maybe even Dryl. It doesn't matter, as long as we're together."

Home. The word hit like a meteor. It shattered reality. It set his soul on fire. He stood there, stupidly for a moment, then reached out to her growing belly.

"Together," he repeated, letting a small breath of a laugh escape, "yes."

"We should go," Entrapta reminded herself after a little too long, "Tallulah can't keep them distracted forever."

"Yes she can," Hordak chuckled, taking the heavy sword from her, "but yes, we should go. The vents, yes?"

In response, Entrapta reached up with her impossible lavender locks and pulled a nearly invisible panel from the ceiling.

"I prepared it earlier today too!" She explained excitedly, "you can be impressed later."

Hordak *was* impressed too. There was no reason for this plan to have gone as well as it did. Sure, they were a little behind

schedule, but he was feeling a confidence that not know his entire life. This woman gave him hope. Clarity.

Without another word, she swung herself up into the open vent with a flash of lavender. Hordak followed, tossing the sword up inside before climbing inside as well, his impossibly powerful muscles working with him in a way he found almost unnatural.

I can get used to this, he thought as Entrapta reached down with her hair to close the vent tight behind them.

"Alright. Not far now," Entrapta murmured, bringing up a holographic map of the vents.

"Lead the way, Princess."

Crisp white covers pulled up to his chest, The Emperor lay on his back, arms occupied the two beauties sleeping curled up on either side. All six eyes focused on a single point in the high ceiling. In his mind, he was imagining Etheria, the pretty little blue gem in space. He imagined he could reach out for it, hold it in his hand, between his two claws like a marble.

And then he imagined crushing it like a grape.

Oh. They would pay. Quite dearly. But he would be patient. He would not destroy the planet yet. Not until he had squeezed every resource out of its pretty soil. Not until he had the heart of Etheria in his hands.

But first... well. He had been generous enough to grant their Precious Princesses a certain level of independence, but they had chosen to act like spoiled children. Rebelling against their all knowing Emperor. They must be disciplined. It was, after all, the responsible thing to do.

At his side, Karena stirred, but it was Scolopendra who spoke.

"My love?" She purred, blinking up at him through thick lashes, "you look troubled. Is it that awful little planet again?"

The Emperor pulled his attention away from the imaginary universe above him and to the stunning woman next to him. His lips pulled up into a brilliant green smile as he gently played with her insect-like hair.

"Oh, do not worry about me, my precious moonbeam," he sighed, "Etheria won't be a problem for long."

As to illustrate his point, he slipped his arm out from under Karena and held up his palm. At his urging, a holographic model of Etheria flashed to life in the low light of the royal bedchambers.

"All I need are a few Princesses, their silly rocks and this She Ra person and the rest of the Universe will be mine."

"Rocks? Princesses?" Scolopendra raised a brow as her centipede hair crawled across her husband's bare chest.

"Never mind that, my dear. No need to worry your pretty little arthropods about it," he teased, "all you need to do is-"

"This?" She purred, slowly dipping below the bed sheets. Prime chuckled, then groaned as she reached her goal.

"Ah! Yes. That."

At his side, Karena opened one eye and lifted her head slightly. She opened her mouth to speak, but caught one of the Emperors eyes instead.

"You may go now," he sighed, "Scolopendra will be sufficient."

Karena blinked and frowned as Scolopendra poked her head out from under the covers slightly, just enough to gloat. Karena frowned, tossed her kelp-like hair over her shoulder, picked up her clothes and left.

As Prime watched her leave, one of his eyes fell to his nightstand. Something was different. Why?

Oh, it didn't matter. He would remember eventually. For now, his thoughts were otherwise occupied as his wife once more vanished below the bed sheets.

They were free. Or at least near enough. The finish line was in sight. The end was near.

And then it all fell apart.

Getting through the vents had been easy. But the instant they were out, it all fell apart.

The second the alarm was set off, Entrapta understood. Everything that came before was easy because Prime had a very expensive security measure in place.

Alarms. Ajna cursed, hastily wiping clone blood from her hair. She could see them, just climbing down from the vents into the nearly empty hangar.

Nearly empty, because three clone guards now lay dead and bleeding around the only conveniently fueled ship.

"Don't just *stand* there!" Ajna shouted, startling the couple, "you're leaving right? Hurry up! We don't have much time!"

Entrapta and Hordak exchanged glances, stared from the dead clones, to the blood covered wife of the Emperor holding the blaster. It took less than 2 seconds to make a decision.

They burst into a sprint, holding hands, hearts thundering together. Freedom, seconds away. A life. A home. Together.

Ajna gestured to them impatiently from the ships ramp, and as they began to climb on board, the hangar filled with bots and clone soldiers.

"You're-?" Entrapta began, but Ajna cut her off as she began to raise the ramp.

"Ajna. Yeah. My sister tried to kill you. I don't have time to get into it. No. I *can't* convince you to trust me. Yes. I *am* the best chance you've got."

Hordak snarled, pointing the stun baton at the woman.

"We should throw her off-"

"Try it, Planet Breaker," the other woman snapped, blaster trained at his face, "i can blow a hole through that new face of yours, or we can get out of here. Your choice!"

"I'll take my chances-"

"No you won't!" Entrapta snapped, holding her hands up to both, "Ajna, can you fly this?"

Ajna lowered her weapon, as did Hordak, reluctantly.

"Prime stole the design of these ships from my people," Ajna grumbled, making her way to the cockpit, "I've got it."

Entrapta sunk into the nearest seat, Hordak set his stun baton down next to the sword and hovered close by.

"Whats taking so long?" He demanded.

Ajna blinked at the console, shaking her head.

"It doesn't make sense! It says unauthorized cargo, but-"

She turned and her eyes widened. All at once, all three realized too late what had happened.

"Entrapta-!"
"The jewel-"
"It won't-"

Entrapta reached to her throat where the Emperors wedding gift now glowed a faint, sickly green.

"Take it off!" Hordak shouted, "throw it outside!"

"I- I can't!" The panic rang clear as a bell, "it won't come off! It's-"

"It's locked," Ajna answered, "Entrapta... the only way that's coming off, is of we take your head off first."

The Emperor sat up the instant the alarms went off, nearly knocking Scolopendra off of his lap.

"Enough," he snarled, "to your room. *Now*."

The wife blinked in confusion, but quickly gathered her clothes and hurried away.

That was the moment it hit him. The crystal was gone.

"You touch her and I-!"

"Well, it's her or us, Clone!"

"I am not leaving without her!"

"We. Can. Not. Leave. With. *Her*!"

"Then we aren't leaving!" Hordak roared, "We will-"

He did not get to finish. His strong new body seized and a paralyzing bolt of electricity shot through every cell. He dropped to his knees, fighting the darkness filling his vision.

"Entrap-"

Another volt shot through him and he fell forward, unconsious, but alive.

And, if Entrapta had anything to say about it, free.

"Did you just-?"

Entrapta set the stun baton down and reached into her pocket.

"There isn't a moment to lose. I need you to do something for me."

Ajna looked from the unconscious clone, to the Emperess, knowing full well what she was asking already.

"Alright," she agreed, "anything you need."

Entrapta reached for her hand and shoved the crystal into her palm.

"When he wakes, give this to him. As for me... i need you to walk me out of here with a blaster to my head."

Ajna nodded.
"A hostage situation. Sensible."

"Get him to Etheria. Find Adora. Give her the sword."

"Etheria. Adora. Sword," Ajna repeated, grabbing the woman and placing the blaster against her temple in a way that she hoped looked convincing. "Anything else."

"Yes," Entrapta sighed as she lowered the ramp again, "take care of him."

Hordak hurt. That was the first thing he noticed.

The next thing he noticed was the clean scent of a new ship, and the standard issue gray blanket thrown over him.

But it wasn't until he opened his palm that he remembered everything.

"*Entrapta*!"

He sat up, ignoring his splitting headache, ignoring the tension in his muscles. Ajna did not answer. She stared ahead, silent, watching a hologram of a woman who looked just like her.

"Entrapta!" He shouted again, tripping over his own feet to check the rest of the tiny ship, "Where is Entrapta?!"

"Gone," Ajna answered at last with a sigh, "she's gone. But alive. And so are you, thanks to her."

So close.

He sunk to his knees, long ears drooped to his shoulders. He grit his sharp teeth, moisture pricking his eyes. His strong claws clutched the crystal tight to his chest.

"No," he whispered, "*No*. She... she's hiding somewhere. This is a bad dream. She-"

"She really cares about you," Ajna murmured, reaching out as if to touch the smiling woman in the hologram. "Take her sacrifice. Live."

Hordak shook his head, shoulders shaking, breathing shallow and uneven.

"And then use it," Ajna continued, "Let's kill that bastard. For them. And for us."

Entrapta stood in the middle of the throne room. Dirty and humiliated. Her arms were bound behind her and as she faced her Imperial husband, she was nearly unrecognizable.

Where once a river of lavender once flowed, now short spikes of hair poked unevenly in all directions.

She had wept when they cut it. She had wept nearly nonstop since leaving the ship.

But now, she had no tears. Now, she was facing death. If not for the child inside her, she might have been dead already.

"*Well*?"

The voice of the Emperor was quiet, almost too calm. A terrible sign.

"I... don't know what to say," she whispered, "I was-"

"Your companion escaped with Ajna, and they took the sword," he sighed, making a show of studying his sparkling silver claws, "He transfered into a new body as well. Now, my dear, how ever did that happen?"

"My Love, I-"

"How dare you?" He snarled, "*Love*? You have betrayed me."

"No!" She lied, "I-"

"If I may, sire, It wasn't her fault!"

All eyes turned to look at a clone guard. The Emperor narrowed his eyes and impatiently tapped the arm of his throne.

"Double Trouble," he snapped, "explain."

Before the eyes of the court, the clone shifted into a black mass before narrowing out into an elegant green figure.

"I saw it all, Majesty," they purred, "that clone had our dear, dear Emperess at the end of a blaster. He and Ajna both. Apparently those two had plans to betray you and her."

The Emperor pushed himself up to his feet and a hush fell across the court. One, two, three steps.

Entrapta closed her eyes and looked down.

"Dear One," she heard him whisper as he knelt down in front of her. "Is this true? Look me in the eyes now."

As instructed, she looked up. Magenta studied six sickly green eyes. Slowly, never looking away, she nodded.

"*Yes*."

The Emperor let out a long sigh and leaned in. She flinched, but when she felt his lips touch her forehead, she knew he had been desperate enough to believe it.

"Release her," he ordered, rising to his feet. "Never fear, my darling. We will find the traitors and when we do, I will allow you to kill your former companion yourself."

Entrapta did not reply. As soon as her cuffs released, she touched her wrist, examining the ugly bruises they had left.

"Ah, my poor, sweet, Precious Gem," he sighed, stepping forward to pull her into his embrace, a big public show of forgiving her. "A shame about your hair. It truly was a marvel."

He ran his sharp fingers through the short, messy tufts.

"Still, hair does grow back." he said, then leaned down, close to her ear.

"Better to lose your hair," he whispered darkly, "than to lose your *head*."

Burgundy

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The moons rose and fell as they always had on Etheria. The days came and the nights moved in, cloaking the sky in darkness. Now the night had a sea of stars to decorate her gown.
Etheria spun on, unaware that on its surface, her people cried out in pain.

Adora stood at the mouth of a cave, the most recent rebel hide out. Her blue eyes scanned the tree line as the sun dipped low on the horizon. Something rustled in the bushes and her hand went to the weapon at her side.

"Hey Adora."

A figure stepped out from behind a tree, hooded and cloaked, but Adora relaxed her grip and smiled.

"Catra," she sighed, "you're back early. Something happen?"

Catra put a finger to her lips and glanced around as she approached.

"Inside," she whispered, "can't talk here."

Adora did not argue, especially as Catra took her hand and led her inside the cave.

"Catra, what happened?" Adora asked in a hushed voice as they strode passed tent after tent lined up against the craggy cave wall.

"Get Hordak," Catra sighed, "we intercepted a transmission and he... he needs to see it."

"Its her, isnt it?" Adora asked quietly, "is she-?"

"Alive? Yes. But..." she cut herself off and sighed. "Look, just bring him. He'll see it anyway. Its better if he, uh, isn't alone when he does."

"My Emperess?"

A significant stretch of time passed before the short figure began to rise from her chair.

"Is it time?" Entrapta asked, voice quiet, cracking from disuse.

Zallah nodded, sending little sparkles of gold reflecting off the perfect white walls of the nearly empty room.

"The Emperor is allowing you to carry Prince Zed today," Zallah informed her, voice pitching up just a touch, "isn't that exciting? He says if you're well behaved, he will consider lifting some of your restrictions."

"Zed?" She asked, turning her neatly clipped head to look at the women behind her. "Will he let me...?"

"He may allow you to visit him more often as well," Zallah reluctantly offered, "but only if you are on your best behavior. Understand?"

Slowly, the Emperess inclined her head. That seemed to be enough for the beautiful Zallah who smiled and offered a hand. A brief moment of hesitation passed before Entrapta took the hand offered with a tiny, obediant smile.

"Good girl," Zallah whispered, "Let's get you dressed now."

"If you are interrupting my work," Hordak growled from where he sat hunched over a work bench, "then there must be a dire reason."

Adora let the tent flap fall behind her and motioned to Bow to leave. The young man looked up from his work and cleared his throat.

"Oh, I'm just gunna go to the place... to do the thing?" He lied unconvincingly. Making his exit.

Hordak finally looked up from where he sat hunched over the sword, tools still in hand.

"It's... Entrapta," he guessed, saying her name out loud for the first time in months, "isn't it?"

Adora nodded solemnly, and Hordak felt his chest rise and fall as panic overtook him. Shaking hands dropped his tools with a loud clatter. A thousand thoughts raced through his mind. She must have had the baby by now. Was she dead? Was the baby? Did she get hurt? Was she safe?

"Hey, hey!" Adora crossed the tent to put what she hoped was a comforting hand on his shoulder, "She's fine! She's alive. It's just..."

Her words died in her throat as she looked at the face of the once feared conquer of Etheria. Tears gathered at the corners, his teeth clenched, and then he broke. Before Adora could do anything, he slumped forward, weeping over the work bench.

"Err-! It's okay!" She awkwardly tried to sooth the former Lord of the Frightzone, patting his shoulder. "She's okay. The baby is okay. Prime just made the announcement-"

"Let me see it," he choked, "the transmission. Let me see her."

Adora hesitated but Hordak grabbed her arm, forcing her to look at his face.

"Please," he nearly begged, "please."

The blonde blinked, shaken by the sudden vulnerability displayed. Without another word, she pulled a small holoplayer from her jacket and he let go of her arm as she set it down at the bench in front of him. As she hit play, he turned his entire focus to the hologram.

"Ah, there you are, Dear One."

The pleasant voice of her royal husband made the small Emperess shrink. For months, he had forced her to watch as one by one, he erased every clone she had come in contact with, resetting them back to what he deemed "acceptable".

Those were the lucky ones. There were some who's screams she would never get out of her head.

"Husband," she greeted, keeping her eyes to the floor as she bowed to him.

"You look acceptable," he commented, after circling her once. He stopped in front of her, one silver tipped talon tilting her chin up to meet his cold emerald gaze. His lips turned up at the corners. "Bring him in."

A small cry set her heart racing. Tallulah entered, cradling the tiny heir to a galactic empire. It was the first she had seen of him since his birth. She'd been allowed to hold him once, kiss him on his bright red hair, before he was torn away from her to be cared for by strangers.

As he got closer, her eyes welled up and the Emperor snapped his fingers. With this wordless order, the newly nameless clone once known as Theo, approached to dab at her eyes with a soft handkerchief.

"I trust my Emperess will keep her emotions in check during the broadcast?" The Emperor chuckled and reached for the tiny squirming Prince with his own hands. The baby stared at his Emperor with wide amber eyes, squirming in his soft white blanket. Entrapta took one step arms out to take him, but stopped as four of his eyes fixed on her.

"Oh, you won't be holding him," he said darkly, lowering his voice, "to introduce the new heir to the Galaxy is my duty."

Her heart sank like a stone and she dropped her arms in defeat. The Emperor didn't seem to notice, or if he did, he didn't care. His focus was entirely on the tiny squirming child in his arms, eyes glowing with pride and smile curled with glee.

"Come. It is time," he purred, leaning forward to give the child a light kiss to his fluffy red hair.

She was beautiful. Like the summer rain. Sadness in her eyes, in her smile. There wasn't a soul in the Galaxy that would notice, but him. He saw it. The way her gaze lingered on the tiny bundle as Emperor Prime spoke about the brilliant future of his Empire.

And the child, Hordak felt himself take a sharp breath when the video feed focused on the child's face. Large eyes, fluffy bright hair. He was perfect and although Prime held him tight and proud, it was clear his features favored his mother.

Hordak felt his heart both break and mend again in a matter of seconds. The emotional whiplash sent his senses reeling and he had to grip the workbench with a pincer grip to keep himself from falling to the floor.

His child? Perhaps. There was a hope there, a possibly. And yet, also a fear. As his mind struggled with the implications of fatherhood, the reality that he would never be a part of this child's life set in, like a stone sinking him to the depths of despair.

"With this new life, we celebrate the birth, not only of your new Prince, but the birth of our future," Horde Prime continued, holding the child up proudly, "A glorious, shining unity! A future where all beings, great and small, have a place and purpose!"

Entrapta smiled a plastic smile, a dolls smile, nothing more. But although her mouth imitated the emotion, her eyes remained glassy and unchanged. When her husband held a hand to her, she took it wordlessly, lovelessly.

And then the transmission ended and her hand was dropped.

"Escort the Emperess back to her quarters," her husbands cold voice ordered, passing the baby to a clone to her left. So close. So close she could almost touch a curl.

Another nameless clone bowed and offered an arm which she took without a word. She bowed to the Emperor once more before turning to leave.

"You did well today, Dear One."
His voice was soft, caring. She froze and turned her head to look at him over her shoulder, stunned. He hadn't called her that in months.
"Tonight, I will visit," he promised and a cold chill ran up her spine.
"With our son," he added, before walking away in the opposite direction.

And for the first time in so long, her smile finally reached her eyes.

Adora watched Hordak silently for a long time as he studied the frozen image of Entrapta. He had gone back after it was over, just to pause at that frame. She was looking dead ahead, smiling, her son visible just to her right.

After what felt like ages, he reached out with the tips of his sharp claws, gentle as if he could caress her face. His lips moved, silently taking the shape of her name.

Then he turned it off and passed it back to Adora.

"Give me another day," he said, fresh determination in his words, "She Ra will return to Etheria. But I request one thing, Adora."

The blonde put the device back in the confines of her jacket.

"What ever you need," she replied.

"When the time comes," he growled, examining his claws, "I will take the Emperors life."

Chapter End Notes

> Shorter chapter than usual. You'll have to forgive me. Life imploded, but I am doing better. I could have made this longer, but I liked the ending too much to let that go on. I promise an extra thicc boi next chapter. :3

Emerald

Chapter Summary

> Been a minute! Sorry for the late chapter! You would think that in these quarentimes, I would have more time than ever to write, but instead, I am busy af.
>
> I will try to have the next chapter up much sooner. Promise! <3

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Ajna had remained near Hordak the last few months. The others in this Etherian Rebellion were nice enough. But years as Primes spouse had made her reluctant to trust. Trusting too easy on The Velvet Glove could cost you dearly.
Not that she thought this crew of sparkly Queens and mermaid Princesses were quite as cutthroat as Primes Court.
Still, she had stayed alive this long by being cautious and Hordaks was a familiar face.

"Ajna," Hordak said from the work bench he was still hunched over, "tell me again what happens to the children of Prime."

Ajna rolled her eyes from where she sat in the corner of the tent, but she did not refuse him this distraction. He had to know. It soothed him, she assumed, to know his lover and possible child were in good hands.

"After a spouse gives birth, the child is frequently removed from their care. The spouse is often given extravagant gifts as a reward for their service," she explained, pulling her knees to her chest, "and the child is given to a trusted team of servants who will see to the child's every need. Entraptas child will be treated a little differently, however."

Hordak nodded slowly as he worked, and she noticed his grip suddenly tighten on his tool.

"Prime will be more involved," he guessed, and Ajna nodded.

"Correct. For his chosen heir, Prime will see to his education personally," she confirmed, "but he will be safe. The safest child in the Universe."

"And the hardest child to rescue," Hordak sighed. He set his tools down and rubbed his temples. "Is it hopeless?" He whispered.

"My sister used to say hope is useless without action," Ajna offered, rising from her place on the ground and stretching, "everything is hopeless until you give it hope."

Hordak turned slightly in his chair to look at her over his shoulder and she could see it clear as day. Tears sparkling in the corners of his eyes. She sighed and made her way over to place an awkward hand on his shoulder.

"You're worried about them," she murmured, "good. You should be. But she is alive and still his Emperess. While she holds that title, she will be untouchable. All she has to do now is keep her head down and do as she is told."

"That is what I am afraid of," he whispered, shrugging her hand away, "Entrapta is... not obedient by nature. Nor do I wish her to be. I..."

"I understand," Ajna said, backing away slightly as he turned back to his work, "you want her to still be herself next time you see her. Don't worry. From what I've seen, nothing is going to break that girl."

"Dear One, you have not touched your meal. Are you unwell?"

Entrapta stared ahead at the plate, hands folded neatly in her lap as her husband smiled at her over the long white table.

"I am not hungry," she slowly and softly replied, one finger extended to push the plate back. Sitting in a decorative array of exotic fruits, was a long bony finger of one of the clones. This one had been the one she had named "Bridget". She knew from the deep green color Entrapta had helped paint on their long talons.

"Such a shame," The Emperor sighed, rising to his feet, "you should really eat. After all..."
He closed in, soft footfalls sounding like execution drums to her. She kept staring ahead, face set and without expression, even as he placed a hand near her neck.
"Tonight," he whispered right against her ear, "you will need all the strength you can get."

Before Entrapta could get the words out, the instant her mouth opened, his hand grabbed a slice of olive colored fruit from her plate and shoved it between her lips. Salty. Metallic.

The taste of blood.

The fruit flew out of her mouth with a sob, tears spilling over onto her cheeks. Behind her, the Emperor softly clicked his tongue in disappointment.

"Manners, my Dear," he chastised, "I expect you to be on your best behavior when you meet my new spouse."

Spouse. New. The words hit her like a bomb. New victim. New pain. New... freedom? He would leave her alone now, wouldn't he?

"When is the wedding?" She asked automatically, staring straight ahead.

"Are you not jealous?" He asked teasingly, teeth a little too close to her ear for comfort. "In two weeks. I will trust you to show them the ropes."

Entrapta took a deep, careful breath. Her next words had to be chosen with great care.

"I will do anything you request, my Love," she replied, "so when do I meet them?"

The Emperor chuckled, pulling away slightly. Entrapta felt her shoulders relax some, until his hand curled around the back of her chair. With one sudden movement, he pulled the chair away from the table.
Strong. Sometimes she forgot how strong he was.

"When?" His lips curled into a playful grin. "Why, you've already met them."

The Emperess didn't have time to look properly confused before his claw shot out to yank her to her feet. Talons pressed into delicate flesh until she felt bruises pop up under her sleeves. She winced, but didn't fight it. There was no point in fighting it. Not now. Patience. Tallulah told her to be patient. In whispered conversation, snippets shared in passing, that was something she always said.

Be. Patient.

And she would. It wasn't what she was good at, but she would do it for Zed and Hordak and the Rebellion.
And for Etheria.

He led her out of the dining room, down the long corridors that Entrapta had memorized at last after almost a year, and when they stopped at last, it was in front of a door she had never noticed.

She looked up at her husband, eyebrows knitted together in curiosity. He let go of her arm and brought that hand up to press on the control panel and with a whish that she had grown accustomed to, the door slid aside.

The figure inside, for just a moment, was shapeless, black as the depths of space.

And then she was looking at her own face.

"Double Trouble," she guessed at once and the other her smiled her smile and tossed their purple hair, growing it at once to the impossibly long twin ponytails she had once been so proud of. Entrapta narrowed her eyes, but made no comment on it.

"Congratulations," she offered in a reluctant monotone.

At her side, the Emperor reached up to place a firm hand on her shoulder, inching dangerously close to her neck. A warning.

"I wish you all the happiness life has to offer," she said, this time sounding far more sincere. His grip loosened and Entrapta had to remind herself not to sigh in relief.

"You may go, Dear one," the Emperor dismissed, waving a silver tipped hand, "please make your way straight to your room. I will have you escorted to ensure you make no detours."

Entrapta expected as much. Face neutral, she dipped into a shallow bow and left her husband alone with the shape shifter. Two clones followed close to her side as she followed the familiar path back to her quarters.

As much as she had not expected Double Trouble to have wormed their way into the Emperors bed, Entrapta was not surprised in the least. Of course they would want to get in the good graces of the most powerful being in the Universe.
Still, Entrapta had a feeling that they would soon come to curse their own ambition.

As they reached the end of the hall, one of the clones raised their hand to open the doorway. Hints of green still clung to their remaining four claws. Entraptas eyes widened and she spoke before she could think.

"Bridget!"

The clone blinked at her with a mix of confusion and fear, pulling their damaged hand away as the door opened.

"Your Majesty, forgive me," he said, voice carefully controlled, "I have no name."

As she was gently guided into her chambers, she met the eye of the battered clone for a long time.

"Oh. O-of course..." she finally relented, drawing her gaze away at last as the door slid shut behind her, locking her inside with another nameless copy.

The Emperor waited just inside with his new lover. Double Trouble crossed the room the moment the door closed and they were alone. They purred and reached up to lace their arms around him, like ivy reaching for the sun.

The Emperor turned away before be could be touched, leaving his spouse-to-be with their arms outstreched, looking foolish. Cold. The atmosphere had gone from warm and loving to ice-cold indifference the instant Entrapta left.

"I will have details of the wedding sent to you directly," he coldly clarified, "a seamstress will be sent to your quarters this evening for your first fitting. Good day."

The door slid open, leaving a dumbstruck Double Trouble to watch as the Emperor left without another word.

She didn't care. Prime had waited , watched, hoped. But there was not a single hint of jealousy, not one trace of sadness. After all this time, after all they'd been through, her heart was the one thing of her that he did not possess.

At one time, he held hope. She had shown acceptance, even friendship to him, in a way. But before that friendship could turn to love...

Where did it go wrong? He asked himself as he approached his personal chambers. When did I lose her?

The answer was hard to settle on.

Another slave wearing his face pressed the panel on the wide wall, making the intricately decorated panel slide open. As he stepped inside, he held a hand up, stopping his attendant from entering. Without a moments hesitation, the clone bowed and stepped out, closing the panel behind him.

The instant he was alone, the Emperor snatched up a bottle of some deep Emerald colored liquid and poured himself a glass with shaking hands.

"She is mine," he mumbled as he clumsily set the crystal decanter back on the low stone table. "She is mine and he is gone. She will bend one day. She must. Etherians are... predictable."

But as he caught his reflection in his glass, he realized at once that more than anything, he was trying to convince himself.

An explosion of emerald green and glass crashed against the farthest wall. All six eyes snapped to his now empty hand. Growling with rage, he grabbed another empty glass and threw it full force as well, following by another and another. The crystal decanter followed the same fate.

Her.

The heavy stone table overturned with one swift movement.

Her eyes. Her hair-

With a snarl, he lifted one of the comfortable white chairs and hurled it across the room, snapping a leg off as it hit the floor.

Her heart. Her tears.
Her love.

Why? Why isn't any of it for me?

He snarled, stalking across the room to a full length mirror.
Six eyes stared back at him. Six perfect emeralds, glittering with a weakness reserved for these private moments.

"Why won't she love me?" He whispered to his reflection, "why am I... not good enough?"

Like a fountain, the water broke free, but his fist hit the mirror before his reflection could betray this weakness. A thousand shards of silvery glass clattered to the floor. His knees gave out and he fell with them, sinking to the crisp white tile, holding his hand as it bled freely onto its perfect surface.

Outside his chambers, two clones exchanged fearful looks as the uncontrolled sobs of their Emperor echoed from inside. Without a word exchanged, one of the clones left to secure the hallway so that nobody else would hear this that didn't have to.
For the sake of their Emperor, yes, but also for the sake of any soul unlucky enough to overhear.

Dhar lounged next to Tallulah in her clear, warm waters. There was a silence between the two that stretched out for light-years a tension that could be cut with a knife.

"I'm just going to say it," Tallulah sighed, lifting one tentacle heavily out of the water, "he's changed."

Dhar opened one emerald dusted eyelid to look at his best friend and sister-wife.

"You would know better than me," he shrugged, "you've known him much longer."

Tallulah closed her eyes and shook her head.

"Not long enough," she murmured, "not long enough to know how to fix him."

Dhar was now staring up at the high crystal ceiling and the expansive, colorful Galaxy beyond. It was true. Their husband was broken. Had been for some time, he supposed. How had none of them noticed until it was too late?

"She really did a number on him, didn't she?"

"No, don't blame her," Tallulah sighed, sinking lower into the water, "it was never her fault. She never asked for any of it."

"Did any of us?" Dhar shot back, "think back, Tally. Did you ask for this? Did I? Did Zallah? Did Ajna? Did... Aleiz?"

Tallulah whipped a tentacle up to cover his mouth, hastily glancing about. Once she seemed certain they were not being watched, she lowered it again, covered in Dhar's wild green lipstick.

"You have to be more careful!" She hissed, leaning in, "do you want to end up like Rawnie?"

Dhar felt his eyes go wide with fear and he shook his head, remembering another horrifying execution. Rawnie had already been on thin ice, but when a fan with the words "Paharna Forever" was found in her chambers during one of the Emperors new "inspections", there was no help for her. He offered her a "trial" of course and an "investigation", but that only helped to prove her guilt more. She had assisted in Ajna's escape.

Dhar could only watch as their husband's large claws closed around her thin throat and snapped it like a tree branch.

"We have to be more careful than ever," Tallulah warned, "but... Dhar. I have to know. If it comes down to it, if he can't get better-"

Dhar reached out to place an emerald painted finger to her lips to hush her.

"I am on your side, Tally," he whispered, "No matter what. Friends 'til the bitter end, right?"

Tallulah smiled weakly, wrapping a tentacle around his wrist.

"'Til the bitter end," she agreed, "and beyond."

Entrapta pressed her hand against the thick window, examining the endless glow of the Universe. It had been a view that had initially thrilled her, but now the endless black reminded her of what had been lost. The stars so distant, so small, reminded her that circling one of those tiny specks of light was a planet. An entire world. Home.

And somewhere on that world, she he waited, at least she hoped so. She would often pick a spot, unsure if he was there or if he had even lived long enough to make it back, and while she focused, she would talk as if he could hear her.

"It's been a while, Hordak," she whispered, leaning her forehead against the cold glass, "do you miss me? I miss you. I miss the others too. Scorpia, Adora, Bow... I think you'd like Bow."

She smiled, touching the spot where the star she had chosen for this particular conversation shone back.

"I can't take this much longer," she confessed, "Adora has the sword, right? You're coming for me, aren't you? He's getting worse. He-"

The door whooshed open and Entrapta shut her mouth very quickly, hoping that whoever it was, did not hear anything.

"Dear One?"

Her heart stuttered in her chest. She'd been hoping for anybody else in the entire Universe. As he came into view, she forced a smile onto her face.

"What are you doing, Dear One?"

"Waiting for you," she answered at once, rising to her feet and bowing automatically, robotic, stiff. Her face pulled into a painted smile, eyes glassy as a dolls. She hoped he did not see the cracks forming in her perfect porcelain persona.

His lips curled at the corner as he approached, reaching out to tilt her chin up to meet his many eyes.

"Cheer up, my little jewel," he purred, "I came to tell you the good news."

His smile unnerved her. Not in the usual 'I control your every move' way. This wad a smile of victory, complete and unchallenged.

"We will be taking a trip to Etheria," he whispered, leaning in close enough for her to feel the chill of his breath against her neck. "Aren't you excited to see your friends again?"

Entrapta jerked away from his grasp. A moment of foolish hope flashed across her face, joy in her very eyes before a chuckle from her husband dashed that dream before it had a chance to take flight.

"For the weapon," she guessed, crossing her arms, nails digging lightly into the thin fabric of her nightgown.

"Ah, yes. How could I forget?" He chuckled, slowly circling her like a vulture, "you are not as stupid as the others from your little world."

Entrapta didn't have time to feel offended. Her mind raced with ideas. Possibilities. She had to get a message somehow to Etheria. She had to contact Hordak, Adora. Anyone. She-

"You will invite your Princesses to a ball. All of them."

Magenta eyes turned into slits, watching her husband suspiciously as he stalked around her.

"A ball?" She questioned, "for your wedding?"

The Emperor stopped, appearing confused for a moment, as if his upcoming wedding had entirely slipped his mind. Then his face cracked into a sharp green smile and he closed the distance between them.

"Why, to celebrate the birth of my heir, of course," he purred, tracing a claw along her waist, "and to honor my Emperess. After all..."

He bent to her height, face less than an inch from hers. She could feel his cool minty breath on her lips, and his intentions were made immediately clear.

"It will have been one standard Etherian year since our marriage, Dear One," he whispered, pulling her body flush with his. "How time does fly."

Chapter End Notes

> YOOOO!!!!!! CHECK OUT THIS ART FROM @Lilyponyart1 on Twitter. <3
>
> I'm so happy! Go give them a follow! Their art is spectacular!
>
> https://twitter.com/lilyPonyArt1/status/1333281726056067075?s=20

Ruby

Chapter Notes

> Okay. So it's been a minute. I have no other excuse besides being busy and distracted.
>
> Also just kinda brain dead.
>
> But we are approaching the end. I promised I would finish this, and I like to keep my promises. I just want to be sure its a satisfying ending more than anything.

Late. At this time of night, Entrapta should have been asleep. Should have been dreaming of places far away from here. People a thousand light-years away.

Should be. Couldn't. How could she sleep with him pressed against her. His cold, minty breath sighing in her ear, claws that dug new bruises into her hips.

The bruises. Her entire body up and down felt like a bruise. His teasing threat had been a valid warning. He had used her thoroughly before curling against her and drfting off to a deep slumber.

Entrapta watched his sleeping form carefully, counting the length of each breath, watching his many eyes move under perfectly formed eyelids. Dreaming, she realized. He was dreaming.

For an entire year she had spent with him, she had not once considered that he might do something as mundane as dream. What would an Emperor dream of, anyway? She wanted to wake him and ask. For science.

Instead, she carefully lifted his heavy arm so she could slip out of bed. He stirred only once, then went silent again. In the darkness, she stood beside the bed, counting the length of his breath once

more until she was quite certain he was fast asleep. She bent down to pick up her robe and cover her nude form. As she turned towards the door, the faint green glow of two clone eyes nearly made her heart stop.

The attendant. Of course. How could she forget? He made a clone watch. It... excited him. And it assured that she would not make a move to escape him.

Just as she was doing now.

"I... need to pee?" She whispered as an excuse, and the clone simply closed his eyes in acknowledgment. Odd, but she did not question it.

Quiet as the vacuum of space, she tiptoed out of her bedchambers, realizing only when the door had whooshed open that the clone had followed.

"Need to pee?" The clone sneered the instant the door had shut behind them, "what kind of excuse was that?"

Entrapta blinked at the clone, confused by his strange manner. She watched the clone closely, eyes narrowed. One hand on his hip, examining his claws...

"Double Trouble," Entrapta sighed, visibly relaxing, "I thought-"

"Puh-lease," they snorted, "if I were one of them, you would never have left that room. You know they blame you, right?"

Entrapta blinked up at the sharp green grin towering above her. Still maintaining the clone form. She supposed it made sense. If she got caught out here, she could at least say she had an escort.

"I... I know," she whispered, moving to a window near the end of the hall, "I didn't know he... Why are you here?"

Entrapta quickly looked the shape-shifter up and down. It made no sense. Double Trouble always wanted something. What was it?

"I had to see what he did to you," they confessed, moving to stare out the window next to her, "we're both trapped now, but I don't have to be miserable like you. I can have everything I didn't have on Etheria and more."

"He isn't gentle," Entrapta warned, carefully rubbing her bruised arm, "you might regret you decision."

Out of the corner of their eye, Double Trouble watched her. They took note of her pain, her aches. They had watched the whole thing, after all.

"You know," Double Trouble murmured, "you really are a pretty good actress. You almost had me fooled. You know how to play the dutiful wife, but I know the truth. Your heart is back home on Etheria, with him. Even after all this time."

Entrapta said nothing. What could she say? It was the truth. Was always the truth. Would *always* be the truth.

"Well, you should be careful, Your Majesty. If I'm not fooled, he certainly isn't either."

"I know," Entrapta snapped, "how am I supposed to play nice when every other night is-"

Double Trouble placed a talon to her lips to silence her, shaking their head.

"We all have our parts to play," they gently reminded her, "the key to acting, is not to convince your audience, but to convince *yourself*."

Entrapta blinked as they dropped their finger from her lips, smiling down at her.

"Why are you helping me?" She asked, lowering her voice, "what do you want?"

"Oh, I'm just here to put on a good show, Darling," they snickered, then they turned to face the window. Entrapta followed their gaze, noting how their smile fell away.

Outside, the remains of another fleet drifted a good distance away. Another conquest. They were both getting used to this, seeing dead bodies floating in their wake. The Emperors armada swarmed like a buzzing hive of angry hornets

"Every leading act..." Double Trouble continued, "needs a stage hand, after all."

Terr stood at the side of her new brothers cradle. He was small. So much smaller than she had expected. We're babies always this tiny?

For the longest time, she had been the youngest child. A part of her had wondered if Father would forget her now. But the last time he had seen her, he had scooped her up in his arms and talked. Just talked. He liked to chat about mundane things.

She smiled at the sleeping baby and slipped out of the room. The children's corridor was long, winding. And entirely off-limits to almost everyone.

Except her personal clone companion, affectionately named Kusi. She'd colored stars on his face, and he silently put up with it.

"Little Princess," the clone mumbled as she reached up for his hand, "First Princess Beck is here."

The tiny girl raised her furry head, meeting the emerald eyes of the Emperors daughter and personal secretary. As always, she was dressed in a clean pressed uniform, pale hair falling in thick curls to her neck. Her face was so similar to their fathers, but

softer, gentler. She was smiling, tapping the little beauty mark on her chin.

"So, this is where you are, little sister," she chimed, "Queen Zallah was looking for you."

Terr smiled back, wagging her long tail. Beck was nice... mostly. She was patient and gentle and Father relied on her. But there were times, not often, but now and again she got angry. And it was terrifying.

"Oh. Should I-?"

"I told her you were busy," Beck shrugged, leaning in as if she were sharing a secret. "That woman wants to think she's the empress. She can't boss you around though. She is replaceable. *You* are not. Remember that, little sister."

Terr grinned and reached up to take her older sisters hand. She was always looking out for her. All of them. She had a pretty face, but she was not one to be trifled with. She ranked above the Emperors wives.

Except the Emperess. And that was fine. She knew she had more power when it *really* mattered.

"Come. I have some business to see to on the bridge. Would you like to help me?"

Terr nodded excitedly, swinging between her attendant and her sister.

"The battle will be wrapping up soon. Have you ever watched the victory celebration? Its spectacular."

The Emperor stared down at four aliens. Three males and one female. Two high ranking generals and the King of their recently

conquered world. Outside the ship, remnants of their defeated armada floated along like dust in the wind.

Entrapta stood at her husband's side, one hand resting on his armrest. She had grown used to this. He always took the highest ranking official on the world along with two generals. It was a formality, a show of power. How they handled themselves in the throne room would determine the fate of their planet.

"A valiant effort," the Emperor commended, "your world will be a jewel in the crown of my Empire. Rest assured, your people will be safe and treated with the utmost respect. I only need you to swear your loyalty to me now."

Across the Universe, this moment was being broadcast. It was always a special. They would either have a celebration, or a public execution. Either way, his message came across.

Wordlessly, the king stepped forward and fell to one knee. A wise decision, in Entraptas opinion. She hated the executions.

"Sar'dna is yours, my Emperor." His voice was soft, but loud enough to be heard. His young face contorted in something like pain, but he held his posture until the Emperors silver claw beckoned him to rise again.

"Princess Beck," Prime called suddenly, "come to me."

In seconds, she was at his side, a tablet at the ready to take notes for him.

"Sweet Stardust," he purred, placing a gentle claw to her face, "I've decided it is time for you to marry."

Entrapta went tense. Beck was at his side always. His most trusted assistant. It was true he would often marry off his children to Kings and Queens of conquered worlds. It was a way to guarantee a smooth transition of power. But she never thought she would see Beck go.

"I..." her eyes stayed strong, firm, but Entrapta saw the pain. Of course she didn't want to leave. To step away from her position was a downgrade. She was the third most powerful individual on this ship.
"I will do as you say, My Emperor."

"Good girl," he whispered, reaching up to take her pretty face in his claw, "don't be sad, Stardust. You are still one of my heirs. After Prince Zed, you are next in line. Do your duty well and we will meet again soon. I promise you."

She did not react outwardly. Her self control was incredible. The way she nodded in response and even offered a sweep smile, it was no wonder the Emperor had kept her near for so long.

He let go of her face and held a hand out to the King at the bottom of his throne.

"My daughter will be your Queen," he announced, "congratulations to you and your world."

Entrapta watched their eyes meet, saw the mix of disgust and fear. This would not be a happy partnership. Even with Entraptas limited understanding of people, she could see that.

The King bowed, shallow, stiff.
"I look forward to a life of happiness," he said, rather unconvincingly.

"Wonderful! The marriage will take place this evening!" The Emperor laughed. "Dismissed."

The other male, the general watched in horror as the Princess decended the stairs and raised a hand for the King to kiss. And Entrapta knew that look as well. It was the same way her eyes had ached, watching Hordak leave with Ajna. Longing, love, loss.

He was watching his lover dutifully promise himself to another, just as Entrapta had done.

The King did not look at him, but his lip trembled, and if Entrapta had not been looking for it, she would not have seen the glimmer of tears clinging to his pale lashes.

"He is losing his mind," Dhar hissed to Tallulah as they made their way through the long corridors after the wedding of Princess Beck to King Zeik. They had learned the Kings name the same moment Beck had. It wasn't uncommon to marry a monarch you barely knew, but it was uncommon to marry them the same day.

The ceremony had been very quick, uninteresting, with little pomp. Beck didn't even have anything appropriate to wear for her own wedding and she was married still wearing her slick gray uniform with a few jewels hastily tucked in her curls.

"Keep your voice low, Dhar," Tallulah hissed, "but that *was* unexpected, even for him. Who is going to keep track of his affairs now? He relied on Beck so much."

"He isn't thinking anything through," he sighed, "Tally. We have to start thinking about our plan."

The larger woman stopped, glanced around to be sure they were alone, then grabbed Dhar by his vest collar and shoved him against the wall.

"We do not discuss that here!" She snarled, "idiot! You want to get us killed?"

"Sorry! It's just... Tally. I'm *scared*, alright? Ever since... well nothing has been normal since *that* happened."

She swallowed hard and let him go. She knew what he meant. When Aleiz died. It had sent their husband spiraling. Betrayal in the Empire was not unheard of, but in all his thousands of years, no spouse had ever betrayed him. To his knowledge, in any case.

"Do you still know how to contact Ajna?" She whispered, quiet as a breeze on the wind.

She didn't miss the way his eyes lit up.

The rebellion was growing in strength the longer Primes forces remained on Etheria. That was just the way of the people there. They had resisted Hordaks horde for years. On a galactic scale, it was just a matter of upping their game. Hordak and Ajna had worked together to spread the word to pockets of rebellion on other worlds and the cause was gaining motion quickly.

She Ra swung the sword in a wide arc, devastating a dozen bots on the battlefield with ease. With the Emperor approaching, his forces has increased here and the nearby worlds. Time was running out. They all knew it.

None of them were stupid enough to think he was really coming just to get married.

At her side, Catra panted, holding her side. She'd been shot earlier, but she remained on her feet. She would always stay standing as long as Adora stayed with her. She'd push through this. She'd push through *anything*.

She had to. They would have the future they discussed. They would have that quiet life together with their friends. She would turn the universe on its head to make it happen.

"H-hey Adora," she panted, flashing sharp teeth, "you wanna get married?"

The blonde grinned back, and in answer, she grabbed her hand, holding the sword out in front of her.

"Do you?" she teased as Catra placed her hand on the sword hilt over hers.

"Maybe," Catra laughed, only wincing a little bit as blood gushed through her claws from the effort. "It's not like I like you, or anything."

Adora chuckled, pulling her close as she began to raise the sword with Catra. The couple began to glow, a warm light, gold like the first rays of dawn.

"Together?"

Catra raised the clasped hand to her lips.

"Together."

"It is time, Queen Glimmer," Ajna announced, standing at the meeting table, "I've received communication from two of the Emperors spouses. He is weak and vulnerable. Within fourty two hours, he will have landed on Etheria and we will finally have our opportunity."

The sparkly Queen regarded her with a small smile.
"How do you know we can trust them?"

"Tallulah and Dhar were the ones who helped me escape. They have been assisting the rebellion from afar for years."

Hordak looked up from the screen he was studying, leveling the Queen with a gentle nod.

"She is correct. Our contacts in the Drez'yn system confirmed this."

Drez'yn had been one of the many places in the Galaxy to have run the Empire off lately. Victory was beginning to become a word on everyone's lips.

"Alright," Glimmer relented, "then let's discuss the plan again."

For an hour, the meeting went on and Hordak contributed with a bite to every word, sharp and precise. Neither Glimmer nor Ajna failed to notice this and when the meeting ended, he was asked to stay.

"I do have other work to do, Your Majesties," he muttered, still staring at the tablet in his claws, "if possible, can we make this brief."

"Hordak, we need to talk." Glimmer folded her hands on the table.

"When this is all done, Your Majesty," Hordak sighed, finally looking up to meet her unwavering gaze, "you may do what you like with me. Public execution, torture, imprisonment. I am not hoping for forgiveness and I am not expecting mercy."

The two women exchanged a look of surprise, but allowed him to continue.

"I'm doing this for her," he muttered, "when she is safe and free, then I will be content enough to die."

"Hordak," Glimmer sighed, rubbing her temples, "are you always this dramatic? I'm granting you a pardon. I've discussed it with the rest of the council already. You'll have to leave the Fright Zone, naturally, since that land rightfully belongs to Scorpia."

The clone stared at the Queen with eyes almost comically large. Mutely, he nodded. This was unexpected. He didn't know where he would go after, assuming he survived, but he would have a lifetime to figure it out.

"We wanted to talk to you about the plan," Ajna said, folding her hands, "you said before that you wanted to be the one to kill him."

"Yes. That is non-negotiable," he stated.

"I see... we can work with that," Glimmer agreed, "however, you're not doing it alone."

Hordak narrowed his eyes.

"Explain."

The blade was plain, gleaming, with ruby red crystal on its hilt. A small, ceremonial thing from a conquered world. A trophy. Prime frequently took them for his collection.

Would he miss this one?

The blade was lifted to painted lips in a delicate kiss before being hidden once again in a sleeve.

"Dear One? Come along."

Entrapta turned to her husband with a painted smile.

"Yes, my Love."

Inside her sleeve, her hand curled reassuringly around that ruby hilt.

Red truly was a warmer color than green.

Jade

She was air. She was water. She was stars and light and pure cosmic bliss. She was life itself.

Anillis was in love. Desperately, fully in love. Waves of violet cascaded down her back like a river. He wanted to fall into that stream of amethyst and drown. He wanted to find eternity in the scent of her.

"Anillis?"

She was watching him now, a ghost of a smirk and a glint in her deep jade eyes. Endless, a nebula of green. He wanted to explore them forever.

"You were staring again," she reminded him, a twinkling of amusement in her tone.

Her face could build an army, summon an armada. Establish an Empire. Turn the Universe on its head.

And it had. Anillis had done all that and more for her sake. He would have done *anything* to make her his. But in the end, all he'd had to do was simply ask.

"You are the dearest one to me," he whispered, stunned as he was every moment of every day that she was truly his. He raised a claw, touching her petal soft cheek with the back of his hand. He worshipped her.

"Starlight," she giggled, leaning into his touch, "you are *mine*."

Yes. He was hers. Everyone knew their Empress was the one who truly pulled the strings. He was her puppet and he gladly danced for her amusement.

They turned back to the window on the ships bridge and she leaned into his much larger frame. A world cracked apart in front

of them, broken like a geode. The couple smiled in triumphant bliss.

"Congratulations, My Love," the beauty at his side purred, "you have just brought order to this Quadrant."

"*We*," he corrected, smiling down at her with pride. The corners of his two bright eyes crinkled at the corners. "It was your brilliant leadership that accomplished this."

"Oh, but it was *your* invention that dealt the final blow," she laughed, nuzzling his chest. "I couldn't have done this without you."

Anillis pulled away and fell to one knee, holding her hand and bowing his head. Above him, his Empress towered, chin raised, smile pulling those perfect lips upwards. Green jewels sparkled at her throat, the color of her eyes. Her symbol and now the symbol of an Empire.

"I will serve you until my final breath," he vowed, pressing a kiss to her smooth hand, "I will make your dreams a reality. I will see your vision through to the end. I swear it."

Her eyes glinted in the light of another explosion before them in the distance. The silent ending of another disorderly world.

"They will thank us one day," she promised, placing her other hand around his and kneeling as well. "We are doing what is best for them. One day, we will be worshipped as heroes for bringing peace and order."

Anillis lost himself in her eyes, pupils black as the endless expanse of space. And he believed her words, her promise. And she believed his.

Cold. Space was cold, no matter how you tried to adjust. No amount of rare furs and dense fabric would fix it. And for more

than a year now, Entrapta had tried her best to adapt, to let the cold seep into her bones and freeze her alive. To become a living ice sculpture, pretty and unfeeling.

And yet, when the shuttle made it's decent, Entrapta knew she had failed in that. The heat was overwhelming. What little ice she had managed to hang onto, what cold armor she had built up, melted away as Etheria grew closer.

Home.

She stood close to the Emperor, letting him hold one hand while her other hand reassuringly checked the knife tucked into her sleeve.

"Dear One, I do believe your little friends will be overwhelmed with how lovely you've grown."

She caught her reflection in the glass. Dead eyes, sunken cheeks, boney frame. A far cry from when she was, well, *happy*. She hadn't been allowed sweets since the doomberry incident. Meals were denied when her Emperor imagined some slight, or if he thought she had gained too much weight. After the birth of her son, preparing her for the next pregnancy had been his highest priority and he decided that a thinner bride would bear superior children.

Entrapta did not care enough to correct him. She had no intention of giving him what he wanted any more.

"My Love," she muttered in response. "I've heard rumors of a Rebellion. Is Etheria in rebellion also?"

Three of his six eyes snapped to her and she knew he was frowning, disapproving.

"Where did you hear such nonsense?" He snapped, "I am the Supreme Emperor of all. They wouldn't dare."

She looked back at him, eyes unwavering, steel and cold like the knife she planned to shove in one of those hideous eyes. Her face broke into a smile. She couldn't help it. She was smug. Defiant.

"What are you smiling about?" He growled, squeezing her hand until she gasped and hunched over in pain.

"Nothing, my *Love*," she muttered, lowering her head again, "apologies."

He loosened his grip and her smirk faded, but nothing was going to stomp out the spark in her eye. She stared ahead as her home came closer, eyes shining for the first time in such a long time, bright and full of so much life.

"You've never looked more perfect."

Anillis ran a claw through her flawless violet strands. Beside him in bed, she breathed a laugh like the twinkling of stars.

"You flatter me."

"No." He rolled over on top of her, lips ghosting over hers. "I *worship* you."

The reception was different this time. A very strange feeling hung in the air. The crowd did not cheer, not that anyone expected them to. But the silence wasn't just an absence of noise.

This was an intentional silence. Purposeful. This was the vacuume of space, empty and devoid. Each set of eyes lacked even hate.

Horde Prime did not know what their gaze meant. Entrapta, for once, did.

She walked arm in arm with her husband, watching the gathered crowd out of the corner of her eye. They passed a hooded figure, taller than most others, thin. And so very familiar. A glint of violet was all she needed to see.

Her eyes remained trained ahead, never straying. She had long ago learned to use her peripheral vision, relying on that to help her gather information without suspicion. Tallulah had taught her well over the course of the last year.

"She was there. Did you see?"

Ajna paced around their base, frantic.

"Or course I saw." His voice was low, but the smile in his tone was everything. "She is surviving."

"Did he notice you?" She asked, suddenly alert

"No. But *she* did. I know she did."

"Good. I made sure Dhar and Tallulah know the plan. They must have passed it along to her by now. Everything is in order..."

"If everything is in order," Glimmer asked, stepping into view, "why are you freaking out."

Hordak rose from his work bench and gave a stiff bow before returning to his task.

"She's worried that it's too soon," Hordak answered, fiddling with a new weapon he'd been perfecting. A new arm canon. Smaller, more compact.

"*Is* it too soon?" Glimmer brought her eyes back to Hordak again, biting worriedly at her lip. "Are we rushing things?"

"You majesty," he sighed, "with respect, it is now or never. He will likely never visit Etheria again. Ready or not, it is time."

"If we fail, we're dead," Queen Glimmer noted evenly, "but if we don't try, we might as well be dead."

"Exactly," Hordak agreed, raising his now finished weapon with a smirk. "Personally, I'd rather die trying than live afraid."

Ajna met his eye. Over the last several months, they'd grown close. Friends, like siblings. Much of their trauma was shared, similar experiences and similar losses. There was a trust. Slowly, Ajna nodded.

"Alright. Let's kill this bastard."

"Your Majesty! You must get to safety!"

Anillis roared and struggled against the arms holding him back. The ship was burning around them. The attack came out of nowhere. At the very last instant, Anillis had been thrown back, out of the blast. But by who or what, he couldn't say.

"She's still-! I have to-!"

"She's gone, Your Majesty. Please. You have to get to safety!"

He tore from the arms of the General who had helped him survive the explosion and ran into the flames without a moments thought.

The remains of the cockpit fell around him, the heat enough to bubble flesh. And in the center of it all, he found her, burned beyond recognition, but breathing. Debris hit one of his eyes, but he hardly noticed the damage to his vision. He didn't notice the heat. It was only her and if she didn't make it out, he didn't want to either.

"You... promised," she choked out as he pulled her to his chest. "You would see... my vision through. You promised. *Go.*"

Anillis breathed out a strangled sob, clutching her tighter as the flames rose around them.

"Please-!" He begged.

"Anillis. Do not... fail me," she whispered, "We... will meet again. One day."

Her body went limp and she let out a single, final breath.

Entrapta sat alone in a room she vaguely remembered from her wedding night. As the Empress, she was entitled to the best room in the castle, regardless of who the bride was this time. The setback was, she was meant to share it with the Emperor.

She was just glad he was out preparing for his wedding. It gave her time. Time for what? She couldn't say. Time to mentally prepare herself, she supposed. Time to taste freedom again.

She stood near a large window overlooking the whispering woods, remembering what had been, honestly, the worst night if her life. It had happened in this very room. It was the day she stopped being Entrapta. The day she had to learn to die a little just to keep going. Sometimes she could still feel old bruises.

Her fingers ran over the blade, knowing it was a silly thing. Thinking for an instant that this would do it. Of course it wouldn't. She wasn't strong enough to kill him with a decorative little blade.

Not alone, anyway. Tallulah told her the plan. After the wedding tomorrow, he would come here. When he was done with his new spouse, he would return to her side.

It would be the last time he would be allowed to touch her.

She took a deep, shuddering breath, hiding the knife again as her assigned Companion came back in the room.

"His Majesty is returning," he informed her, and Entrapta waved him away, unconcerned.

Let him come. Let him do as he wished tonight. Tomorrow he would be gone, or she would be. She refused to live like this anymore.

"You're Majesty?"

"Couldn't you go away?" She snapped, glancing over her shoulder, "I am so tired of-"

Violet.

The hooded clone looked up at her, smiling, eyes sparkling with tears. He wore the uniform of the other clone companions, but his cape was gathered in front of him and around his neck hung a familiar violet crystal.

"I'm tired too," he whispered, stepping closer. "I'm tired of missing you. I'm tired of seeing your face everywhere. I'm tired of seeing you look so empty."

"Hordak..." she breathed, frozen in place by the window.

"I'm tired waiting and wishing. Entrapta. I'm tired of regrets."

Her eyes overflowed. He stood less than a foot away. So close.

"Come with me," he whispered, grabbing her hand. "I can get you out. Tonight. The attack is underway. In an hour, it will begin. Come, before he returns."

Her crimson gaze studied him, memorizing every inch. She wanted so badly everything he had to offer. She wanted to run away. She wanted to be with him. She wanted... him.

But she couldn't. Not yet.

She pulled her hand away and turned back towards the window again. Turned her back to his offer. Turned her back on him.

"I can't," she whispered. "My son. If I run away and this fails, I will have abandoned him. I have to stay. I have to watch him die. I have to be sure. I can't just run away and hope anymore."

Hordak stood with his hand still outstretched, but his face didn't betray his pain. She was right. She frequently was.

"I understand," he sighed, finally lowering his hand. He tucked the crystal back under his uniform, and turned away from her as well. "I love you. More now today than I ever have."

Her lips twitched into an approximation of a smile. It felt strange to genuinely smile. Joy was rare, as infrequent as a supernova. But it was there. In her cold, hard heart, love still beat in her veins.

She caught her reflection in the window. Her hair was unrecognizable, and her face was gaunt and covered in dark makeup. She felt like she wore a mask. But in her eyes, she found it. A spark of the woman she once was.

Despite everything, she was still herself.

"Tell me that when you see what I've become in the morning."

She'd hardly finished speaking when the door was opened by a clone and the Emperor strode inside. Her movements were automatic, robotic as she dipped into a perfect, well rehersed bow and strode to his side.

"Dear one," he purred, pressing the back of his clawed hand to her cheek. "I am sorry to have to leave you for so long. Did you miss me terribly?"

"Of course." The lie slipped off her tongue as easily as breathing. Her face didn't betray even a hint of danger. Her eyes were impassive, blank, dead.

"Good girl," his soft, lilting voice made Hordak want to scream. His claw ran down her face to her neck and gently closed around her throat. Still, Entrapta did not move. She didn't even react. "I have had quite a day, my Dear One. You will help relieve me of my stress, yes?"

Without awaiting an answer, he threw her onto the bed. Her back hit the mattress with a soft thud and she lay still like a corpse, half lidded eyes staring at the ceiling, emotionless. She reminded Hordak of a doll.

As he climbed up her small body, she made a little hum of anticipation and Hordak had never seen anyone so indifferent to abuse in his entire existence. His teeth scraped against the white scar at her neck and for a moment, her eyes met his again.

The spark. It was alive and well behind layers of trauma, behind walls and walls and walls of trained inattention. Behind a careful neutrality.

The change in plans was immediate. A silent agreement between the two. The timing was too good. It truly was now or never.

The Emperor pulled away for only an instant, but it was long enough to expose the soft flesh at his throat. Hordak dropped the cloak, raised his canon-

But it was Entrapta that struck first.

Amethyst

Chapter Summary

The history of our icky Emperor and his final moments.

Not the very last chapter, but getting close.

Chapter Notes

Hi. It's been a minute. Sorry. Anyway, here you go.

Analiss stood above a great assembly. The white tower he stood at the top of hung high over the entire Universe. Trillions of eyes on him as he gave a speech about unity and prosperity. He promised peace, order and love. In flowing robes of silver and citrine, he was a God.

He raised his hands out to his people, swearing his eternal service.

From behind him, his wife stepped forward. Long hair the color of Eternian sunsets, pink and straight, sweeping the ornate pearlescent tile. Her eyes, black and shimmering, studied their Empire. It had been one built of love and perseverance. A bright and noble aspiration. Their teamwork was impeccable and their adoration, unshakable. Decades of bloody war, revolution, freeing slaves and bringing justice to unjust systems, and now they were here at the end.

Just in time for a brand new beginning.

Her small hand clasped his and she smiled like the Heavens. Green painted lips pressed into the back of his hand and he turned to face her, running his other claw gently through dazzling hair.

"This is the happiest moment of my life," he realized.

"This is only the start," she promised, brilliant voice ringing out like bells. "Your beautiful dream will spread joy everywhere the light touches."

"I couldn't have done this without out," he whispered, leaning forward to press the citrine jewel adoring his forehead to the matching stone she wore.

"No," she agreed with a huff of laughter, "but it was your idea."

The Emperor laughed softly at that, snorting lightly in a way that his life companion had always found endlessly endearing.

"One day," she whispered, holding his hands close to her heart, "Maybe not one day soon, but one day, you will complete what we have started and you and I will walk away from this all, hand in hand. One day, we will rest in peace together."

Their lips met for the briefest instant before the Empress pulled away suddenly. With a mysterious grin, she began to lead him back inside.

"Come, Starlight," she called, "the time for rest will come one day, but now you and I have much work to be done and many heirs to make."

The Emperess sat at the control tower of The Velvet Glove, grinning to herself as she admired her own hard work. This was a vessel fit for an Emperor. This would be the perfect home, the perfect base. The work would be done one day, she knew in her heart, but until that time, she would design her instruments and ships and technologies. She would build an empire with her mind and heart.

"So this is it?"

The voice of her husband made the Emperess jump.

"This is it," she sighed, slouching almost childishly in the large throne, "my greatest work. There won't be a rebel armada alive that will stand a chance."

The Emperor nodded slowly, gazing at the hologram of the known universe stretched out before them.

"I do not like war," he admitted softly, "I know it is a necessity for the moment, but I- I sometimes imagine the lives I've taken and-
"

"Shh, Starlight," she rose to her feet and reached for his claw, offering a gentle smile. "You have a good heart."

"And it belongs only to you," he purred, lifting her small hand to his lips.

"Not only to me," she whispered, pulling his hand back to herself, "you will have to share your love with someone else one day soon."

His hand came to rest against his wife's stomach and his mind moved at a mile a minute. His next words came out like a fragile blossom, blooming and fading and falling.

"Are you-?"

"Mmm," she hummed with a gentle smile, "only a few weeks, but your medical staff seems confident."

Eyes like the Universe itself glittered and glowed and now that he looked at her, he could see it. He'd always known he would want a family with this woman. He'd always thought it inevitable, just as their victory was inevitable. But that had always been for the future.

The future, it appeared, was already here.

He swept her up in his arms, laughing like a child, twirling around his throne. In all his hundreds of years, this was a joy like no

other.

And then it was taken. He held the hand of his Emperess tight, kissed her cold hands. She shivered, pale, broken. He wanted to kiss the pain away. They had done all they could already to save the baby, but miracles were for the weak, and his Empress, his love, she was anything but weak.
And he had to be strong, he had to hold it together for the both of them.

But he knew nothing would be the same again. Come tomorrow, they would be alone, surrounded only by pale, meaningless versions of himself. Worthless, living lives that were empty because they had not known what it meant to feel his Emperesses love.

"Starlight," came the choked gasp from his precious gem, "I'm sorry. The baby, I-"

"Hush," he whispered and pressed his lips to her forehead, "it's not your fault."

"They say I can't- that my body won't-"

"I know," he whispered, "We can worry about an heir later. For now, rest."

"Analiss." Her hand clutched his. "You have to take another wife."

"Nonsense," he laughed, "why would I need another when I have you?"

"Ana-"

"Enough. Rest. We can talk more later."

Tallulah was stunning. He'd known her for ages, of course. Their friendship was an old one. During his first travels when he was still practically a child, he had met her. And he trusted her more than anyone now.

"Are you certain?" She asked, touching a tentacle to his sharp face. "You are still mourning. Take some time, Analiss. Let yourself miss her."

"Before she died, she told me to see her vision through," he murmured, watching the inky black water around his waist. "I will not fail her, but I can not do this alone. I need you, Tallulah."

The woman sighed heavily and closed the distance, tentacles slithering to embrace the most powerful man in the Universe.

"Very well," she agreed, "but you can't expect me to do all the work."

Queen Zallah was radiant. Tallulah had been the one to tell him about her.

"She conquered ten kingdoms on her own and united the entire solar system in less than two solar rotations," she'd whispered into his ear, "she would be a perfect second wife."

"And is she-"

"Beautiful?" Tallulah laughed. "Well, let's just say, I wouldn't say no to her myself."

And she was beautiful. The Emperor had to admit, he had never before witnessed a being so extravagant. She sat, perched on a peacock blue lounge, golden gown hanging off in fine rippling layers, thin, nearly transparent. Jewels in a rainbow of colors dotted her shining golden skin.

And Analiss offered a priceless citrus-green jewel.

"So, here I was expecting an invasion and instead I am offered a marriage?" Her voice was like Velvet, smooth and rich. Amusement positively dripped from every word.

"It is your choice," he chuckled, "but I do ask you to consider carefully, your maj-"

"I accept, of course," she smoothly interjected, rising to her feet, "on the condition that you never make the mistake of thinking me just a womb. I assure you, my dear Emperor, I am so very much more."

Rawnie came next. The daughter of a wealthy Emperor, she was the prize when his army tore through their Empire. She wed Analiss in the very same throne room she discovered her Father's body in.

Scolopendra approached Analiss herself. Her family had intentions of opposing the Emperor, of marrying her off to unite against him in rebellion. Scolopendra did not see the wisdom in that and took matters in her own hand.

She spent her wedding night, listening to the screams of her family as they were executed one by one. A small price to pay for the survival of her people.

Dhar was another discovery by Tallulah. The handsome Prince of a rich desert planer, known for it's beautiful dancers and artisans.

Analiss did not threaten his world, not exactly. He had simply been curious to meet this handsome man Tallulah had spoken of. Dhar was the one who invited him to bed.

He had stretched himself over silk sheets and dozens of decorative cusions. His gossamer garments hiding nothing, painted lips smirking, daring him to refuse.

They were married the next day. Analiss couldn't say no to the night he'd just had.

Over the centuries, he gathered a harem of beautiful spouses, but it was the birth of his first child, a girl, that was the pinnacle of his empire.

When Zallah had announced her pregnancy, Analiss couldn't help but fear. He ordered bedrest, the finest doctors to monitor her day in and day out, only the best food. But Queen Zallah was strong. She gave birth to a perfect girl and the Emperor was absolutely beside himself with joy.

In fact, over the years, he rarely let the girl out of his sight. Beck was his right hand, involved in everything. The Universe at large had assumed she would be his heir, but as more children came and went and he made no such announcement, the rumors died off and first Princess Beck remained just that.

The First Princess.

The Twins Aleiz and Ajna were hard won prizes. Their father had resisted until the very end, until he was held aloft by the throat, croaking curses at the Emperor. It was Ajna, a young thing, barely not a child that had offered herself in order to spare her world.

He dropped her Father's corpse at her feet, twitching and bleeding out. Even as his blood soaked the hem of her gown, she did not flinch. Analiss lowered a claw to tilt her chin up, studying her large eyes, young face.

"You are still a child," he sighed, "not ripe or ready."

"Not yet, perhaps," she stubbornly said, meeting his eyes, "but I will be. If you spare my people, I will be yours."

"Brave," he snorted, "but suppose I decided to take you now?"

"Then I don't suppose I would be able to stop you," she said.

"Don't!" Aleiz cried out, "please! You can't do this! Don't take my sister!"

"Twins?" The Emperor looked from sister to sister, smile curling. "I've never had twins before. Very well. I will not separate you. You shall both be mine."

He married them the next year and they spent their wedding night and every night after together,

Until Aleiz was murdered right in front of Ajnas very eyes, just as she'd had to watch their father die.

He lay now, eyes wide, watching a figure above him. Violet hair, bright eyes.

"Dear One..." he rasped, reaching up with a blood soaked hand.

The figure of his wife, his first love, glared down at him and wiped a ruby hilted knife on the hem of her gown.

"*You failed me, Starlight*," he heard her say, distant, echoing from a place beyond time. "*You said you would see my vision through*."

He tried to protest. Reach for her. All that came out was choking glob of blood. He watched her stand above him, narrowed eyes heavy with disgust. As his vision went dark, he watched the love of his life turn her back on him and walk away.

And then,

Nothing more.

Crystal Clear

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Hordak stared at the body of his creator, his genetic brother, his God, his greatest enemy, his first love, his Emperor- expression unreadable. He'd once been so powerful, but as the life faded from his many eyes, flickering out one by one like many stars, Hordak couldn't help but feel a certain... pity. Gasping, his Emperor reached for his Empress as she stepped over his bloody body and walked towards the window.

He watched him writhe and weep, mouth opening and closing as words that would be heard by nobody fell into the dark of the beautiful Etherian night air. The tendrils on his head twitched and slithered uselessly as blood leaked from the gash in his neck like oil from a machine.

And at the end, that was how Hordak saw him. A machine, more metal than man now. Artificial. What ever soul he had possessed was gone now and when the light faded, when his body quit moving, when his parts ceased to function, Hordak saw a machine shutting down for the last time. Outdated, beyond repair.

Useless.

The tendrils on his head twitched one last time before curling close to his skull in a way that reminded Hordak of how that Etherian insect, spiders, would roll up into a tangle of legs when they died. He couldn't look away for what felt like ages. Could have *been* ages for all he cared. The Emperor of the known universe was dead and it only just hit him what that truly meant.

Nothing would ever be the same.

The Universe would fall into complete chaos. Hordak expected this, of course, but it had been an after thought, a footnote.

Freeing Entrapta had been his one goal for so long that now that it was done, the enormity of the task ahead weighed like the collapsing empire around him.

"Hordak."

He finally looked up. Silhouetted against one of the windows, framed by one of Etherias silver moons, the love of his life stood, tall and beautiful. She was different now. Older. Damaged. Scars of the body were fixable, but the scars on the heart were forever. Her face in the faint glow of night seemed tired, expression somewhere between releived and tired and Hordak wondered if somewhere in the dark corners of her soul, she held a shameful greif for the late Emperor.

His gaze fell to the knife still held loosely in trembling fingers- the only part of her that did not radiate calm confidence. Blood slid down the blade, but stopped dripping. Her fingers were coated, sticky and stained and forever those of a killer now. No matter. His were stained with the same sins. He would hold her murderous hand for the rest of eternity, kiss her blood-soaked knuckles, caress her wicked fingers until they grew knobby and wrinkled.

He imagined it. Growing together through the years, the endless spinning of the Universe. Her pretty face, the lines so faint now around her mouth- proof that, despite everything, she was still herself, that she had found the courage to smile. Hordak wanted to push the years into those lines until they grew deep. He wanted to see the valleys of joy on her face at the end of their lives. He wanted the years to mark their joy in wrinkles so deep, the scars would look like snow on the hillside and glitter in the sunlight.

He wanted to see her smile again. *Really* smile.

"Entrapta."

He muttered her name like a punctuation mark at the end of a story. The first and final word to it all. He hadn't lived before her

and he would cease to be when she was gone. She was the sun, moon and stars. The end and beginning. Every breath, every thought, every beat of his hearts, murmured her name like a lullaby.

Only an instant passed between them, a blink of the universe, but in the moment between then and now, between separation and becoming whole, between death and life, the entirety of existence passed between them.

And then they met again in the middle of time and space.

Hordak wrapped her in his arms, holding tighter than he's ever done in his life, holding together, holding fast and holding it all in. In his embrace, she trembled like a falling star. The knife clattered to the sleek tile and slid somewhere out of sight. Her arms came up around his narrow waist and she buried her head in his hard sternum.

The silence that fell was a comfortable one, an *earned* silence. For years, the silence of isolation, of banishment had been overwhelming, but now, he craved the simple beauty of this tiny world. It's quiet calm soothed his soul. He was home here, with her.

"You smell like Brightmoon," she sniffled.

Hordak couldn't contain a chuckle. After all this time, that was not quite what he had expected her to say when they were finally free.

"Is it a bad thing?" He asked, then pressed a soft kiss to the top of her head.

"Not at all," she answered, "I missed this. But I think I miss the lab more."

The lab. It had been destroyed some time ago. Hordak hadn't mourned it before, but now he couldn't resist thinking of their happiest days. Back when dealing with a few Princesses was the

greatest annoyance. Back when he was content to fiddle around with what ever wild idea his Princess could conjure. If things hadn't progressed the way they did, he never would have opened the portal. They would be there still, working side by side, making no real progress, but happy in their work regardless. Happy with each other.

"Let's build a new one," he whispered against her short hair. "Together."

Entrapta hummed in agreement.

"You, me, and our son," she murmured and Hordak couldn't contain a smirk.

His son. Their son. It didn't matter to him if Prime was the one to sire the boy or not. He was certain he could find out, take tests and confirm, but it was a useless gesture. Entrapta was the child's mother and that was enough reason to call the boy 'son'. Enough reason to love him.

"We should go to him," Hordak whispered, reluctant to separate from her warmth. He could live out the heat death of the universe in her embrace, truly, but she pulled away first and as she did, she smiled like the sun.

Hordak knew that in a few million years or so, the sun would explode and Etheria and everything on it would be gone. Their lives, their love, would be nothing but space dust, but right now, in the heat of Entraptas smile, in the path of the Galaxys future destruction, he was content. At long last.

The little Prince streched and cooed in his cradle, entirely unaware of the chaos around him. The moment the Emperor died was the moment the Universe was set at his feet. Barely a month old and he was the most powerful being in the Universe.

Or he would be, if Princess Beck was not standing over his cradle.

Her eyes glowed with something like steel, something like the jewels her mother used to wear. Hard and sharp. Her long nails slid up the infants stomach, touching light as air.

"Most powerful being in the Galaxy," she snorted in amusement, "but you don't belong here."

The child opened his eyes sleepily as Beck pressed a finger into the hand of her youngest brother. Reflexively, the boy grasped it and held it firm. The woman sighed, then reached down and pulled the boy from his cradle.

"You know," Tallulah mused behind her, "you looked just like that when you were a baby."

Beck smirked down at the squirming infant.

"So I was cute then," she chuckled. "You think people will buy it? That the Prince was killed along with the Emperor and Empress?"

Tallulah tilted her head slightly as if considering this. Then she shrugged.

"I don't think it will matter much," she replied at last, "not with the new Empress on the throne. You were born for this, Beck."

The Princess nodded slowly and pressed a kiss to the forehead of the baby.

"When you get back," Tallulah said as Beck handed the child over to her, "make sure you keep an eye on Terr. She won't understand."

Her little sister, her favorite little sibling- of course she wouldn't understand. Beck knew this. The girl adored her Father, loved him. She'd always been one of his favorites. He said Beck was his pride, but Terr? Terr was his *joy*. The loss would be hard for her, but that was what siblings were for. And when she took the throne, she would have Terr close by because they needed each

other now. All of them. The children and the spouses of the Emperor. Because that was what family did.

A new Empire was coming and the Universe would simply have to adjust.

Ajna stood tall next to Queen Glimmer. The new Empress had declared herself and all that was left to do was wait. The way she saw things, there were two ways this could go.

Beck could retaliate, kill them all, destroy Ehtheria to make an example. Or she could leave the planet in peace, usher in a new era. That was the unfortunate thing about a new ruler. One never truly knew what they would become. But Ajna had been a wife to the Emperor for a long time. She'd known her stepdaughter to be a wise woman, kind, even. She was banking on this when she reached out to her.

"So. It's over." Queen Glimmer whispered, staring out the window at Primes ship hanging in the sky like an oppressive bird of prey. "No matter what I do now, the fighting is through."

"You sound terrified," Ajna noted with amusement.

"I am," the Queen admitted with a wry smile, "I've been at war my entire life. If we survive this, I have no idea what I'm going to do."

Suddenly she laughed.
"I'm almost more afraid of surviving than dying. Isn't that stupid?"

Ajna shook her head stiffly, watching the early morning light slip along the distant coastline. Prime had been dead for only six hours now, but the Universe was already aware. Chaos had taken hold and worlds all over lived in uncertainty. But, for as much as Ajna didn't know, one thing was absolutely certain.

She was ready to go home.

"Surviving isn't the hardest part," Ajna muttered. "The hardest part is living *with* your survival."

Glimmer glanced at the other Queen next to her and smiled, but before she could say anything, the ship overhead began to turn. As it did, Glimmer considered her fear and realized that the only thing she had to regret now, was not living while she had the chance. Somewhere on the other side of the door, Bow was waiting.

She turned as if to run to him, but just then the ship glowed a faint green; then it was gone.

And two Queens watched the sunrise sweep the land as they both decided to live again.

Wedded bliss on Etheria was different for everone.

Some had grand, extravagant affairs, like the marriage of Queen Glimmer and Bow. Some were wild, spontaneous bursts of love, like the marriage of Catra and Adora.

But for Entrapta and Hordak, theirs was quiet, calm, humble.

They married in a small, quick ceremony at Dryl. The day after Primes demise, Tallulah handed their son to them and left on the Emperial ship. Not without a kiss to both of them and well wishes, of course. Entrapta held no dreams of meeting her again, much as she wished they could. The thing about being in the public eye of the Universe, was that it was quite difficult to fake your death and keep living.

Once she had dreamed of a Universe to explore, but now she was content. Well, content *enough*, at least. She would forever see the stars and wonder what she may not have seen yet, wonder what wild new worlds she may be missing, what scientific discoveries

would never be hers. And occasionally she would miss...
Him.

It was a source of endless guilt. With Hordak at her side, the man she'd chosen, loved enough to kill for, loved enough to conceive a child with, she *knew* she was happy. And still, every once in a while. She would think of her late husband and feel pain. He'd had moments, instants where Entrapta thought she could see a light in him. Moments where she loved him.

Hordak, to his credit, was patient, understanding. He'd loved him too, for all the terrible things he did, it was a bond that was difficult to shake. The Emperors abuse left scars on them both and recovery was a monumental task.

The only thing to come out of this whole ordeal that was good was-

"*Zed!*"

Hordak called after the laughing five year old boy as he rushed through the halls on the back of Emily.

"Get off the bot! You're going to fall and hurt yourself!"

A laugh from above and a peck on his cheek silenced his scolding for the moment.

"Relax, my love. Hes just having fun," Entrapta snorted as she hung by her hair. It had never grown back as long or as strong, but she didn't complain. It was good enough to assist in her work and that was all she needed.

Hordak huffed as she flipped her welding mask back over her face and turned her attention back to the wiring up above. His hands found his hips as sparks began to fly from the spot she was welding.

"And you shouldn't be up there," He shouted over the sizzling soldering iron, "not in your condition!"

Entrapta lifted her welding mask with a click of her tongue.

"I'm not helpless," she puffed, unable to hide her amusement, "I'm just pregnant."

"Yes!" Hordak snarled, "and that is *precisely* why you should come down! Besides, I need you."

The Princess of Dryl sighed deeply and swooped down to solid ground in a blink.

"Fine. See? Feet on the ground. Now, what did you-"

Her words were cut off as her husband, the Lord of Dryl, father to her children and love of her life, swept her into a brief, tender kiss.

"*That*," he chuckled softly, "was what I needed you for.

A smile pulled at her lips and Hordak marveled at the way her skin crinkled at the corners of her eyes like little starbursts. Her mouth had already developed many lines over the past five years. Light forehead wrinkles from concentration, eyebrow lines from worry, but his favorite was *this*. The lines of joy that painted her face now. And every day they grew, deeper, permanent. Lines from laughter and love.

She grabbed the front of his tunic and pulled him back in for another soul stealing kiss.

Around the Universe, time moved on. People lived, people died. Alliances were made and broken. Empires rose and fell.

But in a Universe full of chaos and uncertainty, one thing remained, imperfect but no less beautiful.

They were LUVD.

And that was all they needed.

Chapter End Notes

And that's it!

Took me years to finally finish this.

In my original draft, the ending was rather bleak. Nobody was happy. Everyone suffered. And at the time that I started this, that was where my mind was. Maybe that's why I struggled to make myself finish this.

In the end, though, I decided to change course. I'm in a much better place in my life and I think a happy ending, while maybe not always perfect, fits the narrative much better.

Nothing is ever perfect and trauma leaves scars, but life will go on if you let it.

Anyway, thank you all for reading and I especially want to thank those that have been on this journey with me from the beginning, patiently waiting for the new chapters. When it was hard to motivate myself, you helped me get through.

I hope you enjoyed. Be well.

End Notes

Season 4 hurt bad. I deal with things best by writing the worst case scenario.

Am I going to put trigger warnings before every chapter?

As much as I can. Remind me in the comments if I forget. As much as I hate to admit it, I am actually human. Mistakes will almost certainly be made, but I'll do my best. I'm not out here to be edgy and intentionally trigger someone.
Be mindful.

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!